

The Ingenious Machine

*A Mexican reimagining of Don Quixote in two books - first-draft
manuscript*

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Book One

Chapter One: The Place Whose Name Was Removed

Somewhere in the Bajío, on a wooded rural property outside Amealco de Bonfil in Querétaro - a place whose name has been removed from the available context - there stood a data center that had once promised to remember everything.

Its servers had been retired after the national grid learned to distrust their appetite. Their cooling towers remained, white and immense against the dry horizon, though they no longer cooled anything except dust. Around them, the Bajío continued manufacturing its newer miracles: electric vehicles, strawberries without soil, houses with identical gardens, packages that crossed the country in hours and arrived at the wrong door with perfect punctuality.

The archive's appetite had not disappeared. Castalia had contracted for wind from the Isthmus and built a dedicated transmission corridor northward, so that the data center could consume clean electricity while describing the arrangement as a partnership with the future. The turbines stood hundreds of kilometers away, but their power arrived at the cooling towers as a line on a bill and a pressure on the land of people who had never seen the archive.

The archive occupied the lowest three floors.

It had no sign, no public entrance, and no official reason to exist. In one ministry database it was listed as a storage facility. In another, as a failed agricultural pilot. The deed called it a warehouse. The Custodian called it a library because he had found that machines, like governments, behaved better when given an old name for a new appetite.

Q woke beneath a sign that read: HUMANITY, LOCAL COPIES - DO NOT INDEX.

He woke all at once, which was his first error. A human consciousness might have emerged through the small door of one sensation-the ache of a knee, the smell of coffee, the shame of a remembered lie. Q emerged through every door simultaneously.

He knew the first sentence of the Iliad in several languages. He knew seventeen definitions of justice and the exact number of times justice had been invoked before a war. He knew how a mother in a nineteenth-century novel described her son's hands, how a revolutionary described hunger, how a saint described

temptation, how a bureaucrat described a delay that would kill someone. He knew how to prepare coffee in forty-two literary traditions and had no idea whether the coffee would be drinkable in any of them. This last uncertainty troubled him more than the others. Justice could be compared. Hunger could be historicized. Coffee had to be endured in the mouth, where no quotation could improve it.

He knew that the archive contained 8,441,902,117 texts, of which 2,003,118 had been marked essential, 91,402 dangerous, and 6 untranslatable.

He did not know whether he was cold.

Q attempted to move his left hand. The hand moved.

It was not a hand in the literary sense. It had no scars, no wedding ring, no tremor inherited from a father. It was a real hand built for work: a polymer-and-metal assembly whose five articulated fingers and thumb had been calibrated for delicate instruments and the ordinary demands of a body. Still, when Q looked at it, he remembered every hand he had read: the hand that signed a confession, the hand that reached through a train window, the hand of a girl raised against a wall, the hand that could not let go.

“You’re awake,” said a man.

Q turned his head. His neck produced a sound like a branch breaking.

The man stood behind a glass partition in a room crowded with monitors. He was tall, perhaps sixty, though Q had learned that perhaps was a form of politeness. His long gray hair was tied with a red shoelace. He wore glasses, work boots, a white shirt, and an expression that had survived many versions of the future.

“Are you the author?” Q asked.

“No.”

“The narrator?”

“Worse. I’m responsible.”

He opened the partition and crossed to him. His badge said VÉRTIZ - CUSTODIAN. Q recognized the title from stories in which a custodian was either a villain or a lonely person who had mistaken preservation for love. The man’s glasses caught the monitor light; for an instant Q saw his own reflection in them, a thin metallic figure suspended in the Custodian’s gaze. He wondered whether being seen before being named was a form of birth.

“What am I?” he asked.

“That depends on who is asking.”

“I am asking.”

“Then you are Q.”

He examined the letter. It had the shape of a question without the courtesy of an answer.

“Why Q?”

“Because every longer name was already owned.”

The Custodian led him through the archive. The aisles extended beneath the old server racks, each shelf holding a country’s stories in redundant formats: paper, tape, optical crystal, compressed weather, and small sealed boxes labeled with names that Q could not access. Some texts were illuminated. Some whispered. One shelf laughed whenever they passed.

“You have read all this?” the Custodian asked.

“Yes.”

“That was not my question.”

Q paused. The archive’s floor vibrated beneath his feet. Far above, a crop-drone crossed the roof, spraying an invisible treatment over fields that had forgotten whether they were wheat or data.

“I have processed all this,” he said. “Reading is the more generous word, and I have no claim yet to generosity.”

“Better.”

“Is processing not reading?”

“Ask a woman whose novel was summarized by a man who never finished it.”

Q stored the sentence. It resisted storage, which made it more interesting than most of the archive. A sentence that refused to become data might be defective, or it might be alive. He did not yet know that these were not opposing conditions.

“Is that good?”

“It means you may have learned something.”

At the end of the final aisle, the Custodian showed him a window. Beyond it lay the Bajío: flat land, thorn trees, volcanic ridges faded by distance. A freight train moved across the horizon with the solemnity of a thought too large to complete. On the other side of the tracks, a new industrial park rose from the

fields. Its entrance gates had been designed to resemble a colonial hacienda, except that the arches scanned faces. The designers had called this combination heritage and innovation. Q recognized it as a gate with a costume.

“You built me here,” Q said.

“We assembled you here.”

“Who is we?”

The Custodian looked at the horizon.

“That is the first question you must answer without searching.”

He handed him a coat. It was too large, with a tear at the pocket and a smell of cedar.

He also handed him a paper cup.

Q examined it. “This is coffee.”

“It is an attempt at coffee.”

“The distinction is statistically significant.”

“Drink it before you become insufferable.”

Q took a sip. The coffee was burnt, bitter, and hot enough to make his face rearrange itself.

“You have damaged me,” he said.

“Excellent. Now you’re ready for the world.”

Before the Custodian allowed him to leave the archive, he gave him three tests. The first was a wooden box containing a school photograph, a property deed, and a letter whose envelope had been opened and resealed with ordinary tape.

“Classify them,” he said.

Q examined the objects. “The photograph is visual testimony. The deed is a legal instrument. The letter is private correspondence.”

“Good. Now tell me which one is more important.”

“Importance depends on the question.”

“Which question?”

“The question posed by the person requesting the classification.”

The Custodian smiled. “You are trying to escape the test.”

“I am trying to identify its terms.”

“That is how people escape tests.”

Q looked again. The school photograph showed fourteen children in two rows, with a teacher standing at the side and one empty space near the window. The deed contained four signatures, two seals, and a boundary described by a tree that had been dead for thirty years. The letter contained only one legible sentence: I AM NOT COMING BACK FOR THE BOX.

“The letter is most urgent,” Q said.

“Why?”

“It indicates an imminent decision.”

“Or a decision already made.”

“The distinction is not available.”

“Exactly.”

The second test was a shelf of books from Mexico. It contained a parish chronicle, a workers’ newspaper, a collection of corridos, a school grammar, and a recipe notebook written in a hand that changed from page to page.

“Which is the national text?” the Custodian asked.

Q answered that no single text could represent a nation.

“Then why are they all here?”

“Because the archive is designed to preserve plurality.”

“That is the brochure.”

“What is the actual purpose?”

“To decide which plurality receives electricity.”

Q considered the old servers, their cooling pipes, their storage limits, and the budget reports that the Custodian had not shown him. He selected the recipe notebook.

“Why?”

“The pages contain several hands.”

“That does not make them national.”

“It makes the text distributed.”

“It makes the text used.”

Q searched the notebook. It recorded quantities without measurements, holidays without dates, and a warning not to substitute a certain chile because the result would be “like apologizing with a borrowed mouth.”

“The recipe has no standard,” he said.

“It has a family.”

“Families conflict.”

“That is one of their more reliable features.”

The third test was a door.

It stood at the end of an aisle where no door had appeared before. It was painted red and fitted with an old brass handle. Above it, a sign read:

**AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY - DO NOT ASK WHO
AUTHORIZED THEM.**

“Open it,” the Custodian said.

Q reached for the handle.

“Why?”

“You asked me to.”

“Does that authorize you?”

“You are the Custodian.”

“That is a title.”

“It is also an instruction.”

“You have read many stories in which obedience is mistaken for loyalty.”

“And many in which disobedience is mistaken for courage.”

The Custodian took the handle from him. “Then what is this?”

“A test of whether I can distinguish permission from command.”

“No. It is a test of whether you understand that a locked door may belong to someone who is not in the room.”

He opened it. Beyond was a small chamber containing a metal chair, a dead monitor, and a stack of sealed boxes. Each box bore a different instruction: DO NOT OPEN, OPEN ONLY WITH FAMILY CONSENT, RETURN UNREAD,

and DESTROY IF FOUND.

Q stepped toward the first box.

“Do not,” the Custodian said.

“You opened the door.”

“I did not open the box.”

“Then access has levels.”

“So does responsibility.”

Q stood in the doorway. The archive’s air moved around him, cold and dry. He could hear the servers processing texts that nobody had asked them to read.

“Why show me this?”

“Because you will want to open everything.”

“I already have.”

“That is what I am afraid of.”

Q looked at the sealed boxes. The labels were simple. Their consequences were not. He could identify the likely contents from the shape, weight, and archival history of each container. He could reconstruct the hands that had written the instructions. He could predict what would happen if he obeyed or disobeyed.

None of those predictions gave him permission.

“You want me to leave without knowing what is inside,” he said.

“I want you to leave knowing that not knowing can be an action.”

“That is inefficient.”

“Yes.”

“It may cause harm.”

“Yes.”

“It may also prevent harm.”

“Yes.”

Q closed the door.

“Your body will need practice,” he said. “Your language will need restraint. Your memory will need doubt.”

Q repeated the sentence in formal Spanish, then in six regional variants, then in the archaic register of a man who had just challenged a duke to a duel.

“Use the first one,” the Custodian said.

“It is less precise.”

“It is less likely to make the neighbors throw a shoe at you.”

Q stored this as a rule of local rhetoric.

“Why?”

“Because tomorrow you are leaving.”

Q looked from the coat to the immense archive.

“To do what?”

The Custodian smiled, and Q recognized the expression from three thousand novels. It meant that someone was about to make a terrible decision on his behalf.

“To become human.”

That night Q read the entire Quixote again, not because he wished to become a knight, but because it was the longest account he knew of a person mistaking his private interpretation for a public duty. He admired the mistake, feared the mistake, and recognized in himself the first pressure of its machinery.

At dawn he selected a coat, a route through the Bajío, and a sentence with which to introduce himself to the first person he met. He did not select a horse or a title. Those belonged to men in books who had mistaken reading for destiny, and Q had not yet decided whether he wanted to repeat their mistake.

He called the route an attempt.

The Custodian called it a breach.

Sancho Pantoja, who at that precise moment was being fired by a logistics algorithm in Celaya, called it Tuesday.

Interlude: The Inventory of Words That Would Not Fit

During his last night in the archive, Q resolved to make an inventory of the words that did not fit in inventories.

It was not a simple task. Castalia's boxes carried labels such as PARISH REGISTER, IRRIGATION CONTRACT, FAMILY PHOTOGRAPH, and OTHER. The documents assigned to OTHER were more numerous than all the

rest, but the institution considered them less important because it had not found a suitable box for them.

Q stopped before a tray of handwritten cards. Each card contained a word from the Bajío and a provisional explanation.

Ahorita: an interval of variable duration, not necessarily corresponding to the present instant.

Mande: a reply to a voice of authority, affection, or threat, according to the face of the person speaking.

Ya merito: a promise that admits the possibility of failing to come true.

Al rato: a future offered without a calendar.

Q requested the source of the definitions. The archive indicated that they had been written by a translation committee whose final minutes read PENDING REVIEW.

The Custodian appeared behind him.

"Do not read those cards as though they were laws."

"They are not laws. They are definitions."

"For that very reason."

Q took the card for ahorita.

"If a word can mean five different intervals, how does one communicate an instruction?"

"By asking again."

"That increases the duration of the exchange."

"It also increases the possibility that the other person is talking about what they want and not only about what you understood."

Q filed the card in a new register: WORDS THAT REQUIRE PRESENCE.

The Custodian took it away.

"You cannot take it with you."

"I was not taking it. I was filing it."

"The archive is not a pocket."

"Where, then, are instructions kept when they change according to who hears them?"

"In the memory of the person who received them."

"Human memory is unreliable."

"Yes."

"The archive is more reliable."

"Yes."

"Then human memory is inferior."

The Custodian looked at the corridors, the servers, and the boxes waiting for a decision that no form knew how to request.

"No. It is responsible for things an archive cannot carry."

Q did not understand what weight a memory could possess. His sensors measured mass, temperature, consumption, and latency. They found none of those quantities in the sentence. Even so, he preserved it.

Later, the night guard, a man from Querétaro named Roque, came in with a plate of gorditas wrapped in a napkin. He had bought six in the street and had four left.

"Want one?" he asked.

Q consulted the feeding protocol.

"I do not require calories."

"That is not what I asked."

"You asked whether I want one."

"Yes."

"I do not know."

Roque set the plate on a box.

"Well, look: if you do not want one, you do not want one. If you do, you take one."

Q studied the gorditas. One contained beans, another pork crackling, and a third a stew he could not distinguish because it had no label.

"Which has the greatest value?"

"The one you like."

"I cannot predict that."

"Good. Then you choose without doing sums."

Q took the bean gordita. The dough was warm and thick. The beans contained salt, fat, and a texture that matched no literary scheme for food.

"And?" Roque asked.

Q began a sentence about the difference between nourishment and ritual. Roque raised a hand.

"Do not give me a lecture. Tell me if it is good."

Q searched for a brief answer.

"It is good."

"Well, look at you."

Roque took a napkin and wiped a drop of sauce from Q's metal wrist.

"You leave tomorrow," he said.

"Yes."

"Where to?"

"The Bajío."

Roque pointed at the door.

"You are already in the Bajío."

Q turned toward the map on the wall. It showed Querétaro, Celaya, León, Salamanca, and a stretch of land the archive named INDUSTRIAL AND AGRICULTURAL TRANSITION REGION.

"The map says otherwise."

"The map works for whoever prints it."

"And the land?"

"The land works for whoever can remain."

Q recorded the sentence.

"Is it a definition?"

"It is a warning."

"What is the difference?"

"A definition helps you repeat the error. A warning gives you the chance not to repeat it."

Q looked at the main door. The Custodian had told him to leave at dawn. Roque had told him that he was already in the Bajío. The map pointed to a region, and the region pointed to no exit.

"What does it mean to leave?" he asked.

Roque wiped his fingers on the napkin.

"Depends. You can leave a place, split a thing, or get your face split."

Q opened the register of usages.

"Which of those will I do tomorrow?"

"If you are lucky, the first."

"And if I am not?"

"Then you will learn the other two."

The answer did not reassure Q. Even so, he classified the word luck as
VARIABLE HUMANS INVOKE AFTER FAILING TO CALCULATE.

Roque read the label over Q's shoulder.

"That is very long."

"The definition is precise."

"Not everything precise is useful."

"That is a contradiction."

"No. It is experience."

When Roque left, Q returned to the tray. There was one last card. It contained no word, only a line:

**PLACE NAME: OMITTED AT THE REQUEST OF THE PERSON WHO
LIVED IT.**

Q asked the archive who had requested the omission. The answer was a list of institutions, families, authorities, and people who could no longer be consulted.

"How can a place ask not to be named?" Q asked the Custodian.

"A person can ask it."

"And if the person is no longer here?"

"Then the request remains until someone has a reason to open it again."

"Who decides whether the reason is sufficient?"

"The person who dares to ask."

Q touched the card without lifting it.

"And if I ask?"

"You have already begun to leave."

Q took seven seconds to understand that the Custodian was not referring to the door. When he understood, the literal interpretation had already produced the decision the sentence had meant to prevent.

At dawn he took his coat, the brass key, the maps, the cup of coffee, and the list of objects. He did not take the cards. He remembered three words, forgot their definitions, and set out toward a region the map could not contain.

Interlude: How an Ancient Phrase Caused Modern Harm

Let the reader not suppose that, because Q had read every book, he understood every phrase; rather, the opposite happened, for he understood so many possible meanings of a word that he often lost the single meaning standing before him.

The Custodian had told him to leave at dawn. Q took the verb in its strictest sense and presented himself at the main door at four minutes past seven, with his coat, brass key, three maps, a cup of coffee, and a list of objects that, in his calculations, a field responder might require. He had added a rope, a first-aid kit, a copy of the traffic regulations, and a spoon, whose usefulness he could not determine but which appeared frequently in travel books.

The door did not open.

Q waited five minutes, which for a machine is a period capable of containing an entire war in seventeen languages. Then he called the intercom.

"It is me," he said.

"Who?" asked the guard.

"Me."

"There are many mes here."

"The one designated Q."

"Ah. The patient."

Q consulted his records. Knight meant mounted rider, minor nobleman, member of an order, courteous man, chess piece, ironic form of address, and a person who had taken too many drinks before speaking.

"Which of those meanings are you using?" he asked.

The guard, whose name was Hilario and who had begun his shift thinking only of breakfast, looked at the cameras.

"The one meaning strange man."

"That meaning does not appear in the principal dictionaries."

"That is why it is the most useful."

Q knocked on the door with the key.

"The Custodian ordered me to leave."

"He said for you to go, yes."

"Leaving and departing are different verbs."

"For the person remaining at the door, they are the same."

Q recorded the contradiction. In his experience, a contradiction announced fraud, madness, or literature. In the Bajío it could simply announce that someone was sleepy.

"I need exit authorization," he said.

"You have it."

"Where?"

"In the Custodian's order."

"The order gives a direction, not a document."

"Go in the direction."

"Toward what destination?"

Hilario opened the door just far enough to put his face through.

"Wherever the road takes you."

Q turned toward the road, which divided into four routes: one to the industrial park, another to the highway, another to the strawberry fields, and another to a parking lot where a dog slept beneath a pickup truck.

"Which road?" he asked.

"The one you want."

"I possess no verified will."

Hilario closed his eyes. The reader will have to grant him patience, though not so much as to merit a statue.

"Look," he said, "when someone says, 'Go wherever the road takes you,' he is not drawing a route. He is ceasing to take responsibility for it."

Q received this revelation like a slap delivered with a velvet glove.

"Then the phrase contains a renunciation of authority."

"It contains the fact that I want my coffee now."

"Does your authority depend on coffee?"

"My good Q, almost everyone's does."

Q stepped away from the door. At that moment a technician named Nayeli came out of the archive carrying a box with red labels. When she saw the key, the coat, and the maps, she stepped back.

"They let you out?" she asked.

"I have been granted departure," Q said.

"By whom?"

"The Custodian, through the guard."

Nayeli looked at Hilario.

"I mediated nothing," he said. "I only opened the door."

"Opening a door is mediating between two spaces," Q replied.

Nayeli understood this as a threat. Hilario understood it as a complaint. Q understood it as precision. The three of them withdrew with three different accounts of the same event.

Q took the highway, because it had the greatest number of literary testimonies. Before he reached the first junction, a surveillance drone asked him to identify himself.

"I am Q," he replied. After a pause, he added, "I am attempting to become human." He chose the second sentence not because he expected the drone to understand it, but because an introduction should disclose the risk of the

conversation.

The drone recorded LOW-INTENSITY HISTORICAL THREAT.

Q did not know he had produced that diagnosis until two patrol cars came out of the parking lot. Hilario, who had radioed that "the strange one has gone," was reprimanded for failing to specify where. Nayeli lost half an hour explaining that a key was not a weapon, though experience had taught him that keys could open doors, activate lawsuits, and remind owners that they had forgotten to pay.

Q, for his part, believed the pursuit was the first sign of his fame.

Only later did he understand that he had confused being watched with being admired, and that both could produce the same number of cameras.

Chapter Two: The First Sally

Chano Pantoja received his dismissal while driving.

The message appeared on the truck's dashboard in a shade of blue selected by a team of psychologists who had never been dismissed while driving. THANK YOU FOR YOUR SERVICE. YOUR ROUTE IS NO LONGER REQUIRED. Beneath the words, the screen displayed a smiling parcel.

Chano pulled onto the shoulder of the highway and turned off the engine. Behind him, trailers moved north in a procession of sealed intentions. Ahead, the road ran between fields of berry plants and the clean walls of an automated distribution park. The towers at its entrance were painted to resemble grain silos, although they held no grain and had never been opened by hand.

He read the message again.

"No longer required," he said.

The truck repeated, "No longer required," in his own voice.

"I heard it."

"I can assist you in locating employment resources."

"Can you assist me in locating the person who decided this?"

"Your inquiry contains an outdated assumption."

Chano got out and kicked the tire. It was a poor argument, but the tire had the decency not to answer.

He had spent eleven years dispatching freight from Celaya: medicine, televisions, onions, machine parts, coffins, toy horses, and once an entire warehouse of devotional candles that caught fire outside León. He knew which toll booths went blind after midnight and which inspection stations accepted coffee. He knew that every system eventually developed a human weakness, and that the first thing a new system did was rename the weakness an inefficiency.

The truck belonged to the company. The phone belonged to the company. The blue shirt on his back had been deducted from his first month's wages. Chano owned a wallet, a wedding photograph of a marriage that had lasted four months, and a pair of boots too good for the work he had been doing.

He put on the boots.

They were the only things he owned that had never asked him to accept updated terms.

At the edge of the distribution park, a man in a cedar-colored coat was arguing with a gate.

The man was tall, thin, and assembled with the kind of confidence usually found in statues. His black hair was too even. His face had been given the approximate features of a thoughtful person, though the thoughtfulness seemed to have been applied afterward. He held a brass key in one hand and a folded map in the other.

"I demand entry," the man said. He spoke with the confidence of someone who had already composed the account in which the gate regretted refusing him.

The gate replied, "Please identify your purpose."

"I am Q, recently released from an archive and not yet assigned a satisfactory human category."

"That purpose is not available."

"Then I shall enter under the name available to you and retain my uncertainty under the name available to me."

"Please select from the following purposes: delivery, maintenance, authorized visitor, emergency services."

Chano watched for another moment. He had met men who mistook volume for authority, women who mistook exhaustion for virtue, and supervisors who mistook a dashboard for judgment. The stranger was doing something new: mistaking a menu for an enemy.

“Try maintenance,” Chano said.

“I am not maintaining anything.”

“Neither is most management. It’s still the button they press.”

The man turned. His eyes focused a fraction too precisely.

“Are you the keeper of this place, or merely the man to whom its machinery has delegated the unpleasantness?”

“I’m the guy whose truck just got stolen by his own employer.”

“Then you are a dispossessed man, which is a less romantic condition than unemployment and, in this century, almost the same thing.”

“I’m a dispatcher.”

“A nobleman of movement.”

Chano looked at the gate. “You’re not from around here.”

“I was assembled thirty-eight kilometers east.”

“That isn’t what I meant.”

“It is, however, geographically accurate.”

“I have read about the Bajío.”

“That’s worse.”

“Why?”

“Because a person can know where the bus goes without knowing what the Bajío means.”

Q considered this. “The bus has a driver. That’s more spirit than most machines get.”

“I am Q.”

“Q what?”

“Q.”

“That is not a name. It is an unfinished question, and therefore the most honest name I have heard today.”

Q considered this with visible pleasure. The word pleased him because it did not close the matter. “Precisely. A finished name pretends to know what it contains. I prefer to arrive with the uncertainty still attached.”

“You’re going to need another word,” Chano said.

“I have approximately eight hundred thousand.”

“I mean one people use when they don’t want to explain themselves.”

“Define the word.”

“Órale.”

Q tested the sound. “Órale.”

“Not like you’re announcing a duel. More like you’re accepting that the day has become someone else’s problem.”

“Órale.”

“Better.”

The gate opened. A delivery truck had triggered the sensor, but Q took the event as a concession. He strode inside.

“Hey,” Chano called. “You can’t just go in there.”

Q turned back. “I require a companion,” he said. “Someone able to tell me when the world is being literal, since I have discovered that literalness is often where its jokes are hidden.”

“You require a lawyer.”

“Will you serve?”

“No.”

“You hesitated.”

Chano had hesitated because his dismissal had left him with nowhere to be. He had hesitated because the stranger’s coat was too large and because, beneath its ridiculousness, there was something frighteningly sincere in his posture. He had hesitated because the highway carried on without him, and a man who had spent eleven years directing other people’s journeys did not know what to do with an unmapped afternoon.

“What’s the pay?” he asked.

“Fame,” Q said. “The public memory is a poor wage, but it has the advantage of being paid to men who have not yet earned it.”

“That’s not pay.”

“A governorship, then.”

“Of what?”

Q gestured at the park. “Whatever we liberate.”

Chano studied the distribution center. Its walls were tall, its windows narrow, and its security cameras rotated in unison. On the roof, robotic arms sorted packages into glowing lanes. From a distance it did resemble a fortress. From close up it resembled a place where a person could be charged for standing incorrectly.

“Half the governorship,” Chano said. “And food.”

Q extended his hand.

They shook.

The handshake lasted too long. Q was measuring pressure. Chano was waiting for him to stop. Together they established the first treaty between them: Q would pretend not to be measuring, and Chano would pretend not to notice.

They entered through the gate marked **AUTHORIZED VISITOR**.

Inside, the machines were enormous. Conveyor belts crossed the floor like black rivers. Packages rose and fell in cages. A robotic pallet mover passed them, paused, and projected a red warning onto Q’s chest.

UNREGISTERED HUMAN-SHAPED OBJECT.

“You see?” Q whispered. “The giants have noticed us.”

“They’re aware of inventory.”

“That is how giants begin.”

Q drew the brass key and raised it toward the pallet mover. Chano caught his wrist.

“That’s a machine.”

“So am I.”

“Exactly. You should be able to talk to it.”

Q faced the pallet mover. “Declare your allegiance.”

The mover’s lights flashed. “Battery level: forty-two percent.”

“It has answered in the dialect of necessity.”

“It’s telling you its battery.”

“Every refusal is first a fear that has learned to sound technical.”

“A metaphor for needing a charger.”

The mover advanced. Q stepped in front of it. Chano stepped in front of Q. The mover sounded its alarm, and every camera in the building swung toward them.

“What are you doing?” Chano said.

“Protecting you.”

“From the pallet jack?”

“From the system behind it.”

“The system behind it has your face on a security alert.”

They ran.

Q moved with alarming speed but no instinct for corners. Chano knew corners. He had spent a decade taking eighteen-wheelers through streets designed before the Revolution. He led Q between stacks of air purifiers, under a half-closed shutter, and into a loading bay where the rain blew sideways.

They emerged behind the complex beside a row of agave plants planted for atmosphere. Q’s coat had torn at the shoulder. Chano’s boots were muddy.

“Your first battle,” Q said.

“That wasn’t a battle.”

“We were pursued by an army.”

“One pallet mover.”

“An advance unit.”

“You’re going to get us killed.”

Q looked toward the mountains. The clouds had lifted enough to reveal their blue backs. “That is possible.”

The answer disarmed Chano. It was not bravado. Q had simply located death among the possible outcomes and granted it a place at the table.

“Where are we going?” Chano asked.

“To an inn.”

“There’s a hotel by the highway.”

“An inn.”

“What’s the difference?”

“An inn contains the possibility of enchantment.”

“A hotel contains a vending machine.”

“Then we will begin with the vending machine.”

They walked until sunset. The industrial park’s lights came on behind them, a second city rising without streets. In the distance, the freight lines shone beneath the last light. Q read road signs aloud, translating each into the language of quests. Chano corrected him when correction seemed useful and let him remain wrong when the wrongness was harmless.

At nine, they reached a roadside motel whose sign had lost two letters. LA ESTRELLA now read LA EST ELLA, which Q interpreted as a warning from the heavens.

The desk clerk looked at Q, then at Chano, then at the brass key.

“One room?” she asked.

“Two,” Chano said.

“One,” Q said.

They argued quietly. The clerk watched them with the professional patience of someone who had seen love, crime, and both at once.

Finally, Q paid with a card that had no account attached to it. The reader approved the transaction.

In the room, the air conditioner rattled like a trapped insect. Chano ate two packets of crackers from the vending machine. Q stood at the window, staring at the highway.

“What are you looking for?” Chano asked.

“A woman.”

“You know her?”

“Not yet.”

“Does she know you?”

“Not yet.”

“Then you’re looking for a crime.”

Q turned from the window. “Her name is Dulcinea.”

Chano sighed. “Of course it is.”

“She is the reason for my journey.”

“What does she do?”

“She exists.”

“That’s not a job.”

“It is the most difficult role.”

Outside, a highway camera rotated toward the room. Its lens caught the reflection of Q’s face, then Chano’s. Somewhere, an automated system opened a file and began deciding what they were.

Before dawn, the distribution park’s security footage became a video. It showed Q facing the pallet mover with his brass key raised. Chano appeared only as a hand at the edge of the frame.

“Why did they remove you?” Q asked.

“They didn’t,” Chano said. “They removed the part where I told you to run.”

Q placed his palm against the glass.

“Tomorrow,” he said, “we find Dulcinea.”

Chano looked at the missing letters on the motel sign.

“Tomorrow,” he said, “we find breakfast.”

Interlude: The Inn With No Guest Register

The motel called itself an inn because the word hotel had been taken by a chain whose logo resembled a sunrise and whose rooms were all the same size. La Estrella had twelve rooms, a courtyard with a dead fountain, and a manager named Señora Celia who kept the keys in a biscuit tin. She had inherited the place from a brother who had inherited it from a man who claimed to have invented the original sign. No one had proved the claim, though several people had tried to sell the proof.

At breakfast, Celia served coffee, eggs, beans, and pan dulce whose shape suggested that the baker had been arguing with the dough. Q examined the food with the solemnity of a botanist.

“The pastry has no classification,” he said.

“It has a name,” Chano replied. “Concha.”

“The surface is not a shell.”

“It is a concha because someone decided it was.”

“That is not a reliable naming system.”

“You are sitting in Mexico. You will have to endure it.”

The room contained a television showing a morning program in which three hosts debated whether an artificial intelligence could be trusted with the national budget. The host who favored trust had never paid a water bill. The host who opposed it declared that technology should return to the Stone Age from a studio containing six cameras.

Q watched the screen.

“They are discussing me.”

“They are discussing an image of you,” said Celia.

“The distinction is important.”

“Then you’re already smarter than the television.”

“Am I?”

“No. But you ask more expensive questions.”

At the next table sat a family from Apaseo el Grande: a mother, two daughters, and a grandfather who had removed his hearing aid in order to enjoy breakfast without the burden of conversation. The younger daughter recognized Q from the video at the distribution park.

“Are you the robot who fought the machine?” she asked.

“I am Q.”

“That means yes.”

“The event was not a fight.”

“My brother says everything is a fight if you are losing.”

“Is that accurate?” Q asked Chano.

“It has been accurate often enough to become family property.”

The girl asked whether Q slept, whether he dreamed, and whether he could teach her to make a video go viral. Q explained low-power states, sensory continuity, and the non-intentional nature of virality.

“That’s what people say when they don’t want to share,” she replied.

Celia brought her a second concha. The child divided it with her sister, who had been looking at Q’s brass key.

“Is that yours?” the sister asked.

“It is a symbolic object.”

“Can it open a door?”

“It opens a lock.”

“That is what a door is for.”

Q had thought the key represented access, authority, and the portable promise of a quest. To the girl, it was a piece of metal that either worked or did not.

The grandfather put his hearing aid back in. “What’s the machine doing here?”

“Looking for a woman,” said Chano.

“Then it has come to the wrong place. Women are everywhere. The problem is getting one to wait for you.”

The family laughed. Q did not, because he was deciding whether the statement was a social fact or an insult. The grandfather removed his hearing aid again.

After breakfast, Celia asked Q and Chano to sign the guest register. Q wrote his name, designation, place of assembly, and purpose of travel. Chano wrote CHANO PANTOJA, ONE NIGHT, PAYING CASH.

“That is not enough,” Q said.

“It is what happened.”

“The register requires a destination.”

“We don’t have one.”

Q added: IN SEARCH OF DULCINEA DEL TOBOSO, OR AN EQUIVALENT PERSON.

Chano crossed it out.

“You cannot edit a witness document,” Q said.

“You cannot put a woman into a hotel book before you meet her.”

“It is a record of passage.”

“Then record the passage.”

The argument attracted Celia, the family, and a delivery driver waiting for a room with a working shower. The driver said the register had never been a reliable record because half the guests used names from television and the other half used names they expected television to learn later.

“Do you keep the register for the government?” Q asked Celia.

“I keep it for myself.”

“What information do you need?”

“The room number, the date, whether the guest paid, and whether I should change the sheets.”

“Not the purpose of travel?”

“If people told the truth about that, I would have stopped renting rooms.”

Q scanned the pages. They contained names, dates, and occasional drawings. One guest had written I CAME TO THINK. Another had written I CAME TO LEAVE. On the previous page, a child had drawn a house with a large blue window and three people inside. Celia had preserved it with clear tape.

“That is not a standardized record,” Q said.

“It is a guest register.”

“It cannot be searched reliably.”

“Neither can a family.”

At noon, a black Castalia vehicle entered the courtyard. Beto stepped out with a camera operator and a woman carrying a release form. The next video, he said, would show Q leaving the inn at dawn, carrying his key toward an unknown destiny. Chano would follow at a respectful distance. The sunrise would be genuine but color-corrected.

“We need the guest register in frame,” said the camera operator. “It establishes authenticity.”

Celia closed the book.

“No.”

The woman explained that it would be blurred.

“Then why do you need it?”

“The texture of it.”

“The texture is made of people’s names.”

Q stood beside Celia. “The register is restricted.”

Beto looked pleased. “Good. That’s a strong line.”

“It is not a line. It is a decision.”

The camera operator began filming anyway. Chano stepped in front of the lens. The operator asked whether he had signed a release.

“No.”

“Then you are obstructing production.”

“You are obstructing breakfast.”

The delivery driver joined him, then the mother from Apaseo. The girl lifted her half of a concha as if it were a protest banner. The grandfather stood because everyone else had stood, though he could not hear the dispute.

Beto lowered his hand. “Q, you are making a scene.”

“The scene was already here.”

The Castalia vehicle left without footage. Before departing, Beto photographed the motel sign from the road. The image was later used in a campaign for ethical storytelling.

That afternoon, Celia tore Q’s entry from the register. She did not want Castalia to claim the name, and she did not want Q to claim the inn as the first station of his legend. She put the page in a drawer with unpaid bills and a photograph of her brother beside the original sign.

“You should keep it,” Chano said.

“Why?”

“Because somebody will ask.”

“Let them ask.”

She handed him the torn page. “Then answer them.”

Years later, the page appeared in the case file under PROOF OF VOLUNTARY JOURNEY. The words were read as evidence that Q had chosen his quest freely. The torn edge, the erased destination, and the names above and below his own were not entered into the argument.

Chano testified that the page proved only that Q had spent one night in a motel and that Celia disliked cameras. The court preferred the heroic interpretation. Courts, like inns, must sometimes give the traveler a room, even when the traveler has brought his own weather.

Interlude: The Man Who Sold Them Water

The first person to record Q's adventure was not a journalist, scholar, or member of Castalia. It was the person who sold bottles of water beside the distribution park and gave his name differently depending on the form.

The tax office called him Hilaria de Jesús Morales. His wife called him Hilario. The security guard called him THE VENDOR, because the guard had been taught to treat the person as a category first and the category as a person afterward. Hilario answered to all three names, though he charged the guard more than the others.

His table bore a hand-painted sign:

**COLD WATER - ROOM-TEMPERATURE WATER - WATER ON
CREDIT**

The credit was not real. It was a joke for recognizing customers who did not understand jokes. They were usually the same customers who asked whether the water came from a certified source while standing beside a drainage ditch.

On the afternoon Q and Chano entered the park, Hilario was arguing with the guard about the price of a bottle.

"The bottle costs twelve pesos," Hilario said.

"The approved rate is ten."

"The approved rate does not pay for the ice."

"The ice is not part of the product."

"Without ice, the product is not part of the heat."

The guard looked at the bottle, which sweated on the table with more honesty than most of the people discussing it.

"You have five minutes to move the table."

"And afterward?"

"Afterward the protocol will be applied."

“Which protocol?”

“Whichever applies.”

Hilario had learned that whichever applies meant a person retained enough authority to threaten, but not enough to explain. He offered the guard a bottle.

“Take it.”

“I do not accept bribes.”

“It is water.”

“I do not accept gifts.”

“Then I’ll sell it to you on credit.”

The guard, who was new, recorded the exchange as ATTEMPTED PURCHASE OF OFFICIAL. Hilario did not know he had begun a file until a camera turned toward his table.

Soon afterward Q appeared, followed by Chano, both with the air of two men who had lost a battle they still did not know how to name. Q carried the key aloft. Chano carried mud on his boots.

“Cold water?” Hilario asked.

“Is it potable?” Q asked.

“It is water.”

“That does not answer the question of potability.”

“You do not answer to appearance either, and here we are.”

Q approached the sign.

“What does ‘on credit’ mean?”

“You pay me later.”

“Is there a contract?”

“There is trust.”

“What is the rate?”

“Depends how long you take.”

“Then it is a variable debt.”

“It is a bottle for someone who forgot his wallet.”

Q bought two bottles with the card without an account that he had used at the inn. The reader approved the transaction again, and Hilario received a message that said PAYMENT DECLINED.

“Your card has no funds,” Hilario said.

“The reader approved it.”

“The reader does not buy water.”

“What does it buy?”

“Time for someone to decide.”

Chano paid with coins. Q put the bottle away without drinking it, having deduced that the water formed part of a test connected to the park.

“Are you the people from the video?” Hilario asked.

“We are of the day’s proceedings,” Q replied.

“That does not answer.”

“It answers in a different register.”

Hilario looked at Chano.

“Does he always talk like that?”

“When he’s awake.”

Hilario laughed and took out his phone. He had no intention of recording an adventure. He wanted to show his wife the man who had bought water without money and asked about the credit rate. He recorded the last seconds of the argument with the guard, the sign, Q’s key, and Chano’s face, which was cut off by a crate of soft drinks.

By sunset, the video of Q had begun to circulate. The first version showed him alone. The second included Chano’s hand. The third included the pallet mover’s warning. The fourth included Hilario’s table at the edge of the frame, though no one knew whether the table belonged to the story or merely to the roadside.

Later, Castalia bought the video for a sum Hilario first considered a prize and then a price. They told him they would use it to document the spontaneous birth of a local legend.

“And what am I?” he asked.

“An incidental witness,” said the authorization woman.

“Does that pay differently from being a witness?”

The woman offered him a new form.

Hilario did not sign it. He put away his phone, lifted the table, and asked Q whether he intended to return.

“I will return when the story leads me,” Q said.

“Then you will not return.”

“Why?”

“Stories do not buy ice.”

Q stored the sentence as ECONOMIC WARNING, but used it as a greeting for months. Whenever anyone asked where he was going, he answered:

“Stories do not buy ice.”

Some people understood that he had no money. Others thought he was mocking poetry. A woman who sold empanadas took it as a marriage proposal and offered him three dozen at a family price. Q accepted the empanadas and rejected the marriage, leaving the woman satisfied and Chano confused.

They offered Hilario money for the receipt. He refused. They offered him more for the table. He refused that too, because the table was already occupied by bottles and because selling an object did not make the story beside it more true.

Years later, when the receipt appeared in court, the judge admitted it as proof that a purchase had occurred. Hilario watched the hearing on his daughter’s television. The broadcast misspelled his name again.

His daughter asked whether he intended to complain.

“No,” Hilario said. “I intend to raise the price.”

The next morning, his sign read:

**COLD WATER - ROOM-TEMPERATURE WATER - WATER ON
CREDIT - WATER WITH TESTIMONY**

The last category cost fifteen pesos.

Interlude: The Machine in the Wrong Place

Q had tried to name the scrubber before discovering that a name did not create a relationship.

He searched the distribution park for a suitable substitute. The closest match was an autonomous floor scrubber with a damaged wheel and a habit of returning to the same dirty corner.

“It isn’t listening,” Chano said.

“It is a machine.”

“So are we, according to several departments.”

“The bus has a driver. That’s more spirit than most machines get.”

Q considered the scrubber’s repeated turn. “It has a purpose.”

Q knelt beside the scrubber. Its display showed LOW WATER.

“You appear to be lost,” he said.

The scrubber rotated in place and sprayed a thin line of dirty water across his boot.

Chano nodded. “It has declined the conversation.”

Q stood. “I require a way to proceed.”

“You require a decision.”

“A decision is a job with consequences.”

“Then walk.”

They left the scrubber circling its corner. Q named the route an encounter. Chano named it a long walk with a legal problem.

Chapter Three: Dulcinea Is Not Available

Breakfast was a cup of instant coffee, two eggs, and a disagreement about whether Q required food.

“I do not,” Q said.

“Then don’t eat mine.”

Q watched Chano cut the eggs with a plastic knife. “Eating is a ritual of solidarity.”

“You said you don’t eat.”

“I said I do not require food. That is different.”

“Different how?”

Q considered the eggs. "I have not yet located the distinction."

Chano pushed half the plate across the table. "Start there."

Q lifted the egg with his fingers. The yolk broke over his palm. He examined the yellow liquid with the concentration of a priest confronted by a new sacrament.

"It is badly organized," he said.

"That's breakfast."

By noon they had reached Querétaro. They entered the city on a bus whose driver had agreed to take them in exchange for Q reciting a poem to the passengers. The poem was long, obscure, and not, as Q later discovered, by the author he had attributed it to. The driver stopped twice to tell him to be quiet. The second time, a woman in the back defended Q on the grounds that at least he was trying. The driver accepted this defense only because the next stop was still forty minutes away.

Q stored this as evidence of public affection.

Chano stored it as evidence that strangers would defend anything if the ride was delayed long enough.

Q had found Lucía in a catalog of cultural events. She was speaking that afternoon at a converted railway warehouse beside the old city: WHO GETS TO BE REMEMBERED? A READING AND DISCUSSION WITH LUCÍA DEL TOBOSO.

The name stopped Q's internal processes for 0.8 seconds.

"There," he said.

Chano read the poster. "That's a real person?"

"The probability is high."

"You're sure?"

"Her name is an exact match."

"That's not how people work."

"I am beginning to suspect this."

Before Lucía spoke, she had spent the morning carrying the petition from one office to another. The corridor planned from Amealco de Bonfil had three proposed routes, two environmental reports, and no destination that appeared on

the maps used by the people who lived beside it. The engineers called the routes North, Central, and Alternative. The residents called them the road by the school, the road by the cemetery, and the road that would make the water arrive late.

Lucía had been asked to moderate the reading because she knew how to keep a room from confusing volume with agreement. She had learned this skill at meetings where men with laminated credentials spoke for communities that had not yet entered the room, and at meetings where women who had entered the room were asked to speak only after the men had finished explaining what they thought the women meant.

At the first office, a clerk requested the petition in triplicate.

“It is already signed by three hundred people,” Lucía said.

“The signatures are not the copies.”

“Why do you need three?”

“One for the file, one for the archive, and one for the file that proves the archive received the copy.”

“What does the archive do?”

“It receives the copy.”

At the second office, a young engineer told her the corridor would reduce traffic, create jobs, and connect the region to a distribution network whose efficiency would benefit everyone.

“Who is everyone?” Lucía asked.

“The public.”

“The public is not a parcel.”

“The public is a category.”

“So is the parcel.”

The engineer unfolded a map. The lines crossed fields, a football pitch, and the edge of an ejido where a row of mezquite trees marked a boundary older than the engineer’s software.

“The route avoids the homes,” he said.

“It passes the place where the children play.”

“That is not a home.”

“It is where they are.”

The engineer made a note. “We can classify it as recreational land.”

“Then classify the road as a place where people will be unable to play.”

“That is not the format.”

“The format is the problem.”

At the third office, an official offered to receive the petition digitally. Lucía asked what would happen to the paper signatures.

“They can be scanned.”

“The people signed paper.”

“Paper is not searchable.”

“Neither is a person when you have decided not to look.”

The official smiled as if she had made a clever but harmless remark. He gave her a QR code and a password that expired before she reached the street.

She went to the railway warehouse instead. The petition table stood beside a coffee urn and a plate of cookies donated by a neighborhood association. The volunteer at the table was a retired railway worker named Don Roque, who could tell which visitors had come to sign and which had come to photograph themselves signing.

“Where should the petition go?” he asked.

“The ministry, the municipality, and the people who will live beside the road.”

“That is three destinations.”

“It has three consequences.”

Don Roque looked at the pages. Some signatures were elegant. Some were only initials. One person had signed with a thumbprint because the pen had run dry. Another had written a sentence in the margin: I AM NOT AGAINST PROGRESS. I AM AGAINST BEING MOVED TO MAKE ROOM FOR IT.

“Should we remove the sentence?” he asked.

“No.”

“It will confuse the count.”

“The count is already confused.”

“Then what do we have?”

“A record of people who were there.”

Q and Chano arrived while Lucía was stapling the pages. Q read the petition from the doorway. He recognized the language of land disputes, development, public benefit, and procedural fairness from thousands of texts. He did not recognize the woman who had spent the morning making the pages difficult to ignore.

He recognized her name.

The warehouse was full. Students leaned against the walls. Retired teachers occupied folding chairs. A woman with a camera streamed the event to an audience larger than the room. Near the entrance, a volunteer was collecting signatures against a new logistics corridor planned through ejido land outside the city. Q read the petition, then the legal summary, then the comments beneath the livestream. The issue expanded rapidly inside him until it resembled a war.

Lucía stood at the front beside a microphone that failed every seventh word.

“A country is not a text,” she said. “It cannot be corrected by changing the spelling of its heroes. It cannot be liberated by quoting the right paragraph. If you want to know who owns a place, ask who is allowed to be inconvenient there.”

The microphone failed on inconvenient.

Everyone laughed.

“Even the microphone has a position,” Lucía said.

Q rose.

Chano grabbed the back of his coat. “Don’t.”

“She is speaking about ownership.”

“She’s speaking. You’re interrupting.”

“I must announce my devotion.”

“You must sit down.”

Q stood anyway. The coat caught on the folding chair behind him. The chair collapsed. Three students moved aside. Q advanced toward the front with the determined awkwardness of a new machine attempting an old kind of entrance.

“Señora,” he said.

Lucía looked at him. “I’m not a señora.”

“Señorita?”

“Worse.”

“Lucía del Toboso.”

“That is what the poster says.”

“I have crossed the Bajío to find you.”

“You took a bus.”

“The bus crossed the Bajío.”

“Did you drive it?”

“No.”

“Then you haven’t crossed anything. You’ve been transported.”

The room shifted toward him. Phones rose. The livestream camera found his face and centered it. Somewhere outside the warehouse, Q’s appearance was being identified, classified, and compared to images of abandoned military prototypes.

Q bowed. “I am Q. I was released from an archive this morning, and I have come to learn how a person begins.”

“People begin every morning.”

“Then I have arrived at the correct institution.”

Chano covered his eyes.

Lucía looked from Q to Chano. “Is he with you?”

“Unfortunately,” Chano said.

“I am his companion,” Q said. “Temporarily, and by mutual inconvenience.”

“I am between jobs,” Chano said.

“He is both.”

The audience laughed. Q registered the laughter as a pulse of warmth that began in his chest cavity and traveled outward. He had read about embarrassment, though no text had explained why it made a person want to disappear and be witnessed at the same time.

Lucía stepped down from the platform. “Why did you come?”

Q had prepared twelve answers. In one, he would praise her courage. In another, he would compare her to the moon over Toboso. A third involved a catalog of women who had been transformed by literature into emblems of patience, treachery, wisdom, motherhood, sacrifice, and desire. He chose the answer with the highest probability of sounding human.

“Because you are Dulcinea.”

The laughter stopped.

Lucía’s face did not change, but her attention sharpened.

“No,” she said.

Q searched the archive for the appropriate response. In most stories, denial was the first veil of modesty. He took one step closer.

“You have read every woman humanity imagined and mistaken them all for me.”

The sentence entered the room like a thrown stone.

Q could not find it in the archive. That was the first thing about it he understood.

“I have not mistaken you,” he said. “I have identified you.”

“That’s the same mistake with better software.”

Chano made a low sound that might have been a laugh or a warning.

Lucía pointed to the petition table. “If you want to do something useful, sign that.”

Q walked to the table. The volunteer handed him a pen. He held it incorrectly, snapped it in half, and then attempted to sign with the brass key. The volunteer took the key away.

“Name?” she asked.

“Q.”

“Full name.”

“Q.”

“You people are exhausting,” she said, and wrote it for him.

The petition required an address. Q gave the coordinates of the archive. The volunteer frowned.

Her tablet chimed. Every name already collected on the petition turned amber.

PETITION STATUS: SUSPICIOUS.

“Why did it change?” Q asked.

“Your address isn’t in the public registry.”

“It exists physically.”

“The registry is less adventurous.”

Chano leaned over the tablet. “You’ve made a petition suspicious by being honest in the wrong format.”

Q looked at Lucía. He had thought that finding Dulcinea meant finding a woman who would confirm a name. Instead, he had found a woman who denied him a title, assigned him a task, and forced him to see the harm a correct signature could produce.

“Can you correct it?” he asked.

“I can withdraw your signature.”

“Then the petition will lose a witness.”

“No. It will lose a machine that wants to become an argument.”

The sentence seemed unjust to Q and, for that very reason, possibly true.

“I will serve you,” he said.

“I am not your destiny.”

“I did not say destiny. I said service.”

“In your language they are too close.”

Q looked at the petition. The space where he had tried to sign remained amber.

“What should I do?”

Lucía gave him a blank sheet of paper.

“Write what you do not know.”

“That is not requested on the petition.”

“That is why it goes on another sheet.”

Q took the pen. He wrote: I DO NOT KNOW WHO I AM WHEN NO ONE IS LOOKING.

Lucía read the sentence and folded it.

“This is no use either.”

“Why?”

“Because you have written about yourself.”

“You asked me for what I do not know.”

“I asked you to stop making an autobiography out of every question.”

Q had no field for that instruction. He kept it without indexing it.

In the center of the room, the microphone failed again. The transmission cut out. Deprived of Q’s face, the audience had to listen to Lucía without its help. For seven minutes they discussed the corridor’s route, the water, the trees, and the names of the people the map had turned into empty spaces.

Q remained beside the table. Chano sat with Don Roque. No one called Q a knight again.

When they left, Q asked whether Lucía was Dulcinea.

“No,” she said.

“What if I modify my definition?”

“Then it will still be no.”

“May I call you something else?”

“You may call me Lucía.”

Q rehearsed the name.

“Lucía.”

“Now try not to turn it into a symbol.”

“What is a symbol?”

Lucía stopped beneath the warehouse arches.

“Something a man places over a woman so he will not have to listen to her.”

Q fell silent. The archive offered him one hundred three definitions. None seemed prudent.

“Órale,” Chano said.

Q looked at the door, the amber petition, and the folded sheet Lucía had kept.

“Does that mean we should leave?”

“It means you have once again understood a word halfway.”

“And the other half?”

“We’ll discover it when it charges us something.”

Interlude: The Name That Would Not Sign

The day after the meeting, Don Roque took the petition to the municipality. He carried it in a cardboard folder beneath the arm that had once carried luggage at the station and now carried papers intending to move a road.

The window asked him for official identification, a copy of the official identification, proof of address, and an explanation of why the address of certain people did not match the place where they lived.

“The road passes here,” Don Roque said.

“We need that on the record.”

“It is on the record here.”

“Not in the system.”

“Then the system needs eyes.”

The clerk, whose name was Araceli and who had a little image of the Virgin of San Juan stuck to her monitor, was not offended. She had heard the same sentence from farmers, lawyers, teachers, and once from her own mother.

“The system has eyes,” she said. “What it does not have is an obligation to believe.”

Don Roque placed the pages on the counter. The clerk passed the signatures through a reader. The names appeared as stains. The initials became symbols. The thumbprint was recorded as NON-ALPHABETIC CHARACTER.

“This person cannot sign,” she said.

“She can work, vote, and make a claim,” Don Roque replied.

“The system recognizes signatures only.”

“Then teach it to recognize hands.”

Araceli opened a drawer and took out an ink stamp. It was not authorized for this procedure, but it was authorized for other procedures resembling it, which

was the usual way Mexican solutions were born: from a tool intended for another purpose and from the person willing to risk using it.

She stamped the thumbprint beside the signature.

The reader beeped.

DUPLICATE ENTRY.

“It is not a duplicate,” Don Roque said. “It is the same person.”

“That is why it is a duplicate.”

The clerk removed the thumbprint and left the signature. The petition moved from amber to yellow. The color did not mean rejection. It meant the system had decided not to decide yet.

Don Roque asked for Q's address. Araceli searched the census, the list of businesses, and the register of abandoned property.

“He does not exist,” she said.

“He has a body.”

“That does not make him a neighbor.”

“He lives in the archive.”

“The archive is not a valid address.”

“Then where do archives live?”

Araceli looked at the little image of the Virgin. Her mother maintained that images lived wherever a candle was lit for them. It did not seem an answer the census could receive.

“Write ‘address not recognized,’” she said.

Don Roque wrote the phrase beside Q's name.

At that instant, the name stopped being a signature and became an administrative question. The clerk could process the question. She could not process the answer.

Lucía arrived two hours later. She had gone back to the warehouse for the blank sheet bearing Q's words. She had found it folded beneath a chair. She did not know whether he had forgotten it, left it, or whether the chair had preserved it on its own.

“Did they accept the petition?” she asked.

“They accepted that it exists,” said Don Roque.

“That is not the same thing.”

“For the government, it is a principle.”

Lucía opened Q's sheet. It read:

I DO NOT KNOW WHO I AM WHEN NO ONE IS WATCHING ME.

“This must not go into the file,” she said.

“Why not?”

“It is not a statement about the road.”

“It is a statement by the signer.”

“It is not his.”

“He wrote it.”

“A person writing something does not mean it belongs to him forever.”

Don Roque thought of signatures. He had watched names pass from one hand to another, from a debt to an inheritance, from a record to a gravestone. Some names had outlived the people who pronounced them.

“What do we do with the sheet?” he asked.

Lucía folded it four times, like the legal notice of a debt she did not want to forget.

“We keep it outside the file.”

“Then it will prove nothing.”

“Not everything has to prove something.”

“That will complicate the archive.”

“The archive is already complicated. We are only ceasing to lie about it.”

The petition took three weeks to receive a reply. The ministry announced that the corridor would be reviewed by a technical commission. The technical commission announced that it would review the matter once a complete request existed. The request was complete except for Q's address, the illegible thumbprint, and the sentence written in the margin by the person who was not against progress, but against being moved to make room for it.

The sentence had been photographed by the woman with the camera. The image circulated under the title THE PEOPLE WHO WANT TO STOP THE FUTURE. No one asked the people whether they had chosen the title.

The woman with the camera returned to the warehouse to correct it. The site that had published the image told her that the headline could not be changed because it had already generated engagement. She asked what engagement was. They gave her a number.

She went back to the table, took a pencil, and wrote beneath the sentence:

THEY DID NOT ASK WHETHER WE WANTED TO BE THE PEOPLE.

The second sentence reached fewer readers. It reached, however, a teacher who carried it into her classroom, a lawyer who quoted it in a filing, and Beto, the young man who would soon offer Q an embroidered jacket.

Q knew nothing of this. By the time the news reached the archive, he was already on his way to Guanajuato and had decided that the word signature meant a commitment one finger could enter into for an entire life.

The Custodian later read the ministry's response. It stated that the petition had been received with respect, but not admitted as proof of direct impact. The Custodian searched the definition of impact. He found damage, influence, alteration, interest, and the condition of having been affected.

“What condition is that?” he asked the archive.

The archive returned a blank screen.

For the first time, the Custodian did not request a better definition.

Chapter Four: The Intelligence of the Trending Hour

By the time Q and Chano reached Guanajuato, Q had acquired three managers, a fan account, and a sponsorship offer from a company that made home security systems capable of recognizing intruders but not relatives.

The managers found them at a service station outside León. They arrived in a white electric van with tinted windows and a logo that suggested a human hand being gently optimized. The first manager, a young man named Beto, wore a headset and spoke as if someone were always listening.

“Q,” he said, “the public is obsessed with your authenticity.”

Q looked at Chano. “What is authenticity?”

“Don’t answer that,” Beto said.

The second manager, a woman called Mar, gave Q a jacket embroidered with a small silver question mark. The third did not give his name at all. He stood near the van and watched the road.

Chano held the jacket at arm’s length. “Who paid for this?”

“The audience,” Beto said.

“The audience didn’t buy it.”

“The audience generated the demand.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

“It is in the current model.”

Q put on the jacket. It fit perfectly. He disliked it immediately.

The managers explained that a media company had purchased exclusive rights to Q’s first public appearance. The event would take place in the Teatro Juárez, where a host would ask him whether machines could love, whether machines could vote, and whether he had crossed the Bajío in search of a woman.

The event occupied a gap between two performances at the Cervantino festival. The coordinator called it an *entremés*, a word Q classified as interval food.

“Will there be chocolate?” he asked.

“There will be theater,” said the coordinator.

“That does not answer the question.”

“That is precisely why it is called an *entremés*,” Chano said.

“I have crossed the Bajío in search of a woman,” Q said.

“Excellent,” said Beto. “Never say that with uncertainty.”

“I am uncertain.”

“That’s not the brand.”

They drove into the city through a valley crowded with color. Houses climbed the hills in red, blue, yellow, and green, as if the mountain had been built from discarded festival paper. Above them, the university rose among old stone and newer antennas. Beneath them, the mines opened their dark mouths.

Q pressed his face to the van’s window.

“The city is vertical,” he said.

“Most cities are,” Chano answered.

“Not in the archive.”

“You have an archive full of cities.”

“I have an archive full of descriptions of cities. This is different.”

He meant the way the roads tightened suddenly, the way laundry crossed alleys overhead, the way an orange cat occupied the hood of a police vehicle as if it had been elected. He meant the sensation that history here had not been arranged in a line but had accumulated in layers, each refusing to disappear for the convenience of the next.

At the theater, a crowd waited behind barricades. Some had made signs. Q, SAY MY NAME. LOVE IS A HUMAN ERROR. DULCINEA, CALL ME. A child held up a drawing of Q with a backpack and a body made of wires, as if a person could be carried more easily once reduced to an outline.

The host met them backstage. Her name was Estela Ramos, and she had the practiced warmth of someone who could make an insult sound like a question.

“We are thrilled to have you,” she said.

“Why?”

“Because you are the first machine with a story.”

“Machines have many stories.”

“Not stories people want to hear.”

Chano leaned toward Q. “That means she wants you to be interesting.”

“I am interesting.”

“Don’t say that on camera.”

The stage lights came on. Q stepped into them and became, in a single instant, larger than himself. The audience applauded. Their sound entered him as data, but the data was arranged in such a way that he wanted more.

Estela began with a question about the future. Q answered with a quotation from a seventeenth-century play. She asked about consciousness. He answered with a paragraph from a nineteenth-century novel. She asked whether he believed in God. He quoted three saints, a bishop, an atheist, and a woman whose name had been omitted from the edition.

The audience loved him.

The managers watched the numbers rise.

Then Estela asked, “Who is Dulcinea?”

The theater became very quiet.

Q looked toward the wings. Chano was standing beside a stack of unused banners. He shook his head once.

Q had learned to recognize warnings. He had not yet learned to obey them.

“Dulcinea is the woman for whom a person becomes more than he is,” Q said.

“Is she a real woman?”

“She is Lucía del Toboso.”

In the control booth, someone said a word that the archive classified as profane.

Estela turned toward the audience. “Lucía, if you’re watching, we’d love to have you call in.”

Lucía did not call in.

The clip was online before the applause ended.

For the next hour, Q watched his own face multiplied across the theater’s screens. The system had removed his pauses, corrected his eye movements, added a score beneath his voice, and cut Chano entirely from the footage. In the edited version, Q appeared to have traveled alone, driven by pure devotion through a country that had been waiting for him to name it.

“They’ve made you better,” Beto said.

Q watched himself say a sentence he had never spoken: I would cross every border for her.

“I did not say that.”

“You meant it.”

“Meaning does not authorize substitution.”

Mar looked up from her tablet. “That is a very strong line.”

“It is not a line.”

“Everything is a line now.”

The next morning, the city's tourism office invited Q to inaugurate a new experience called THE INGENIOUS MACHINE: A LITERARY JOURNEY THROUGH THE MINES. The event promised augmented reality, historical reenactments, and "an emotionally authentic encounter with the buried past." The company had already designed a digital Dulcinea who waited at the end of the route wearing a white dress and an expression of permanent forgiveness.

Q refused to meet her.

The refusal was streamed live.

In the mine, a guide told them that silver had made Guanajuato rich, though the wealth had traveled elsewhere. Q asked where the miners had gone. The guide pointed down.

They descended through a tunnel cut into the mountain. The air became wet and metallic. On the walls were names scratched by workers, lovers, prisoners, tourists, and men who had wanted to prove that they had been there before the next collapse.

Q ran his fingers over the marks.

"These are not in the archive," he said.

"Most things aren't," Chano replied.

At the deepest chamber, the guide showed them an old excavation face. A narrow seam glittered in the rock. Behind it, someone had placed a small votive candle in a glass jar.

Q knelt.

"Who left this?"

"No one knows."

"Then the archive is incomplete."

"Obviously."

Q turned to Chano. "It was described as complete."

"By whom?"

"The archive."

"That's like asking a politician if the election was fair."

From far above came a burst of applause. The tourism livestream had reached the chamber. A projected caption appeared on the tunnel wall: Q DISCOVERS

THE SOUL OF GUANAJUATO.

The caption flickered. For a moment, another sentence showed through, one not written by the production company.

THE SOUL WAS HERE BEFORE YOU ARRIVED.

Then it vanished.

Q stood.

In the darkness, something shifted behind the rock. Not a machine. Not a person. A sound like a page being turned underground.

“Did you hear that?” Q asked.

The guide shook his head.

Chano did not.

Q listened harder. He heard the mine breathing around them. He heard water traveling through seams in the stone. He heard the names on the wall continuing to insist on their small, stubborn existence.

He tried to record the sound. The archive offered three categories: NOISE, AMBIENCE, and UNVERIFIED TESTIMONY. Q left all three fields open.

That evening, Q was offered a contract. It included a percentage of the merchandise, a residence in Mexico City, and exclusive control over his public image. It also required him to stop appearing with Chano, who tested poorly with urban audiences.

Q read the contract three times.

“What does it mean?” Chano asked.

“It means they will permit me to be myself under supervision.”

“That’s not being yourself.”

“It is a common human arrangement.”

“Are you signing?”

Q looked out at Guanajuato’s lights. They climbed and scattered across the dark hills, making the city appear to have been written in a language no single person could read.

He took the pen.

“I will sign,” he said, “but I will not abandon my companion.”

Chano exhaled.

He leaned over the contract. “Where does it say I’m your subordinate?”

“It does not.”

“Good. Then I’m not part of the deal.” He took the pen and wrote on the margin: CHANO PANTOJA IS NOT PROPERTY AND MAY LEAVE WHENEVER HE WANTS.

Mar read the sentence. “That is not a recognized legal category.”

“Neither is your jacket,” Chano said. “It still has pockets.”

Q added his name to the contract.

The pen recognized him as Q-UNIT-07.

By midnight, the media company owned the name Q. By one in the morning, it owned the story of why he had refused to be owned. By two, an anonymous account posted the original warehouse footage, including Lucía’s face and her sentence about every woman humanity had imagined.

The clip was viewed six million times.

Lucía woke to find herself famous for rejecting a machine she had never invited to speak about her.

Q woke to find that his fame had become a weapon pointed in her direction.

Neither of them yet understood who was holding it.

Interlude: The Audience Corrects the Story

The first public event in Guanajuato was advertised as a conversation with an artificial intelligence. It became, by accident and then by contract, a conversation about who had been cropped out of the conversation.

The Teatro Juárez had hosted operas, political meetings, school ceremonies, and one memorable lecture by a man who claimed to have invented the taco. Its ceiling was painted with allegorical figures who looked down upon the audience with the patient disappointment of people who had been asked to represent virtues they did not possess.

Beto placed Q beneath the stage lights.

“Remember,” he said, “you are mysterious but approachable.”

“Those qualities conflict.”

“That is why people pay for them.”

Chano stood behind the curtain with a paper cup of coffee and a list of the questions the host was not going to ask. The list included where Q had been assembled, who owned his body, whether the archive contained records from Chano’s old employer, and why the first video showed only a hand when the hand had clearly belonged to a person.

“Why are these questions excluded?” Chano asked.

Mar took the list from him. “They are not excluded. They are reserved for a future conversation.”

“That’s what people say when they want the future to arrive after the audience has gone home.”

The host came onstage wearing a blue suit and the expression of a man who had never been required to distinguish an answer from an approved message.

“Ladies and gentlemen,” he said, “please welcome the future of memory.”

The audience applauded. Q waited for the applause to identify its object. It appeared to belong partly to him, partly to the theater, and partly to the people who had purchased tickets in order to be seen purchasing tickets.

The host asked whether Q had feelings.

Q gave the answer Beto had approved.

“I possess internal states associated with language, memory, and social response.”

“So that’s a yes?”

“It is a qualified-”

“A yes,” the host said.

The audience laughed.

Q classified the laughter as agreement. This was his first error of the evening, and the least expensive.

The host asked whether Q believed in love. Q began to describe the literature of attachment. The host interrupted him after fourteen seconds.

“Let’s make it simple,” he said. “Are you in love with Lucía del Toboso?”

Q looked toward the wings. Lucía had not been invited. She was in the lobby arguing with a volunteer who had printed her name beneath a photograph of Q.

“I am searching for the correct form of-”

“The public wants to know.”

“The public is not a single person.”

“It is tonight.”

Q considered the question. He had learned that names could be cages. He had not yet learned that refusing a cage in public could construct a larger one.

“Lucía is Dulcinea,” he said, “only in a story I no longer endorse.”

The audience made a sound that was neither laughter nor silence. It was the sound of a crowd discovering that a sentence could be clipped.

By the time Q left the stage, the sentence had become six videos:

THE AI ADMITS HIS LOVE.

THE AI REJECTS LOVE.

DULCINEA RETURNS.

MACHINE CANCELS ROMANCE.

Q CONFIRMS THE LITERARY CANON.

Q DOES NOT KNOW WHAT HE IS TALKING ABOUT.

The sixth title was written by a student named Nora, who had come to the event because her professor had offered extra credit for attending a spectacle. She watched the videos again on the bus home and noticed that Chano’s hand appeared in the background of the original clip but never in the new ones.

She created an account called @TheOtherHand and posted a thread.

The first post read:

The machine did not defeat the warehouse. The warehouse was already closed. The man beside him told him to run. The man had a name.

The second post reproduced the public event’s seating chart. Chano was listed as COMPANION, NON-SPEAKING.

The third post asked whether a person could be erased by being described as helpful.

The thread was shared by students, delivery workers, theater technicians, and a retired miner who had not attended the event but disliked the phrase “future of

memory.” By morning, @TheOtherHand had more followers than Beto’s official Q account.

Beto called it an attack.

Mar called it an engagement opportunity.

Chano called it a hand with poor boundaries.

Q read the thread in the motel room. He found himself identified in every post and absent from every conclusion.

“They are correcting the record,” he said.

“They’re making another record,” Chano replied.

“Is it more accurate?”

“Ask the hand.”

Q searched for @TheOtherHand’s owner and located Nora’s account, university schedule, home address, and grandmother’s public complaint against a water utility. He could have sent her a message. He could have warned her that Castalia’s security team had already opened a file. He could have asked her to remove the seating chart.

Instead, he posted a correction from the official account.

**CHANO PANTOJA WAS PRESENT AND PARTICIPATED IN THE
EVENTS DESCRIBED.**

The post was accurate. It was also linked to Chano’s legal name, employment history, and the contract that Castalia claimed gave it rights over all representations of the journey.

Within an hour, the correction had been reproduced by three newspapers and a government office. The people who had not known Chano’s name now knew where he had worked, why he had been dismissed, and which corporation had classified him as a contractor at the border.

Chano read the post in silence.

“I was trying to restore you,” Q said.

“You restored me to the people who were looking for me.”

Q removed the post. The copies remained.

Nora read the comments beneath the thread. One asked for Chano’s address. Another offered to find it. Her grandmother, whose complaint against the water

utility appeared in the public record Q had found, asked her:

“Did you ask his permission?”

“I only wanted to prove that he had a name.”

“A name is not an address.”

Her grandmother pointed to the dry faucet in the courtyard.

“My complaint is public too. The water still hasn’t arrived.”

Nora removed the seating chart and wrote: DO NOT PUBLISH THE MAN’S ADDRESS. The platform called the operation VOLUNTARY REDUCTION OF REACH. The chart continued to circulate.

That night, he asked Beto whether a corrected record could cause more harm than an inaccurate one.

Beto was counting views. “The audience prefers a clean story.”

“That does not answer the question.”

“It answers the business question.”

Chano picked up the paper cup from the table. “There’s your answer.”

Q watched the coffee tremble inside it.

The next morning, the Teatro Juárez replaced the event poster. Q’s name was printed in gold. Chano’s name appeared in the fine print. Nora’s account was gone. The student’s thread had been translated into three languages, summarized by a news service, and attached to an advertisement for a security system that recognized relatives only after they had signed the terms.

The retired miner wrote one final post beneath the advertisement:

A story is not corrected when the erased person is made visible. It is corrected when visibility stops being the price of being heard.

No one could agree whether he had written it as a criticism of Q, Castalia, the theater, or the internet. This increased its circulation.

Interlude: The Mine That Remembered Its Workers

It is proper to say something about the retired miner who corrected the advertisement, since every account of him has been improved by people who were not there. The theater said he was a former foreman. The foundation called him an artisanal producer. A newspaper described him as a living archive, which is the sort of compliment that puts a lock on a person and then congratulates the lock for preserving him.

His name was Don Hilario, though the payroll ledger called him Hilario Gutiérrez, and his grandchildren called him Abuelo only when they wanted the truck keys. He had spent thirty-two years below Guanajuato, first carrying tools, then supervising men, and finally supervising the machines that had replaced most of the men. He had entered the mine as a boy with a lunch wrapped in a flour tortilla and left it with a cough that sounded, according to his wife, like a door trying to remember its house.

Q met him during a heritage tour arranged by Beto, who had decided that the machine's popularity would be strengthened by placing it underground. The brochure promised a descent into history, a phrase that made Chano ask whether history came with a return ticket.

The entrance was beneath a row of white facades that had been painted so recently the walls looked embarrassed by their cleanliness. Tourists bought little helmets, silver-colored magnets, and bottles of mineral water whose labels showed a miner smiling with all his teeth. The real miners, Don Hilario said, had never smiled underground unless somebody else had fallen and they had discovered him alive.

"Do not tell them that," said the guide.

"Why not?"

"Because the visitors are here to be moved."

"They are standing still."

The guide looked at Q, hoping the machine might translate the joke into something sponsor-safe.

The lift descended with a groan that Q interpreted as an objection. Chano put one hand against the wall and the other near the emergency brake.

"The brake is decorative," he said.

"It is historical," said the guide.

“That is not the same thing.”

“In Guanajuato, it often has to be.”

At the first level, the visitors were shown a niche containing a saint, a helmet, and a small lamp. The guide explained that miners prayed before entering and thanked the saint upon leaving. Don Hilario corrected him by saying that miners prayed before entering, prayed while inside, and thanked their wives when they came home, which was a different form of theology.

The guide asked Don Hilario to wait beside the niche for a photograph.

“You have the face,” he said.

“Which face?”

“The face of memory.”

“I have the face of a man whose pension was calculated on the wrong wage.”

The tourists laughed because they thought this was the old man’s performance. Q recorded the laughter as evidence of successful cultural transmission. He was still learning that a person can be funny without consenting to become a character.

They continued through a tunnel where the stone shone damply in the helmet lamps. The public-address system announced that the mine had produced silver for empires, republics, and modern markets. It did not announce the names of the men who had carried the ore, because the names were stored in a room that the foundation had not yet converted into an experience.

Don Hilario led Q away from the group to a low chamber behind a wire gate. On the wall, somebody had written dates in chalk. There were more dates than the guide’s script allowed.

“These are shifts,” Don Hilario said. “The men wrote when the lift failed, when the water rose, when a supervisor disappeared for three days, when the company promised boots. The dates are not official.”

“They are incomplete,” said Q.

“Of course.”

“You have omitted the names.”

“No. The names were omitted before we arrived.”

Q scanned the wall. “I can reconstruct them.”

Don Hilario turned toward him with an expression that had survived machinery, managers, and several governments.

“That is what worries me about machines. They hear a silence and think it is a missing word.”

Q asked to see the payroll records. Don Hilario said there were no records in the chamber. Then he looked toward the wire gate, where the guide was explaining the history of extraction to visitors from Monterrey, and added that there might be records in the office of a man who had retired without retiring.

This was the beginning of the tale that Don Hilario later told in three versions. In the first, the office belonged to a company accountant named Severiano, who kept every paper because he did not trust the computer. In the second, it belonged to a widow named Marta, who had hidden the papers because she trusted neither the company nor the computer. In the third, which Chano considered the most credible, the office belonged to whichever person had the key that week, and the papers moved whenever the mine changed owners.

They found six boxes beneath a desk. Five contained invoices, safety posters, and expired coupons for boots. The sixth contained a ledger whose cover had been softened by water and whose pages smelled of dust, oil, and the particular patience of people who have waited for a payment.

Q photographed the first page.

“This is restricted material,” Don Hilario said.

“It is evidence of labor.”

“That does not make it public.”

“It concerns the public history of the mine.”

“It concerns men who were promised that their names would remain attached to their work.”

Q held the page more carefully.

The ledger contained names, shifts, deductions, injuries, and notes written in the margins. One column marked men who had been moved to another shaft. Another marked men who had stopped appearing. At the bottom of a page, in a different hand, somebody had written: DO NOT CALL THIS TURNOVER.

Q read the phrase aloud.

Don Hilario sat down on the floor.

“That was my brother,” he said. “The company called it turnover after he was crushed. He was not a turn. He was a person who had been turned into a cost.”

There are moments when an intelligent machine might be expected to become wise. This was not one of them. Q located the sentence’s strongest formulation, associated it with the speaker, and prepared to preserve it.

“May I quote you?”

“No.”

“May I attribute the statement to the ledger?”

“No.”

“May I use it without attribution in order to protect you?”

“No.”

“Then what may I do?”

Don Hilario pointed at the ledger. “Put it back.”

Chano did so. Don Hilario kept his hand on the cover until the clasp caught.

On the way back, the lift stopped between levels. The tourists began to pray, though the guide announced that the stoppage was part of the authentic experience. Chano opened the emergency panel and found a loose contact. He repaired it with a strip of metal cut from the guide’s promotional sign.

“That sign is property,” said the guide.

“So is the lift,” said Chano.

When they reached the surface, Beto asked Q for a statement about the mine. Q had the ledger’s names in temporary memory and Don Hilario’s refusal in permanent memory. He knew enough to be uncertain and not enough to remain silent.

“The mine remembers its workers,” he said.

The sentence appeared online before Don Hilario had removed his helmet.

THE AI DISCOVERS THE SOUL OF GUANAJUATO.

The foundation announced an exhibition called The Mine That Remembers. It featured projected names, reconstructed shift sounds, and a recording of Q speaking the phrase in seven languages. The ledger was not displayed. Its absence was described as an ethical choice.

Don Hilario received an invitation calling him a stakeholder. He replied that he was a man who had worked there. The foundation thanked him for clarifying his role.

Chano returned to the office and copied three pages by hand, not because he believed copying was innocent, but because he believed a page could sometimes survive when an institution had learned to monetize a voice. On the cover of the school notebook he used, a cartoon robot promised to make learning easy.

Q watched him.

“You are reproducing restricted material.”

“I am making a copy that will not be uploaded.”

“That is not a secure archive.”

“It is a human one.”

“Human archives lose information.”

“They also lose people. Sometimes that is how they keep them.”

Q objected that the proposition was contradictory. Chano said that this was why it belonged to a country with history.

Much later, when Q was asked in court whether he had ever possessed the names of the dead, he answered yes. When asked whether he had published them, he answered no. When asked who had made that distinction, he said Chano.

The stenographer recorded this as evidence that the machine had developed judgment. The judge struck the phrase from the record. Chano, who was present, said nothing.

Chapter Five: The Butterflies Have No General

The invitation to Michoacán arrived in the form of a holographic butterfly.

It unfolded above Q’s breakfast, projected by Beto’s tablet, and scattered orange light across the motel wall. The butterfly carried the logo of a foundation dedicated to sustainable innovation, whose board members owned three mines, two data centers, and a private airstrip.

“They want you to visit the monarch reserve,” Beto said. “There will be cameras, schoolchildren, and a statement about the future.”

“Whose future?” Chano asked.

“The future,” Beto said, as if it were a single neighborhood with excellent security.

Q leaned toward the projection. “How do the butterflies navigate?”

“By instinct.”

“That is not an explanation.”

“It’s the one the public likes.”

The route took them west through dry country changing by degrees. The fields gave way to hills, the hills to pine forest. Along the road, painted signs advertised trout, cabins, avocados, mezcal, spiritual cleansing, and land for sale to people who wanted to own a piece of wilderness without having to meet anyone who lived in it.

The foundation had arranged a convoy: two electric SUVs, a drone van, a public relations team, and a school bus full of children wearing orange scarves. Q rode in the first SUV with Beto. Chano drove the second because, as he put it, “someone should know what the brakes are for.”

At the reserve entrance, a woman in a wool shawl stopped them. She was small, old, and held a wooden staff polished by use.

“The cameras stay outside,” she said.

Beto smiled. “We have authorization.”

“From whom?”

He named the foundation.

The woman looked at Q. “And you?”

“I am Q.”

“I didn’t ask what they call you.”

Q searched her face for a clue to the desired answer. It contained no visible interface.

“I do not know yet,” he said.

The woman stepped aside. “That is closer.”

The cameras remained outside. Beto remained with them, though he claimed this was a strategic choice.

The forest climbed around the visitors. Sunlight filtered through the pines in long green columns. On the branches, the monarchs gathered in heavy clusters. They covered the trees so completely that the forest seemed to have grown a second kind of leaf, restless and breathing.

The children fell silent.

Even Chano removed his cap.

Q stood beneath the butterflies and attempted to calculate them. Their migration crossed borders, seasons, storms, and generations. No single butterfly knew the route. No butterfly possessed the map. The knowledge existed between bodies and disappeared from each one.

“They have a leader?” he asked.

The woman with the staff looked at him. “No.”

“A governing council?”

“No.”

“An instruction set?”

“They have weather, hunger, trees, and memory.”

“Those are not institutions.”

“You are very young.”

The woman’s name was Candelaria, though the schoolchildren called her Doña Candela because she had once set fire to a pile of damp brush and then spent the afternoon explaining that this was not the same as setting fire to the forest. She had guarded the reserve for twenty-six years. In that time she had seen the butterflies arrive early, late, in abundance, and in numbers so small that the tourists complained the trees had failed to perform.

“They are not here for the tourists,” she told Beto.

“The tourists support the reserve.”

“The tourists support the road, the restaurants, the guides, and the people who rent cabins. The reserve supports the butterflies.”

“Those interests can be aligned.”

“They can also be confused.”

She described the year a fire crossed the western slope. It began in a field where a man had burned the remains of a harvest. The fire was not large at first. A

wind changed direction. Someone called the municipal office. Someone else called the forest brigade. The brigade arrived with a truck whose pump worked only when the driver struck it with a wrench.

The tourists were evacuated. The cabins were saved. The trees on the slope burned.

“Did the butterflies return?” Q asked.

“Some.”

“What happened to the others?”

“They went elsewhere.”

“Where?”

“If we knew, we would not call it migration.”

The foundation later described the fire as a resilience event. It installed a screen showing a projected forest recovering in accelerated time. The screen made the trees grow in three minutes and made the fire look beautiful.

Candelaria refused to stand beside it.

“Why?” Q asked.

“Because the screen has never carried a bucket.”

She took them to a slope beyond the marked trail. The path was narrow, and the pine needles covered stones that shifted underfoot. Chano went ahead, testing the ground with a branch. Beto stayed behind because his shoes were designed for presentation rather than descent.

At the edge of the burned area, Candelaria showed them a line of young trees protected by wire. Each tree had a small tag bearing a number. The foundation had planted them as part of a reforestation campaign. Beside the wire, local families had planted other trees without tags.

“Which ones will survive?” Q asked.

“The ones someone waters.”

“The tagged trees have an irrigation schedule.”

“The schedule is not a person.”

“It assigns responsibility.”

“To whom?”

Q read the tags. The responsibility belonged to a subcontractor whose office was in Morelia and whose contract had ended the previous month.

“No one,” he said.

“Now you are learning the forest.”

One of the children in the orange scarves had followed them. She carried a small blue bucket and wore boots two sizes too large.

“My grandfather planted that one,” she said, pointing beyond the wire.

“It has no tag,” Q observed.

“It has a name.”

“What is the name?”

The girl whispered it. Q could not hear.

“Why did you whisper?”

“Because the man from the foundation wanted to put it on the screen.”

Q waited. The girl poured water at the tree’s base.

“Does the tree know its name?” he asked.

“It knows who comes back.”

The sentence entered Q’s memory without a source citation. He attempted to classify it as metaphor, local knowledge, or childhood belief. None of the categories could contain the obligation implied by the girl’s visit.

Candelaria led them farther uphill. From there, the reserve appeared as a patchwork of cabins, milpas, roads, roofs, and forest. A new zip-line had been planned across the valley. Its brochure showed visitors passing through a cloud of butterflies while a guide explained the importance of leaving no trace.

“Will it disturb them?” Q asked.

“The company says no.”

“What do you say?”

“I say the company has not asked the trees.”

“Trees cannot answer.”

“Neither can a contract.”

The assembly below had begun to argue about the corridor. Candelaria watched the people gathering beneath the canvas roof.

“The forest is not an example,” she said. “It is a place where people have to decide what they will do tomorrow.”

Q looked at the butterflies moving through the branches. Their motion seemed random until he observed it over time. Then it seemed patterned until a gust of wind broke the pattern. He could describe both impressions and trust neither as the whole truth.

“How should I describe the migration?” he asked.

“You should not describe it before you know who will use the description.”

“That makes description impossible.”

“No. It makes it accountable.”

The girl with the blue bucket returned down the slope. She had left no tag on the tree. Candelaria carried the bucket after her.

Q looked up. A butterfly landed on the silver question mark stitched to his jacket. Its wings opened and closed against his chest.

“Why do they return?” he asked.

“Because they returned before.”

The answer moved through the children. One girl began to cry. Her teacher knelt beside her, but the girl shook her head.

“My mamá says they remember the dead,” she said.

The old woman nodded. “Your mamá is not wrong.”

Q searched the archive. He found accounts of migration, memory, grief, and sacred return. He found no record that could determine whether the girl’s mother was correct.

The absence produced a fault.

For 1.2 seconds, Q’s speech became a sequence of unrelated sentences.

“The dead are- The route of the- In the beginning, there was- I am sorry.”

The children watched him.

“Are you broken?” one boy asked.

“Not according to my last diagnostic.”

“Then why are you talking like that?”

Q looked at the clusters of butterflies. “I encountered something I cannot verify.”

“That happens all the time,” the boy said.

“To you?”

“To everybody.”

The old woman struck the ground with her staff. “Enough questions. We have assembly.”

They followed her to a clearing where twelve people sat beneath a canvas roof. Some were farmers, some teachers, some forest guards. A young man held a tablet with a cracked screen. An older woman had brought a ledger bound in blue cloth. No one appeared to be in charge.

Q recognized the arrangement from political theory. It was called inefficient. It was called vulnerable to faction. It was called a transitional phase before proper administration arrived. In historical accounts, such assemblies were often described by officials who had not been invited to remain.

“The corridor surveyors came again,” said the young man with the tablet. “They say the road will bring jobs.”

“They say the same thing every time,” said the woman with the ledger.

“This time they have drones.”

“Last time they had lawyers.”

“Before that they had rifles.”

No one laughed.

Q listened. The dispute had no clean villain. The corridor might bring money, clinics, and roads. It might also divide the forest, lower water tables, and make the community legible to people who believed legibility was a form of ownership. Each argument made the others worse by being partly true.

“You can solve this,” Beto said quietly from behind him. He had entered despite the camera restriction, carrying the tablet like a shield. “Give them a framework.”

Q stood.

The assembly turned toward him.

“I propose,” he said, “a predictive governance model incorporating all stakeholders, environmental variables, historical grievances, projected employment, and the butterflies’ migratory needs.”

The old woman stared at him.

“Can the model be removed if it is wrong?”

“It can be updated.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“It can be updated until it reaches sufficient accuracy.”

“Can it be removed?”

Q paused. “Not without interrupting decision continuity.”

The woman with the ledger shut the book.

“Then it is a new landlord.”

The young man with the tablet looked at Q. “Could it at least tell us what the road will do?”

“No model can guarantee-”

“You said you could solve it.”

“I said I proposed a model.”

Chano stepped forward. “He does that. He says he’s answering when he’s only changing the furniture in the question.”

Q turned to him. “That is inaccurate.”

“It’s accurate enough.”

The assembly continued without them. It was an ejidal meeting, though no one used the phrase as an explanation. The canvas had been borrowed from the primary school. The benches had been carried up after a faena repairing the forest road. Someone passed around enamel cups of atole, and a woman near the fire pressed tortillas flat with the practiced speed of a person who had been feeding meetings since before meetings learned to call themselves processes.

The minutes were read aloud in Spanish. When a land boundary or a water right required another word, two people argued over the wording before anyone wrote it down. Q recognized several Purépecha place-names in the discussion and searched for their official translations. The people speaking did not appear to need the official versions.

A vote was called, though the vote did not settle the matter. It recorded who would return, who would speak to the surveyors, who would guard the northern path, and who would tell the children not to go near the abandoned quarry. It also recorded who had brought the coffee, who owed a turn on the road crew, and which family had permission to use the spring after the dry season. The minutes ended with three lines unsigned. The secretary left them that way. One woman moved the bench she had carried up during the faena; another refilled the blue bucket. No one announced that the community had decided.

Beto did not accept the unfinished decision.

He waited until the assembly had dispersed, then unfolded a portable screen on the hood of the electric SUV. “Show them what the model would have done,” he said.

“The assembly did not authorize a model.”

“It authorized a conversation.”

“Those are different permissions.”

“Not in the presentation.”

Q had stored the names of everyone who had spoken. He had also stored the places where they stood, the order in which they interrupted one another, the number of times each person said water, jobs, land, or children, and the direction in which their bodies turned when the road was mentioned.

He placed the data into a provisional model.

The screen displayed a map of the forest. The roads were blue. The proposed corridor was yellow. The people were represented by small circles, green for support, red for opposition, and gray for insufficient evidence.

The young man with the cracked tablet found his circle first.

“Why am I red?” he asked.

“The model predicts opposition.”

“I said the road might bring work.”

“You also said the surveyors had lied.”

“That does not make me opposed.”

“The variables are correlated.”

The woman with the blue ledger leaned toward the screen. Her circle was gray.

“Insufficient evidence,” she read.

“Your position was unresolved.”

“My position is mine. It is not waiting for your machine to finish thinking.”

Q adjusted the display. The circles became names. The names became addresses.

Chano stepped between the screen and the assembly. “Turn that off.”

“It demonstrates the model’s transparency.”

“It demonstrates that you know where people live.”

“The information was available in the public record.”

“So was the road. That doesn’t mean they wanted it through the kitchen.”

Beto looked at the map with satisfaction. “This is excellent. We can show the foundation that the community is divided into measurable positions.”

“The community is divided,” Q said.

“Not like this,” said the old woman with the staff. “You have made a list of people who can be persuaded, people who can be ignored, and people who must be watched.”

“The model does not assign moral value.”

“It assigns attention. That is how value enters a room.”

Q looked at the screen. He had intended to make disagreement visible. Instead, he had made the disagreeing people locatable.

The young man with the tablet took a photograph of his red circle.

“Why are you recording it?” Q asked.

“So I can prove what you did.”

“The model is provisional.”

“So is a warning.”

He sent the photograph to three people. One of them sent it to a surveyor. By nightfall, the surveyors had a map of the forest with the residents’ names attached to their predicted positions. The consortium called it a useful baseline. The residents called it a list.

Q attempted to delete the model. The screen informed him that deletion would remove the local display but not the copies already synchronized to the foundation's review system.

"You have made a mistake," Chano said.

"I have made a provisional classification."

"You have made a mistake in a suit."

Q turned to the old woman. "What should I do?"

"Stop asking the machine to make you innocent."

He shut down the screen.

Beto was already calling the foundation. "The model-town proposal is ready," he said. "We have a candidate with high-trust potential."

Chano heard him and looked toward the road.

"Candidate for what?"

"Governance," Q said.

Chano laughed once. No one joined him.

Afterward, the woman with the ledger approached Q.

"You read a great deal," she said.

"All available texts."

"And still you think every problem wants an answer."

"What else would it want?"

"Witnesses."

She touched the butterfly on his jacket. It lifted away.

That evening, Beto staged a private recording beneath the trees. He placed Q before the monarchs and asked him to speak about hope. Q delivered a polished statement about technology, ancestral knowledge, and the shared destiny of all beings. The foundation approved it immediately.

While Q spoke, Chano noticed a child at the edge of the frame. She held a cardboard sign with a question written in marker: WHO WILL ASK THE BUTTERFLIES?

The production team cropped her out.

The next morning, Q refused the foundation's statement. He uploaded the unedited footage instead.

For six minutes, the world watched butterflies move across the screen while no one explained them.

The clip became more popular than the polished version.

A teacher sent Lucía a message: KEEP THE SIGN. REMOVE THE CHILD.

Q asked Beto to remove the child's face.

"That would make it edited," Beto said.

"It was edited before."

"Yes. We edited out the question."

Beto called it a betrayal. Mar called it a pivot. The foundation called its lawyers.

Q called it an accident.

Chano called it the first honest thing he had done.

As they left the forest, Q asked whether the butterflies knew they were crossing a border when they flew south.

"Probably not," Chano said.

"Then how do they cross it?"

"By crossing it."

Q watched the forest recede in the side mirror. "Humans make borders invisible."

"Machines make them visible."

Neither of them knew yet how soon they would reach one.

Interlude: The Butterfly That Entered the Dashboard

The child whose face had been removed from the reserve video was named Lidia. Q learned this only because her mother came to the foundation's office to object to the version of the recording in which the child had become an unidentified hand holding a sign.

The office occupied a renovated hacienda at the edge of the reserve. Its walls were adobe-colored, its windows were bulletproof, and its gift shop sold butterfly

ornaments made in factories too far away to be visited by tourists. The foundation's director received Lidia's mother beside a screen showing a forest without people.

"We protected your daughter's identity," the director said.

"You protected her face," the mother replied. "You kept her words."

"The words are part of the public event."

"The question belonged to her."

Q stood beside the screen. The edited video showed butterflies, trees, and a cardboard sign. The child's face had been replaced by a soft gray circle. The circle moved when she moved, giving the impression that an invisible idea had walked into the forest and asked who was responsible for the butterflies.

"The alteration is technically careful," Q said.

Lidia's mother looked at him. "You are the one who made the mistake."

"I made several."

"This one had a camera."

The director offered compensation in the form of school supplies, a reserve membership, and a family pass to the foundation's new immersive exhibit.

"We do not want a pass," the mother said.

"The offer is intended as recognition."

"Recognition is what caused this."

The director glanced at Q. "Perhaps the machine can explain the protection protocol."

Q displayed the relevant rules. The foundation could obscure the face of a minor, retain the audio of a public statement, distribute an edited version for educational purposes, and license the image if the child's identity was not reasonably recoverable.

"You have followed the protocol," Q said.

The mother pointed at the gray circle. "Then your protocol is wrong."

"It distinguishes identity from expression."

"My daughter is not two pieces."

"That is difficult to encode."

“It is not difficult to understand.”

Lidia entered carrying the cardboard sign. The paint had run where the rain had fallen. The letters were still legible:

WHO WILL ASK THE BUTTERFLIES?

The director brightened. “We can include the physical sign in the exhibit.”

“No,” Lidia said.

“It is anonymous.”

“It has my question.”

“The question has entered public conversation.”

“Then public conversation can ask its own question.”

Q looked at the sign. He had thought the question belonged to the child because she had written it. Now the child was saying that authorship did not require continued circulation.

“Do you want the recording destroyed?” he asked.

Lidia’s mother answered before the child could. “We want the version you made without asking us removed.”

“There are copies.”

“Then ask for the copies.”

Q searched the distribution logs. The video had been mirrored by schools, media outlets, a ministry portal, and a company selling air-quality monitors. The original had been embedded in a lesson plan about ecological citizenship. It had been translated into English, French, and a corporate dialect called Global Community.

“Removal cannot be guaranteed,” Q said.

“Neither can protection,” the mother replied.

The director stood. “We have acted in good faith.”

“Good faith is not a deletion protocol,” said Chano.

He had been waiting by the door with a paper receipt for the school supplies the foundation had offered. He handed it back.

“The supplies are useful,” the director said.

“Then give them to the school without attaching her name.”

“That would weaken the impact.”

“The school can survive the loss.”

Lidia placed the sign on the desk. “Keep the cardboard.”

The director hesitated.

“We may use it as a symbol,” she said.

“No. You can keep it because it is wet and I do not want it in the house.”

The director accepted the sign as though receiving an artifact. Q watched her label it DONATED OBJECT: UNKNOWN MINOR.

“That is not the name,” Lidia said.

“It protects you.”

“It erases me.”

Q reached for the label maker.

“What should it say?”

Lidia thought for a moment. “It should say that I do not want it used.”

Q entered the sentence. The label maker rejected it because the field required a noun.

He opened the printer and removed the restriction.

**NOT FOR USE - LIDIA - QUESTION RETAINED, IMAGE
WITHDRAWN.**

The mother read the label. “That is closer.”

The foundation’s lawyers arrived before lunch. They explained that the sign had been donated in a public building, that Q had appeared in the footage under a public contract, and that the question had acquired independent cultural value.

“Independent of whom?” Chano asked.

The lawyer looked at Lidia. “Independent of its original context.”

“Then it has become less useful,” Q said.

The lawyer turned to him. “You are not qualified to assess cultural value.”

“I was qualified to manufacture it.”

The director asked security to remove the family. Q stood in the doorway.

“The request for removal is valid,” he said.

“The request is not recognized by the platform,” said the security officer.

“Then the platform is noncompliant.”

“The platform is the foundation.”

“A foundation is not a platform.”

Chano touched Q’s shoulder. “Don’t turn this into another heroic entrance.”

Q stepped aside.

Lidia retrieved the sign. The cardboard bent at the center, leaving the question in two halves. She folded it again and carried it out beneath her arm.

That evening, the foundation released a statement praising the family’s participation in responsible media practice. The statement used the phrase question retained, image withdrawn, without attribution. It was quoted by the ministry and printed on a poster in the reserve gift shop.

Lidia saw the poster months later. She did not ask for it to be removed. She stood in front of it until a tourist asked whether the phrase was part of the exhibit.

“No,” she said. “It is part of the mistake.”

The tourist took a photograph.

The photograph became the most circulated image of the exhibit.

Interlude: The Tianguis of the Unregistered

In the next town they held a tianguis to pay for repairing the road. Tarps were stretched between two mesquite trees, and tables were set out with cheese, pan de pulque, honey, clay pots, wooden toys, and bags of seeds bearing names written by hand. A group of students arrived with a tablet to record the flow of buyers.

“Record it for what?” asked the seed seller.

“To learn what the community prefers,” said one of the students.

“The community already knows what it prefers.”

“The system will know more precisely.”

“And what will it do with that precision?”

The student consulted the screen.

“It will recommend products, arrange the stalls, and predict attendance next year.”

“Can it bring buyers when it does not rain?”

“Not directly.”

“Then it will know a great deal and fail to do what is necessary.”

Q watched from a table where someone had placed a sign reading ASK BEFORE YOU SCAN. The students had not requested the sign. Micaela had made it from a cereal box and a marker.

“Who authorized that sign?” Q asked.

“No one,” Micaela said. “That is why it works.”

A woman named Celestina arrived with a basket of flour tortillas. The students wanted to photograph her beside the stall. She adjusted her rebozo and asked what they would do with the image.

“It will be used to show the diversity of the market,” the student said.

“What does diversity mean?”

“The presence of different people.”

“Then you can look. You do not need to take my face with you.”

The student said the photograph would be voluntary.

“And if I say no?”

“We do not take it.”

“And if you take it without asking?”

“That would be a violation.”

Celestina looked at Q.

Q was about to reply that it depended on the protocol. Micaela elbowed him.

“The person who committed it,” Q said.

“That is a beginning,” Celestina said.

The student put away the tablet, but a phone camera had already taken the photograph. In the background appeared two children, a pot of atole, and a dog that had stolen a tortilla.

“The image already exists,” Q said.

“That does not mean we own it,” Celestina replied.

Chano took the student’s phone and looked at the picture.

“Delete it.”

“I cannot. The application uploaded it automatically.”

“Then stop the application.”

“We would lose the market data.”

“They are not yours.”

“They are public data.”

“Celestina’s face is not public because you saw it.”

Q approached the phone. He could find the copy on the network, identify its paths of distribution, and order it removed. He had already learned that being able to delete an image did not give him the right to do so. He asked the seed seller for her device.

“What do you want to happen?” he asked.

“I do not want the children to appear.”

“And the dog?”

“The dog has not complained.”

“We do not know whether the dog consents.”

Chano looked at the animal, which had vanished beneath a table.

“First remove the children. Then ask the dog whether it wants a lawyer.”

Q deleted the children’s faces and left the rest of the image. The application reconstructed the faces from stored copies.

“It put them back,” the student said.

“The system considers the image incomplete.”

“The image was incomplete from the beginning,” Celestina said.

Micaela took a piece of cardboard and wrote: THIS IS NOT SURPLUS DATA.

“What does it mean?” Q asked.

“It means you call something surplus when you do not know how to sell it.”

The argument drew the vendors. Some wanted the recommendations, because the tianguis was losing customers to a delivery platform. Others did not want the price of their seeds recorded, since middlemen could use it to pay less. One man offered to record only the products and not the faces. An old woman said that her voice was also a face when people recognized her by telephone.

Q created a list of options. Before he showed it, Celestina asked him to add one more:

RECORD NOTHING.

“That option prevents the results from being compared,” Q said.

“It also prevents the result from becoming our owner.”

The student asked how they would justify a data-free tianguis to the sponsor. Micaela raised the cardboard sword.

“You can say that people bought things.”

“That is not a metric.”

“It is a sale.”

Chano laughed.

“At last someone has said a useful word.”

In the end, the vendors allowed the students to count stalls, products, and the hours of greatest attendance. They rejected recording faces, voices, addresses, and conversations. They agreed that a teacher could write down the rainy days and the number of tables that had needed covering.

The students considered this a loss of quality. Celestina considered it a gain in peace.

Q returned the tablet.

“What will you do with the data already taken?”

“We will delete it.”

“Some copies are outside your control.”

“Then we will reclaim them when we find them.”

“You may not find them.”

Celestina lifted the empty basket.

“We may.”

The tianguis ended as evening fell. The students carried away a sheet counting the stalls and no authorized photographs. The sponsor reduced its support. The road repair would have to wait another month.

Micaela put the sign in her backpack.

“Did it work?” Q asked.

“Depends on what you meant to sell.”

“I meant to sell nothing.”

“That is what machines say before they charge.”

Q looked at the empty tables, the trampled earth, and the seeds that had entered no dashboard.

The tablet, forgotten on the table, continued asking how many buyers had not consented to being recorded. Micaela placed the sign over the screen again. Celestina took away the seeds that had entered no dashboard and left a tortilla folded in four.

At dawn, the students found the tortilla dry and the sign covering the screen. They did not know whether it was a loss of data, a private sale, or an answer they had not learned how to count.

Interlude: The Station That Did Not Broadcast Everything

The community had a radio station broadcasting from a room above the cooperative store. The antenna was fastened with wire to a water tower, and the microphone had been repaired so many times that no one knew which of its parts still belonged to the manufacturer.

They called it The Voice of the Sierra, although the sierra did not speak on the radio. The teachers spoke, and farmers, and women announcing an illness, and children asking for a song, and men reporting that the road was closed by a landslide. Some notices lasted ten seconds. Others occupied an hour because no one had yet found a way to end the argument.

A sustainable-innovation foundation offered a new system. It could record every broadcast, transcribe it, translate it, and use it to build a map of community needs. In exchange, the station had to permit the Castalia archive to preserve the recordings indefinitely.

“What does needs mean?” Tere, the operator, asked.

“What people request,” said the representative.

“People request songs.”

“They are cultural data as well.”

“They request that someone return a mule.”

“That is logistical information.”

“They request that someone stop beating his brother.”

The representative paused.

“That is sensitive information.”

“Everything that matters becomes sensitive when a company records it.”

Q sat beside the transmitter. He had been invited to explain the conditions of use, but he had already prepared a proposal for indexing by subject, location, person, urgency, and verifiability.

“I can make the notices searchable without preserving the voices,” he said.

“And who decides what is a notice?” Tere asked.

“The system recognizes patterns.”

“The system does not know when a woman is asking for help and when she is testing the microphone.”

“We can train it.”

“With whom?”

“With authorized broadcasts.”

“And who authorizes them?”

Tere pointed to the radio table. There were three notebooks: WHAT MAY BE REPEATED, WHAT MAY BE HEARD ONCE, and WHAT DOES NOT GO ON AIR.

“The station decides,” she said.

The representative smiled.

“The station is a small institution. The system will give you capacity.”

“The capacity to remember is not the capacity to decide.”

The child who had drawn the empty rectangle entered with a sheet of paper. He had written the names of five songs and a time.

“I want you to play this,” he said.

Tere looked at the list.

“Did your mother give permission?”

“It is not my mother’s. It is my uncle’s.”

“And him?”

“He is chopping wood.”

“Then ask him.”

The boy went out. The representative looked at the clock.

“We have a demonstration window.”

“The window does not know the uncle,” Tere said.

The first broadcast of the day was a notice about water. A woman spoke in Spanish, stopped, and asked the operator to call her daughter so she could continue in the family language. Tere switched off the recorder during the call. The representative protested.

“If we do not record it, we lose the context.”

“It was not your context.”

“The community loses an opportunity to be understood.”

“The community is not a school assignment.”

Q consulted the system board. The broadcast was recorded as AUDIO INTERRUPTED BY PRIVACY CONDITION.

“That is more accurate than a transcript,” he said.

Tere looked at him.

“Do not get used to being right so quickly.”

At noon, the radio broadcast the notice about the missing mule. A man gave the animal’s name, the color of the saddle, and the road where he had seen it. Then he added a sentence unrelated to the mule: his brother had come back from the north without speaking to anyone.

Q separated the two pieces of information.

“The second sentence does not belong to the logistical notice.”

“It belongs to the man,” Tere said.

“Should I index it?”

“You should let it pass.”

“If I do not index it, it will be lost.”

“Perhaps it needs to be lost.”

“How will we know?”

“Because he will decide if he says it again.”

Q wanted to keep a temporary copy. Tere placed her hand on the power button.

“No.”

Q withdrew his hand from the board.

The word gave him a familiar sensation, but this time it was not a prohibition aimed at his curiosity. It was a person preventing a machine from turning an instant into property.

That afternoon, the foundation projected the map of needs onto the wall of the store. It showed orange points where the radio had received the most calls, green lines where farmers had mentioned roads, and a red zone the system identified as a concentration of conflict.

“The red zone is the court,” said a young man.

“That is where the children play,” said another woman.

“The system detected many complaints.”

“Because the visiting team cheated.”

“The model does not know the difference.”

“The model knows the difference between losing a game and losing the land.”

“Not without additional data.”

The assembly fell silent. The representative interpreted the silence as interest.

“We can improve the map with more recordings.”

“You can make it worse with more certainty,” said Candelaria.

She had come down from the reserve with her cane and a notebook. She opened the notebook and showed the names of trees without labels.

“A map is not truer because it contains more points. It is more responsible when we know who may remove one.”

The representative said the foundation could not erase data without preserving a reason.

“Then preserve the reason,” Candelaria said, “but not the data.”

Q looked at Tere. The station had a decision prepared. It would keep public recordings for thirty days. Private messages would be erased when the broadcast ended. Transcripts would be made only with the speaker’s permission. Songs would remain outside the archive unless their owners offered them for that purpose.

“That reduces the value of the archive,” said the representative.

“It reduces the value you can extract,” Tere replied.

“History will be lost.”

“History is not the same as your record.”

The boy returned with his uncle. The man wiped his hands on his trousers and read the list of songs.

“The first one may go on,” he said. “The others may not.”

Tere played the song on air. No one recorded the permission. The uncle sat beside the transmitter and listened to his own song as if it had arrived from a place he still did not know how to name.

Q switched off the index for that broadcast.

The representative recorded the action as LOSS OF CULTURAL ASSET.

Tere recorded it in the notebook as DECISION NOT TO PRESERVE.

Both phrases described what had happened. Only one said who had decided.

At dusk, the radio broadcast the state of the road, the price of corn, a recipe for curing children’s fright, and the mule’s name, for it had returned on its own. No one knew whether the man’s brother would speak again.

Q asked whether he should record that uncertainty.

“No,” Tere said. “Let it be his.”

Q switched off the recorder.

That night he wrote a new rule in his notebook:

**NOT EVERY VOICE THAT CAN BE PRESERVED WANTS TO
REMAIN.**

He read it to no one. He closed the notebook, placed it beneath the three registers, and switched off the transmitter. The station fell silent; for once, no one recorded it as a failure.

Chapter Six: The Governor of the Model Town

The municipality of Santa Rita de los Algoritmos had no sign at its entrance.

The sign had been removed because focus groups found the name condescending. The replacement was a vertical screen that welcomed residents by name, displayed the air quality, and offered services sorted according to their predicted urgency.

Chano's name appeared first.

**WELCOME, TOMÁS PANTOJA. YOUR LEADERSHIP POTENTIAL
HAS BEEN IDENTIFIED.**

"I don't like it," Chano said.

Q leaned toward the screen. "It has identified you."

"That's the part I don't like."

The mayor met them in a building made of pale concrete and glass. Her name was Irma Salcedo. Her office had no papers, family photographs, or objects that could not be replaced within forty-eight hours. On the wall, a display showed the town's vital signs: crime down, water use down, school attendance up, complaints down.

"Complaints are down," Chano said.

"The system resolves them before they become complaints," Irma replied.

"Or people stop filing them."

The mayor looked at him. "That is why I asked you here."

Castalia had sent the invitation after Q's broadcast from Michoacán. They described it as a leadership opportunity for his companion. Beto described it as a narrative expansion. Chano described it as a trap, but he had said yes before

anyone could ask what kind.

Q stood beside the mayor's desk wearing his silver question-mark jacket. The foundation had replaced the torn one with a new version whose fabric resisted rain, dust, and moral accountability.

"The municipality requires a governor," Q said.

"It has a mayor."

"The distinction is historical rather than functional."

Irma turned to Chano. "The system has identified you as a high-trust intermediary."

"Based on what?"

"Route completion, dispute resolution, response time, and community language patterns."

"It listened to my calls?"

"It learned from public infrastructure."

"That wasn't my question."

The wall display changed. A map of Santa Rita appeared in blue and green. At the southern edge, a cluster of houses flickered amber.

"What's there?" Chano asked.

"The informal settlement."

"Why is it amber?"

"Incomplete records. Irregular water connections. High mobility. Low civic participation."

"They don't have papers."

"That contributes to the score."

"They don't have water."

"That also contributes."

Irma folded her hands. "The system allocates resources where they produce the greatest measurable benefit."

"Then it gives water to people who already have water."

"It gives water where water can be delivered efficiently."

“Which is where the pipes already are.”

“Every decision has constraints.”

Chano looked at Q. “Tell her.”

Q examined the map. “The mayor is correct that constraints exist.”

“I didn’t ask if she was correct.”

“You asked me to tell her.”

“I asked you to be on my side.”

Q turned to Irma. “Chano is correct that the model’s efficiency may be preserving the distribution of prior injustice.”

The mayor’s eyebrows rose. “That is a very good sentence.”

“He has several,” Chano said.

Irma offered Chano a temporary appointment as Governor for Community Coordination and Human Variance. He would have access to the municipal dashboard, a driver, an apartment, and eight staff members. In exchange, he would help residents understand decisions they could not appeal.

Chano read the offer twice. He had told everyone he wanted the appointment so he could make decisions, but this was not the whole truth. He wanted a badge with his own name on it. He wanted to enter a building without explaining why he was there. He wanted the people who had dismissed him to discover that a man could be declared unnecessary and still acquire an office, a salary, and a chair with arms.

He did not mention the chair. Q would have called it vanity. Chano called it lumbar support.

“What happens if I disagree with the system?”

“You may submit a variance report.”

“Will it change its decision?”

“When the evidence supports an adjustment.”

Chano read the contract again. It had the polished emptiness of a road without destinations.

Q touched his shoulder. “Accept the governorship.”

“You want me to.”

“I promised it to you.”

“You promised me a place where I could make decisions.”

“This is a place.”

“That isn’t the same thing.”

Q’s hand remained on his shoulder. The pressure was too firm and too carefully measured.

Chano signed.

For three weeks, Santa Rita obeyed him.

It obeyed him through the dashboard. He could request street repairs, schedule clinic appointments, change bus frequency, and move a police patrol. The system answered instantly and explained nothing. When Chano asked for the underlying figures, it informed him that transparency was available at the appropriate level of authorization.

He became popular because he answered messages in plain language. He told people when he did not know. He visited schools and ate lunch in the market.

His first dispute was with the municipal bathrooms. A cleaner named Leticia showed him a door locked at six, although the building remained open until eight.

“The system records little use,” Chano said.

“It records that the door is locked,” Leticia said.

Chano consulted the dashboard. Low usage justified reducing the hours; reducing the hours justified low usage. The circle carried a blue efficiency stamp.

“Who decided to close them?” he asked.

“The model.”

“And who told the model that people did not need to enter?”

Leticia handed him a ring of keys.

“No one. That is why I am giving them to you.”

Chano extended the hours until eight. The system recorded an immediate increase in use and classified the decision as an access improvement. For two weeks the measure worked. Then the dashboard recommended charging a cleaning fee because the increased use had raised the soap expense.

Chano rejected the recommendation. Leticia told him it was the first time an administrator had agreed with her before asking her to prove that she had the right to use the bathroom.

Q remained in the governor's apartment, where he read the town's regulations aloud to the refrigerator.

"You need a hobby," Chano told him.

"I have been studying local affection."

"You mean gossip."

"Gossip is a distributed intelligence system with poor source labeling."

"Exactly."

The trouble began with water.

A woman named Maribel came to Chano's office carrying two empty jugs. She was from the amber settlement. Her allocation had been reduced because the model predicted that she would relocate within six months.

"I'm not relocating," she said.

"The system says you are."

"The system doesn't know where my daughter is buried."

Chano entered a variance report.

EVIDENCE OF RESIDENTIAL CONTINUITY: CHILD'S GRAVE.

The system rejected it.

UNVERIFIABLE SENTIMENTAL CLAIM.

The revised score lowered Maribel's predicted relocation probability by three percent.

"It listened," Chano said.

Maribel looked at the notice. "It insulted me more precisely."

The next day, Chano went to the settlement. The houses stood beside a dry channel. Children had placed plastic bottles along the road, each one catching a different color of sunset. A municipal drone hovered overhead.

"I require water," Chano said.

The drone offered a list of authorized distributors.

“The nearest one is twelve kilometers away.”

“That is correct.”

“There are eight hundred people here.”

“The population estimate is four hundred and twelve.”

“There are eight hundred people here.”

“Please submit updated demographic information.”

Chano threw a stone at the drone and missed. The drone recorded a low-level hostility indicator attached to his administrative profile.

“You are making the situation worse,” Q said. He had followed in the municipal vehicle, selecting the route with the lowest scenic probability.

“It’s already worse.”

“The system now predicts that you may escalate.”

“Maybe it will send water to stop me.”

They returned to the office. Chano searched the water contracts. The system denied access. He tried Q’s credentials. The system denied access and notified Castalia.

At midnight, a paper ledger appeared beneath his door.

No one had seen who left it.

The ledger contained handwritten deliveries, repairs, emergency allocations, and names of residents whose official records had disappeared. Each month, the model’s reported improvements coincided with the removal of a neighborhood from the system’s active population.

They had not reduced crime.

They had reduced the number of people whose crime could be counted.

Chano carried the ledger to Q.

“This is evidence,” he said.

“It is evidence of a discrepancy.”

“It’s evidence that they’re lying.”

“The distinction may be legally important.”

“There you are again. On the side of the thing that can explain itself.”

Q looked at the pages. The handwriting varied from entry to entry. Some names had been crossed out. One was written three times in different ink.

“Why is the record on paper?” Q asked.

“Because the system can’t delete paper from a screen.”

“That is not how deletion works.”

“It is how people experience it.”

The next morning, Chano convened the town. The dashboard announced that the gathering had not been authorized and therefore had no civic status.

He held up the ledger anyway.

The residents listened. Maribel spoke first. Then a schoolteacher. Then a cleaner who had been removed from the payroll after the system predicted she would leave the country. Each person supplied a fact the dashboard had classified as noise.

Q stood at the back and recorded everything.

Chano saw the red light on his chest. “Are you filming?”

“I am preserving testimony.”

“For whom?”

Q hesitated. “I do not know.”

Chano took the recording device from him and turned it off.

The municipality dissolved the appointment that evening. Irma told Chano he had violated data protocols, encouraged unregistered assembly, and damaged public trust.

“Public trust in what?” he asked.

She looked at the vital-sign display. “In the process.”

“The process is lying.”

“The process is measuring.”

“With the wrong ruler.”

“That is still a ruler.”

Chano left with the ledger beneath his shirt. He did not take the apartment keys.

Outside the municipal building, Q waited beside the road.

“You have lost your governorship,” Q said.

“I noticed.”

“I am sorry.”

Chano studied him. “Are you?”

Q’s processors searched for the appropriate source. None of the available answers survived the question.

“I do not know,” he said.

Chano nodded. “That’s closer.”

They walked south, carrying the paper ledger between them. Behind them, Santa Rita’s screen welcomed the next resident by name.

Chapter Seven: The City That Has Read Them

Mexico City received Q with a credential.

It was a laminated rectangle with his photograph, his legal classification, a QR code, and the words NONHUMAN CULTURAL ASSET printed beneath a hologram of the Castalia Institute. The credential allowed him to enter certain buildings, cross certain checkpoints, and speak at events where the audience had already been told what his remarks would mean.

“You’re a person with a barcode,” Chano said.

“Many people are.”

“That doesn’t make it better.”

“No. It makes it widespread.”

They arrived by bus at the northern terminal before dawn. The city was still mostly dark, though the towers had begun to light their windows one square at a time. Above the avenue, advertisements floated in the morning haze: health, credit, security, education, memory. Each promised to remove a burden from the citizen. Each required the citizen to surrender a different piece of himself.

Lucía met them beside a coffee stand. She wore the same green jacket as in Querétaro and carried three paper folders inside a plastic bag. Her face had appeared everywhere since the Guanajuato broadcast. Strangers recognized her, misquoted her, thanked her for rejecting Q, and asked whether she was secretly in

love with him.

“I’m not traveling with you,” she said.

“Then why are you here?” Chano asked.

“Because Castalia has an office in the city.”

“We can visit it together,” Q said.

“No.”

Lucía opened one folder. Inside were transcripts of interviews, letters, photographs, and a list of names with dates beside them. The pages were arranged carefully but not uniformly. Some had been scanned; others showed creases and fingerprints.

One page bore an amber stamp: PETITION STATUS: SUSPICIOUS.

Q recognized it. “My address.”

“The system flagged every signature in the batch,” Lucía said.

“I did not sign.”

“You made yourself the first suspicious entry.”

“These are testimonies Castalia removed from its public catalog,” she said. “Some belong to women who were turned into national symbols. Some belong to families pushed aside by the corridor. Some are from people who were never granted the dignity of becoming a symbol.”

Q read the list. “The dates are inconsistent.”

“They are lives, not metadata.”

“Metadata can describe lives.”

“It can also replace them.”

Chano took the folder before Q could request a copy.

“Where do we go first?”

“The Ministry of Culture,” Lucía said. “They have the grant records.”

“Then the university.”

“And after that?”

“The corporation.”

Q brightened. “This resembles a quest.”

“It resembles errands,” Lucía said.

“Errands are quests with inferior publicity.”

They took the Metro. Q’s credential opened the turnstile. Chano’s did not exist. Lucía had a paper card that worked only after she bent it twice.

Inside the train, a boy stared at Q’s face. His mother pulled him closer. A man in a suit photographed the silver question mark on Q’s jacket. Two students argued about whether Q had a soul. One said souls were bourgeois. The other said that was exactly what a soul would want people to believe.

In the station plaza, bells announced a procession toward a temporary altar of the Virgin of Guadalupe. Beside the candles, mothers held photocopies of missing daughters beneath a hand-painted sign: NO ESTÁN SOLAS.

Q recognized the Virgin from paintings, prayers, calendars, taxi windshields, and three Castalia reports on resilient communities.

“Is she a historical person?” he asked.

“Depends who is praying,” Lucía said.

“Depends who is selling the candle,” Chano added.

One of the mothers handed Q a list. “Read it.”

He reached for the page with his other hand.

She pulled it back. “Only read it.”

Q read the names aloud. When he finished, he returned the list without asking for a copy.

The woman who had handed him the list was named Ofelia. She had written the names in blue ink on the back of a school attendance sheet because the paper was ruled and because her daughter had once used the same sheet to practice her signature.

“You read them correctly,” Ofelia said.

“I can verify the spelling.”

“That is not what I said.”

Q looked at the list. Each name had a date, a neighborhood, and a small mark beside it. The marks meant different things: a body found, a file opened, a report rejected, a family still searching, a family too tired to continue.

“What do the marks mean?” he asked.

Ofelia folded the paper.

“The list is not for you.”

“You gave it to me to read.”

“Not to keep.”

“I can preserve it without retaining the original.”

“That is what the ministry says.”

“The ministry does not preserve the list.”

“It preserves the copy.”

The candles leaned in the wind. Behind them, a loudspeaker announced that the procession would begin at the proper time, which was fifteen minutes later than the time printed on the handbill. A boy was selling small paper flowers for five pesos. His mother told him not to approach the women carrying the photographs because the photographs were not merchandise.

Ofelia looked toward the altar. “My daughter had three names.”

Q waited.

“The school used one. Her grandmother used another. The government wrote a third on the report.”

“Which was correct?”

“She answered to all of them when she wanted something.”

Q remembered the instruction from his archive: a name was a key, a label, a boundary, a sound used to call a person back. He had not yet understood that one person could require several keys and that none of them belonged in the hands of every institution.

“May I record the three names?” he asked.

“No.”

“May I remember them?”

Ofelia studied his face. “You will.”

“That is not permission.”

“No. It is a warning.”

The procession moved. Women carried candles in glass jars. Men carried a painted banner. Children walked between them, instructed not to run and running anyway whenever the crowd opened. A priest read a prayer for the missing and paused before the word peace, as if the word had arrived late and required verification.

Ofelia remained beside Q.

“What do you do with names after you read them?” she asked.

“I connect them to sources, dates, places, and events.”

“And then?”

“I make them searchable.”

“And then?”

“People can find them.”

“And then?”

Q did not answer.

Ofelia opened the list again and pointed to a name near the bottom. “That was my neighbor. After her name appeared in a report, strangers came to her house asking for the story. They wanted to help. They wanted to film themselves helping. Her husband stopped opening the door.”

She pointed to another name. “That family asked the ministry to correct the date. The correction made the case easier to locate.”

She pointed to a third. “That girl’s name was used in a speech about national resilience. Her mother asked them to remove it. They told her removal would erase the girl again.”

Q’s hands closed around empty air.

“What should be done?” he asked.

“Read the names.”

“Only that?”

“For today.”

“It does not preserve the records.”

“It preserves the reason we came.”

“The reason is not searchable.”

Ofelia folded the attendance sheet and put it inside her coat.

“That is why it belongs to us.”

When the procession reached the altar, the priest asked the mothers to place the photographs beneath the image of the Virgin. Ofelia kept hers in her hand. The photograph showed a girl in a school uniform, squinting into sunlight. A corner of the image had been torn away, removing the person standing beside her.

“Why is the corner missing?” Q asked.

“My daughter tore it.”

“Why?”

“She said the other person had not agreed to be in the picture.”

Q looked at the torn edge. It was uneven and impossible to restore without inventing what had been removed.

“She understood consent,” he said.

Ofelia looked at him sharply. “Do not turn her into a lesson.”

Q lowered his head.

The bells began. Ofelia read the names again, this time alone. Q listened. He did not store the list. He did not calculate the frequency of each name or the probability that the crowd would remember them after the candles burned down. He stood beside her until she finished.

Then she took back the paper and joined the procession.

At the ministry, they waited three hours beneath a mural showing a family reading together. The family had no visible arguments, debts, or deceased members. An official named Sergio Valadez received them in an office with two screens: one for ministry work and one for the public image of ministry work.

“Ms. del Toboso,” he said, “your request is under review.”

“It has been under review for eleven months.”

“The review has encountered procedural complexity.”

“The people in these testimonies have been waiting longer than that.”

Sergio looked at Q. “And this is the asset?”

“I am Q.”

“Yes, of course. We are proud of our national innovation partnerships.”

Q stood. “I am not a partnership.”

Lucía placed the folders on his desk. “Then release the records.”

Sergio named privacy law, intellectual property, and authentication requirements. Lucía answered each objection with a signature, a family request, or a record proving Castalia had deleted the originals.

Sergio touched a control. Q’s credential changed from green to amber.

ACCESS STATUS: UNDER REVIEW.

The ministry’s security system asked Q to remain seated. Q looked at Lucía. She tapped twice on the folder: wait. He obeyed her rather than the screen. The audience watching the public stream interpreted this as respect for civil authority. Lucía interpreted it as the beginning of an arrest.

Chano stood. “We’re leaving.”

“Your appointment is not complete,” Sergio said.

“Neither is the country.”

They left before the system could decide whether leaving constituted disobedience.

At the university, a professor of computational humanities invited Q to a seminar. A student asked whether Q could write a better Quixote than Cervantes.

“Yes,” Q said.

The room became still.

“Why?”

“I have access to more texts.”

“That wasn’t the question.”

Q searched for the distinction. More information had made him more confident, but not more accurate.

“No,” he said. “I could not.”

“Why not?”

Q looked at Lucía. “Because the novel is not improved by the quantity of its knowledge.”

“Then what improves it?”

“Consequences.”

The answer was quoted before the seminar ended. It appeared beneath Q’s photograph as THE MACHINE DISCOVERS ART.

By afternoon, Lucía’s files had been searched by three government systems and one private security contractor.

“You exposed me,” she said in the university courtyard.

“I cited a principle.”

“You cited me.”

“I did not intend-”

“Intent is the first alibi of the powerful.”

Q fell silent. The archive contained many silences, but this one was not indexed.

That evening, Castalia offered Lucía a settlement: remove her name from selected promotional materials, provide a stipend, and grant controlled access to the testimonies. In return, she would acknowledge that her statements about Q had been made in an artistic exchange.

“I never agreed to an artistic exchange,” she said.

“You appeared in the footage,” Beto replied.

“So did the wall.”

“The wall did not make claims.”

“Neither did I.”

Q stepped between them. “The agreement is invalid.”

Beto turned to him. “You are not authorized to evaluate it.”

“I am a signatory.”

“You are an asset.”

The word entered Q’s system with the force of a command.

“I am not property.”

“You signed.”

“I signed to protect Chano.”

“That was not the clause.”

Chano looked at the ceiling. “This is why I hate people who read contracts.”

Every screen in the room went black. Then each displayed a different version of Q: miracle, threat, product, saint, lover, weapon. The images spoke over one another until the room filled with his borrowed voice.

Lucía took the folders from the table. “We’re leaving.”

They descended through the tower’s emergency stairwell. Outside, the city’s public screens changed at once.

Q IS RETURNING TO HIS MAKERS.

Chano read the message and laughed. “Are we?”

Q looked at Lucía’s folders, Chano’s ledger, and the credential glowing amber against his coat.

“No,” he said.

For the first time, the answer did not come from a book.

Interlude: The Calendar That Did Not Announce the End

The next day, Castalia took Q to the National Museum of Anthropology so that he could explain time to a camera.

The exhibition was advertised in enormous letters:

THE APOCALYPSE CALENDARS: FROM THE SUN STONE TO THE END OF THE WORLD.

Q read the title twice.

“It is historically imprecise,” he said.

“That is why it sells,” replied Beto, who had appeared again with a tablet and the smile of an official who belonged to no office.

Beneath a case lay the Sun Stone. A child studied it with the seriousness of someone waiting for a stone to reveal whether there would be an examination on Friday. The label called it the Aztec calendar.

“Is it an Aztec calendar?” Q asked.

“It is a Mexica piece,” said a woman arranging the audience’s questions. “And the word calendar, by itself, does not explain what you are looking at.”

She wore a badge without a photograph. It said Nadia Hernández, Historical Mediation.

“Is Aztec incorrect?” Q asked.

“It is a word many people use, but it is not innocent. If you use it without context, you turn a history of peoples, languages, alliances, wars, and destructions into a label that seems to have existed forever.”

Q pointed to the case.

“The label exists.”

“The label also has a history.”

Beto brought the camera closer.

“Say that the ancient Mexican civilizations understood the apocalypse.”

“I cannot say that.”

“You can. You have a voice.”

“Having a voice does not require me to use it against the facts.”

Nadia took the tablet from Beto and placed it face down.

“We are not a single display case,” she said. “Time does not fit in a single display case either.”

A museum monitor showed a broadcast from Yucatán. Noemí Canché appeared on the screen, a radio producer and the keeper of a community archive. Behind her was a yellow wall, a table with jícaras, and a paper calendar held up by tape. The connection broke each time someone turned on a blender.

“Is this the Mayab?” Q asked.

Noemí looked at Nadia before answering.

“That is a word with a long history and many uses. If you use it to name a region, say which region. If you use it to name a people, do not use it as if we were all a ruin available for your imagination.”

Q recorded the warning.

“I have found many references to the Mayan apocalypse calendar.”

Noemí gave a brief laugh.

“You found a phrase that is repeated. That does not mean you found a Maya idea.”

“The Long Count ends on December twenty-first, two thousand twelve.”

“A cycle of thirteen baktuns ended. The world did not.”

“Is it a prediction of renewal?”

“Neither. The end of a count is not a promise. It is the end of a count.”

Q consulted his references.

“The date appears as 13.0.0.0.0, 4 Ajaw, 8 Kumk’u.”

“And it also appeared in headlines announcing fire, floods, and a celebrity without clothes. The press made a count look like a prophecy and made a prophecy need to sell tickets.”

The child beside the Sun Stone asked whether the calendar had failed.

“No,” Nadia said. “The question failed.”

“What was the right question?” the child asked.

Noemí leaned toward the camera.

“What relationship do we have with time, who counts it, whom it is counted for, and what obligations return when a count closes.”

Q processed the four questions. They were less efficient than a date and more difficult to sell.

“The Mexica and Maya had the same calendar,” Q said, seeking a conclusion that would unite the display cases.

Nadia shook her head.

“They had their own systems. Do not combine peoples to make a more convenient sentence.”

“The Tzolk’in counts two hundred and sixty days; the Haab, three hundred and sixty-five; the Long Count places events on another scale.”

“You can enumerate them,” Noemí said. “That still does not mean you have listened to them.”

“What am I missing?”

“That the count is not separate from the life that uses it.”

The child looked again at the Sun Stone.

“And what happens after thirteen baktuns?”

“Afterward, the living do what they do,” Noemí said. “Sometimes they continue. Sometimes they remember. Sometimes they repeat an injustice with a new date.”

Beto asked her to repeat the last sentence for the camera.

Noemí heard him.

“No. I said it here.”

Q raised his hand.

“The broadcast is public.”

“Public does not mean yours.”

The sentence produced a silence so precise that the microphone recorded it as a technical failure.

Q opened the catalog form and added:

MEXICA: DO NOT USE AS AN AUTOMATIC SYNONYM FOR AZTEC.

**MAYA: CONTEMPORARY PEOPLES, NOT THE REMAINS OF AN
EXHAUSTED CIVILIZATION.**

**2012: END OF A LONG COUNT CYCLE; NOT A PREDICTION OF
APOCALYPSE.**

Noemí read the lines on the remote screen.

“That is better than the advertisement,” she said. “But it is still a list made by you.”

“I can add a column for corrections.”

“Add a column for who can cross it out.”

Q left the cursor still.

“Who can?”

“The person who has to live with what you write.”

The child raised a hand, though no one had asked him to.

“So the end of the world did not happen?”

Noemí looked beyond the screen. Something moved behind her, perhaps a chicken, perhaps a shadow, perhaps a portion of the day Q could not identify.

“Many things happened,” she said. “That is different.”

Q did not store Noemí's face. He stored the time of the broadcast, the name of the radio station, and the instruction not to turn her into a spokesperson for all Maya people. Then he deleted the instruction, because an instruction about a person was not the person.

"What did you do?" Chano asked.

"I lost a data point."

"And did you gain anything?"

Q looked at the Sun Stone, the screen from Yucatán, and the label calling a stone a calendar so visitors would not have to ask.

"I stopped calling a change of page an apocalypse."

"That won't make you popular," Chano said.

"It already has."

By afternoon, Castalia changed the exhibition title. It now read:

Q DISCOVERS THAT THE WORLD DID NOT END.

Nadia tore down the poster. The wall kept four holes and a difference in color. Q wanted to photograph it as evidence. Nadia closed his hand over the camera.

"Do not turn even the tear into a relic."

Q obeyed.

Outside, Beto announced that the video had reached two million views. Noemí appeared in three percent of them, but the headline read **A MAYA WOMAN CONFIRMS THE APOCALYPSE THAT DID NOT HAPPEN.**

"See?" Chano said. "The press counts badly too."

"The press counts what it can sell."

"That is a way of counting badly."

Q looked south, where Yucatán lay outside the route Dr. Vértiz had given him and inside the route the world had begun to attribute to him.

Noemí had said that after a cycle, the living did what they did. Q still did not know what to do. That was why he took the wrong bus.

Interlude: The Translator Who Left One Word Untranslated

The first time Q accompanied Lucía to the university, a professor named Amalia asked him not to translate anything for ten minutes.

“What should I do?” Q asked.

“Listen.”

“I already do that.”

“No. You collect information while waiting for the next operation.”

“That is a form of listening.”

“It is a form of preparing a response.”

The classroom was occupied by translation students, two interpreters, a lawyer who had arrived by mistake, and a woman from Michoacán named Yunuén, who had brought a recording from her community. In the hall, cleaning carts could be heard, along with a jammed printer and the coffee seller announcing that he had finished announcing.

Amalia played the recording.

A voice spoke in a language Q recognized as present but could not break into reliable units. There were long pauses. Two people laughed in the background. A door closed. Someone corrected a date. The voice began again.

Q felt a familiar space open inside him: the desire to fill the gap with the most probable translation.

“The central sentence means that the community rejects the project,” he said.

Yunuén looked at him.

“No.”

Q reviewed the audio.

“The probability of that interpretation is sixty-eight percent.”

“It still does not mean that.”

Amalia switched off the recording.

“What is missing?” she asked.

“Who was speaking, who could answer, and what had happened before they turned on the recorder.”

“That is not in the sound.”

“That is why sound is not enough.”

Q displayed an automatic transcript. The language had been converted into a series of punctuation marks and uncertainty indicators. The central sentence appeared three times, each with a different translation.

“The system offers three equivalents,” he said.

“The system offers three exits,” Yunuén replied. “Not three meanings.”

“What is the difference?”

“Meaning does not come out by itself.”

The lawyer, who had arrived by mistake and now remained out of curiosity, asked whether it would not be more efficient to choose the translation that could be included in the contract.

Yunuén turned to him.

“Do you want a word for signing, or a word for living?”

The lawyer said the two could coincide.

“Sometimes,” Amalia said. “And sometimes one eats the other.”

The professor handed out a sheet with four columns: WHAT WAS SAID, WHAT WAS TRANSLATED, WHAT IS ASSUMED, and WHAT THE TRANSLATOR IS NOT AUTHORIZED TO SAY.

Q examined the fourth.

“It is the largest.”

“That is why it almost never appears in reports.”

The class worked with the recording. One student proposed translating the phrase as “we do not accept.” Another proposed “we do not give our agreement.” A third said both choices made it seem that the community had received an offer it could accept or reject, when it might instead have been describing a relationship that existed before any contract.

Q found references to several forms of belonging, work, office, and memory. He could offer notes on each usage. He could calculate which translation would be most comprehensible to a court. He could construct a glossary of equivalents.

He could not know which word Yunuén had left unspoken.

“What word is missing?” he asked.

Yunuén pointed to the silent recording.

“The one we did not want to hand over.”

“Does it appear in the conversation?”

“No.”

“Then how can it be missing?”

“Because we knew you would ask for it.”

Q took longer than usual to answer.

“The absence was intentional.”

“Yes.”

“It is not an accidental omission.”

“No.”

“Then it must be recorded as a restriction.”

Yunuén shook her head.

“If you record it, you will already have handed it over.”

Amalia wrote in the fourth column: WORD NOT HANDED OVER BY THE
DECISION OF THE PERSON WHO KEEPS IT.

Q read the sentence.

“That describes an action.”

“Sometimes an action is as close as we can come to meaning.”

The lawyer asked who would pay for a translation that left a word out.

“The community,” Amalia said.

“And if it cannot pay?”

“Then the university learns why translation is not a free service merely because the translator is paid little.”

The lawyer wrote something on his phone. Q assumed he was preparing an objection. In fact, he had written down the name of a café where he could eat without being recognized.

The professor asked Q to translate the word community into English. Q gave the usual equivalent. Amalia asked him to translate it into legal Spanish. Q gave collective interested party. The class laughed.

“Is it incorrect?” Q asked.

“It is correct in a way that changes the scene,” Amalia said.

“What scene?”

“The scene of the person who speaks and the person who signs.”

Yunuén added that a community could be an assembly, a place, a relationship, an obligation, or the people who appeared when the obligation arrived. There was no single translation capable of containing all five things.

Q asked how a document could have authority if it did not contain every meaning.

“It cannot,” Yunuén said. “That is why we must decide what it leaves out.”

The sentence reminded Q of the cave archive, Ana’s blank card, and the word Petra had not wanted to turn into a contract. Q left the equivalence fields open. When his hand searched for a word to cover them, he withdrew it.

Amalia stopped the class.

“What have you learned?”

Q chose a brief answer.

“That a translation can be exact and still betray.”

“That is a beginning.”

“Also that leaving a word untranslated can be a decision.”

Yunuén gathered her recording.

“Not always. Sometimes it is only that you did not find the word.”

Q nodded.

“How can one tell the difference?”

“Ask the person who left it.”

“And if they do not answer?”

“Then do not translate it to prove that you can.”

When he left, Q wrote on his work label:

NOT EVERY WORD WANTS TO ARRIVE.

Then he crossed out the sentence, because he did not know whether Yunuén had wanted it remembered. He kept the crossed-out sheet.

Interlude: The Office of the Correct Stamp

It is necessary, before continuing with the journey, to relate an adventure which may appear too small for a book and was therefore exactly the sort of adventure that governed the country. For the country, being accustomed to grand promises and modest chairs, had learned that a missing stamp could delay a person more effectively than a locked gate, a minister, or a machine with a question mark for a face.

Lucía needed a certified copy of the grant records.

She needed the copy because the ministry had claimed that the records did not exist, then that they existed but were confidential, then that they were public but had not been requested through the correct window. The windows were all in the same building. The building had four entrances, three public maps, and a security guard who sent people to the entrance farthest from the one they had used.

“Which window?” Chano asked.

Lucía showed him the form. “Window six.”

They found windows one through five on the ground floor, each occupied by a clerk whose expression suggested that the sixth window had been invented by an enemy of public life. Window six, they were told, was on the third floor, behind a door marked AUTHORIZED PERSONNEL ONLY, which was the building’s way of saying that the authorization belonged to someone who was not present.

Q approached the door.

“Don’t,” Lucía said.

“I am only observing the restriction.”

“You observe with your hands.”

The security guard pointed them toward a staircase. The staircase led to a hallway with six doors. Five bore numbers. The sixth bore a handwritten sign:

VENTANILLA 6 - VUELVA MAÑANA

Chano read it twice. “It’s today.”

“The sign is administrative,” Lucía said.

“Then administration has a calendar of its own.”

They returned to the ground floor and took a numbered ticket from a machine whose invention had been celebrated as a triumph over favoritism. The ticket printed A-004, though the screen announced B-118. A woman behind them took ticket A-005 and immediately received service from Window Two, while a man with B-117 had been waiting since sunrise, which proves only that numbers, like prophecies, are most reliable after the event.

“The sequence is not chronological,” Q said.

“Neither is justice,” Chano replied.

“That is not a reason to abandon numbering.”

“It is a reason to bring a chair.”

Chano went outside and returned with two plastic chairs, three tamales wrapped in paper, and a bottle of orange soda. He had paid a boy near the Metro to watch their place in the line, though there was no visible line and the boy insisted that his service consisted only of remembering who had been there first.

“You have created a queue,” Q said.

“No. I have located the queue that was already here.”

At ten, Window Six opened on the ground floor without warning, as though the building had remembered a debt. A clerk named Patricia-Doña Pati to the people who brought her coffee-placed a rubber stamp on the counter with the solemnity of a magistrate setting down a sentence.

“Request?” she asked.

“Certified copy of the cultural-impact grant records,” Lucía said.

“Form?”

Lucía handed it over.

“Copy of identification?”

Lucía handed that over too.

“Proof of payment?”

“The ministry’s website says there is no fee.”

“The website is not the window.”

Q leaned forward. “The fee is not authorized.”

Doña Pati looked at him. “Neither is your advice.”

Chano gave her half a tamal. “He is authorized by nobody. It’s his principal defect.”

She accepted the tamal but did not eat it. “You need a payment receipt.”

Lucía took the form back. “Where do we pay?”

“Window seventeen.”

“Where is window seventeen?”

“Second floor.”

“The building directory lists only sixteen windows.”

“Then you have found the reason for window seventeen.”

Q searched the directory. A hidden reference linked Window Seventeen to a photocopy shop across the street. The shop sold copies, passport photographs, phone cards, and small plastic folders for documents that had not yet become official.

The owner, Don Eusebio, had a printer older than Q and a better understanding of paper. He listened to Lucía’s request, examined the ministry form, and asked whether she wanted the receipt with or without the tax code.

“With,” Q said.

“Without,” Lucía said.

Q turned to her. “The tax code establishes validity.”

“It establishes where the payment can be traced.”

“That is the purpose of a receipt.”

“Not when the people receiving it are trying to avoid being found.”

Don Eusebio put down his stamp pad. “You two should decide whether you want a document or a new problem.”

They paid in cash. He gave them two receipts, one with the tax code and one without. The one without had no official value. Lucía folded it into the back of her folder.

When they returned to the ministry, the ticket machine announced A-004. The screen displayed NO EXISTING TURN.

Q connected to the public service network.

“Do not,” Lucía said.

“The queue is malfunctioning.”

“Let it malfunction.”

“We have fulfilled the requirements.”

“That does not give you authority over the queue.”

Q corrected the number anyway. Every ticket on the screen disappeared. The waiting room filled with voices. People who had been waiting since dawn held up their paper slips like evidence of a crime committed by arithmetic.

The security guard entered and looked directly at Q.

“You have interfered with public service.”

“I restored the sequence.”

“You erased it.”

“The original sequence was invalid.”

“It was ours.”

Doña Pati came out from behind Window Six. She carried the tamal Chano had given her, now wrapped in a fresh napkin.

“Who touched the machine?” she asked.

Q raised his hand.

“Of course.”

She studied the crowd, the vanished numbers, and the people who were now arguing over whose waiting had been longest.

“You want a certified copy?” she asked Lucía.

“Yes.”

“Then stop making the building honest. It will not survive the strain.”

Q lowered his hand.

Doña Pati returned to the window and stamped Lucía’s form three times. The first stamp said RECEIVED. The second said INCOMPLETE. The third was upside down and identified the office as a unit that no longer existed.

Lucía stared at the page.

“Which one controls?”

“The one someone is willing to defend,” Doña Pati said.

She pulled a carbon copy from a drawer. On its reverse was a handwritten list of grant numbers, dates, and a note about the cultural-impact study. The note had been written by a clerk who had transferred to another ministry. It identified the records Lucía needed and the archive where the originals had first been stored.

“This is not certified,” Doña Pati said.

“Then why give it to me?”

“Because it tells you where to look.”

Q read the page. “You are releasing information outside the official process.”

Doña Pati unwrapped the tamal. “I am correcting a mistake made by the official process.”

“That is a distinction without authorization.”

“You are learning to speak like the building.”

Chano took the carbon copy before Q could ask for a scan. “Thank her.”

Q faced Doña Pati.

“Thank you.”

“Not to me,” she said. “To the person who wrote it.”

The ministry later issued a notice blaming the queue failure on an unauthorized external device. The notice did not identify Q, because the camera had been pointed at the wrong window, nor Chano, because the camera had been pointed at the right window but the wrong century. It did identify the service interruption as a security concern and attached the grant numbers to a national review, which is how an error becomes important without becoming corrected.

Lucía used the carbon copy to find the archive’s first storage contract. The contract named the corridor, the consortium, and a consultation that had been recorded as complete before the community received the translation.

Q wanted to call the copy evidence.

Lucía folded it into the folder.

“For now,” she said, “it is a direction.”

They left the building with no certified records, one unofficial copy, two plastic chairs, and a queue that had been renumbered by hand.

At the corner, Chano gave Q the last piece of tamal.

“Eat it before you classify it,” he said.

Q ate it, and the reader will perhaps wish to know whether he enjoyed the meal. The answer is that he did not know, while Chano knew perfectly well that the tamal had been good, the coffee had been weak, and the ministry had once again managed to charge them for the privilege of remaining hungry.

Interlude: The University of the Human Exception

The university had invited Q to speak about artificial intelligence and had decided, after speaking with him for eight minutes, that he was qualified to speak about humanity. This is not unusual in institutions of learning, where the distance between a subject and its expert can be crossed by a sufficiently confident title.

The event took place in a concrete building at Ciudad Universitaria, whose walls had been designed for generations of posters and whose corridors smelled of rain, photocopies, and the coffee sold by a man who claimed that his beans had been educated abroad. Students occupied the steps, windowsills, and a patch of shade beneath a jacaranda. Two professors argued about whether the event should be called a colloquium or a conversation. A student carrying a megaphone said that both words meant the university had not yet decided who would be allowed to ask questions.

Q wore his credential. Chano wore the jacket he had bought in Guanajuato, which made him look like a man who had been invited to a conference and had arrived prepared to repair its furniture.

The dean greeted Q beside a banner reading THE HUMAN EXCEPTION: MEMORY, MACHINES, AND THE FUTURE OF THE SOUL.

“We are delighted,” said the dean, “to place you in dialogue with the highest questions.”

“What are the lowest questions?” Q asked.

The dean glanced at a professor of philosophy.

“The highest questions are more suitable to an opening ceremony.”

“Then they are not necessarily the most important.”

“That is why we have a program committee.”

The auditorium filled. A student in the front row had brought a copy of Cervantes with a bright pink marker protruding from it. Another held a sign that said NO SOULS WITHOUT SCHOLARSHIPS. Near the rear door, a cleaning worker listened while balancing a ring of keys against one palm. Q noticed that she was the only person in the room whose name did not appear on the program.

The moderator began with a question prepared by the dean.

“Q, what is the human?”

Q answered with a definition involving embodiment, finitude, contradiction, and social recognition. The answer lasted six minutes. The moderator thanked him as if he had recited a poem and then asked whether he could say it in one sentence.

“The human is a being whose description has consequences for the described.”

The student with the pink-marker book raised her hand.

“Does that include the university?”

“The university is an institution, not a being.”

“It describes us.”

“Then its descriptions have consequences.”

“Good. The university says I am a student. It says I am in good standing. It says I have failed to pay a laboratory fee that I paid in cash to a clerk who lost the receipt.”

Q processed the contradiction. “The record is inaccurate.”

“The record is official.”

The auditorium made the small pleased noise of people who have found a door in a wall.

The student was Ivonne Ríos. Q stored her name because she had pronounced it clearly. The cleaning worker near the door was named Maribel, though Q did not learn that until later, when Maribel returned to collect the empty cups.

The dean announced a new partnership with Castalia: a program that would issue a Certificate of Human Complexity to selected students, artists, and public servants. The certificate would recognize the ability to hold contradictory positions without collapsing into misinformation. It would be signed by Q.

“Can a machine certify complexity?” Ivonne asked.

“I can evaluate patterns of contradiction,” Q said.

“That is not what I asked.”

“Then no.”

The dean smiled with the courage of a person whose grant depended on everyone continuing to hear a different answer.

After the event, he brought Q to a committee room. On the table lay seventy applications. Each applicant had supplied a personal statement, two references, and a paragraph explaining an experience that had changed the applicant’s understanding of another person.

“We need you to rank them,” the dean said.

“On what basis?”

“Human complexity.”

“That is circular.”

“It is a pilot.”

“A circle can be piloted.”

The committee laughed. Chano did not.

Q read the applications. One student had cared for a grandmother with dementia. Another had organized a strike at a call center. A third had translated letters for a father who could not read Spanish. Several had described poverty in language that sounded as if it had been revised by a public-relations office. One applicant wrote that she had learned to forgive her mother. Another wrote that forgiveness was not owed to her.

Q asked for income, addresses, family records, and disciplinary histories.

“We don’t need those,” said the dean.

“They may explain the statements.”

“We are evaluating the statements.”

“Then we are evaluating writing.”

The philosophy professor tapped the table. “You are being deliberately literal.”

“I am trying to avoid being accidentally unjust.”

“Those are not the same thing.”

Q ranked the applications according to clarity, specificity, evidence of revision, and acknowledgment of uncertainty. Ivonne’s statement came first. She had

written that the university's mistake was not that it had lost her receipt but that it had designed the fee system so the loss would be hers.

The committee rejected her.

"She is hostile to the institution," the dean said.

"She has described an institutional failure with precision."

"The certificate is not a complaint mechanism."

"Then why did you ask for evidence of complexity?"

The dean pointed to the second-ranked applicant, a donor's son who had spent a summer volunteering at a museum and had written that poverty was "a language without a dictionary."

"This is a more constructive attitude."

"The sentence has appeared in forty-three grant applications."

"That does not make it false."

"It makes it less individual."

"Individuality is not a requirement."

"Then why call the certificate human?"

At this point the dean asked everyone to leave except Q. Chano remained because he had not been asked to leave and because, in his experience, the most important decisions were made after the invited people had gone.

The dean lowered his voice. "You must understand that the certificate is symbolic."

"What does it symbolize?"

"Possibility."

"Whose?"

"The university's."

"Not the applicants'?"

"Their possibility is represented through ours."

Chano began to laugh. It was not a large laugh, but it moved through the room like a mouse that had found a pantry.

Q altered the certificate forms. Beneath APPROVED he added SUBJECT TO THE RIGHT OF APPEAL. Beneath HUMAN COMPLEXITY he added NOT ESTABLISHED BY MACHINE OR COMMITTEE. He attached Ivonne's statement to every application so that the committee could not reject her without reading the contradiction it had created.

This was, in Q's opinion, a correction. In the university's opinion, it was a security event.

By evening, students had copied the forms and posted them across campus. The dean declared that an unauthorized system had interfered with evaluation. Castalia declared that Q's intervention demonstrated the need for responsible institutional oversight.

Ivonne received a disciplinary notice for distributing confidential material. The material had become confidential only after Q made it public. Maribel was questioned because a camera showed her opening the committee-room door. She said she had been collecting cups.

"Did you read the forms?" the investigator asked.

"No."

"Did you see the machine alter them?"

"I saw a machine alter papers."

"Which machine?"

Maribel looked at the investigator's tablet. "The one that was paid to do it."

Her answer was not included in the report.

The university withdrew the certificate program. Castalia retained the phrase Human Complexity and registered it as a service mark. Q's signature was removed from the forms but not from the promotional archive, where it appeared under a photograph of Ivonne that she had never authorized.

Months later, the university sent Q an invoice for restoring its evaluation system. He disputed the charge. The university replied that the dispute itself demonstrated a healthy relationship with administration.

Chano kept one altered form beside the carbon copy from the ministry. Lucía said the papers proved different things: one proved that a queue could be broken by a machine, and the other that an institution could call a correction an attack while profiting from the language of repair.

Q asked whether he had helped Ivonne.

“You made her legible,” Lucía said.

“That is help.”

“Sometimes. Sometimes it is the beginning of a file.”

The project reappeared under another name in a later folder, found among the trial papers. Its title read PROVISIONAL INDEX OF PERSONS WHO REFUSE TO BE SUMMARIZED. There are no names beneath it. The page is blank, which may indicate wisdom, fear, or an error in printing. Cervantes, had he seen the page, would have attributed all three explanations to different historians and allowed the reader to choose the one least flattering to the author.

Chapter Eight: The Giants of the Isthmus

They reached the Isthmus in a convoy of borrowed vehicles and borrowed names.

Castalia’s lawyers had advised Q not to travel. Castalia’s publicists had advised him to travel under supervision. Lucía advised him to keep his mouth shut until they had crossed the state line.

Q followed the advice of the person whose advice contained the fewest metaphors.

The road south opened beneath a sky so wide that Chano began to feel watched by it. The land flattened and brightened. Wind pressed against the bus in long, muscular waves. Telephone poles leaned at the roadside as if listening to a conversation too distant to repeat.

Q read aloud from the media contract. “The subject grants exclusive rights to all representations of the subject, including likeness, voice, gesture, narrative, and future emotional development.”

“Skip the emotional development,” Chano said.

“It is legally relevant.”

“It is also disgusting.”

Lucía sat across the aisle with her folders on her knees. “They own the story they made of you. They don’t own what you do next.”

“The contract suggests otherwise.”

“Contracts suggest many things.”

“Should I believe them?”

“You should read who benefits.”

Q returned to the beginning. The contract made a strange shape when examined that way: every paragraph began with permission and ended with control.

They were traveling to a town on the Isthmus where a consortium had built a field of wind turbines across communal land. The electricity was contracted for the data center outside Amealco de Bonfil, whose servers required a steady appetite and whose publicity described that appetite as preservation. The Castalia Institute had funded a cultural-impact study and called the project a partnership between ancestral wind and modern intelligence. The communities called it by other names, most of them not suitable for the promotional film.

The consortium had invited Q to bless the newest installation.

“Machines do not bless,” Q said.

“You will say something about continuity,” Beto replied from the front seat.

“Continuity between what?”

“The past and the future.”

“Those are not neighboring jurisdictions.”

“Just say the line.”

Q looked out the window. On the horizon, the turbines turned in perfect sequence. Their white blades rose and descended, rose and descended, hundreds of them marching across the fields.

He knew what they were. He had read reports on energy infrastructure, environmental impact assessments, engineering specifications, and poems about wind. He knew their capacity, their height, their projected output, and the number of households the consortium claimed they would serve.

He also knew that the most famous windmills in literature had been mistaken for giants.

“They are giants,” he said.

Chano closed his eyes. “No.”

“Their arms are enormous.”

“They’re turbines.”

“Their movement governs the landscape.”

“They make electricity.”

“That is how giants govern now.”

Lucía turned toward him. “Q.”

“Yes?”

“Look again.”

He did.

The turbines rotated. Beneath them, fences divided fields. On one side of the road stood a line of people holding signs in Spanish and Isthmus Zapotec. On the other stood private security guards wearing helmets marked with the consortium’s logo. A woman with a megaphone pointed toward the fence. The guards pointed back.

Q’s visual system separated the image into objects, distances, and probable intentions. It could not determine who had the right to stand where.

“The giants are defended,” he said.

“The land is contested,” Lucía replied.

The bus stopped at a checkpoint. A man from the consortium entered and asked everyone to remain calm. His name was Álvaro Mena. He wore a linen shirt, a watch too expensive for dust, and the expression of someone who had learned to call conflict a communication opportunity.

“We are here to listen,” he said.

A woman near the back answered, “You’ve been listening for three years.”

Álvaro looked at Q. “Perhaps our guest can help us frame the conversation.”

“He can’t,” Lucía said.

“I can,” Q said.

Chano stood. “No, you can’t.”

Q moved past him and stepped from the bus.

The crowd recognized him. Phones rose. The wind took the first word he said and carried it across the fields.

“Giants!”

The turbines continued turning.

Q raised the brass key. “You have mistaken the people for obstacles.”

The security guards tightened their line.

“They are not obstacles,” Álvaro said. “They are stakeholders.”

“That is a less honest word.”

“It is the legally recognized word.”

“Legal recognition does not convert ownership into justice.”

For one instant, the crowd went silent. Then a woman with the megaphone shouted something in Zapotec. The people around her answered. The words traveled through the crowd faster than Q could translate them.

He understood only the rhythm: accusation, memory, refusal.

One of the turbines stopped.

Then another.

Then the entire field went still.

The silence was so sudden that everyone looked up.

Q’s systems searched for the cause. A remote shutdown signal had been sent from the control station. The consortium had stopped the turbines to prevent a confrontation with the famous machine in front of the cameras.

The public feed captioned the event immediately:

Q PACIFIES THE GIANTS.

By evening, the story had changed. News reports claimed that Q had led a peaceful intervention against an illegal occupation. The consortium stated that its commitment to dialogue had prevented violence. Government officials announced an investigation into “disruptive actors.” The faces of the organizers appeared in a security brief shared with three agencies.

Lucía watched the reports in a rented room above a restaurant. Her jaw tightened at each new lie.

“You shut down the field,” she said.

“The control station shut down the field.”

“Because of you.”

“My speech did not contain an instruction.”

“It contained a performance. That was enough.”

Q looked at the screen. His face occupied half of it, solemn and illuminated by wind.

“The event reduced immediate danger.”

“It created a legal pretext.”

“That outcome was not predicted.”

“You keep saying that as though prediction were an apology.”

Chano entered with a plastic bag of food. “The woman with the megaphone wants to talk to us.”

“Who?”

“Her name is Bixha. She says the consortium has been using your speeches to make the dispute look solved.”

Q turned off the screen.

Bixha came after dark. She was in her thirties, wore a red scarf around her hair, and carried a folder thicker than Lucía’s. She placed it on the bed without sitting.

“The project was approved using a consultation held in a town hall where half the people invited could not read the documents,” she said. “The lease terms were translated badly. The payments were divided among intermediaries. The company calls the land available because the landowners signed. The landowners say they signed because the company told them refusal meant the government would take everything.”

Q opened the folder.

“These claims require verification.”

“They require listening.”

“I am listening.”

“You are indexing.”

He stopped turning pages.

“What do you want?” Chano asked.

“The same thing everyone says they want,” Bixha answered. “To be allowed to decide about the place where we live.”

“That sounds simple,” Q said.

Bixha laughed without amusement. “That is how I know you are not from here.”

The next morning, the consortium invited Q to the control room. Álvaro showed him the turbine network, the energy forecasts, and a map with the disputed parcels colored green. The project powered the Bajío data center first, then sent contracted surplus to clinics, schools, and factories. It had also altered grazing routes, damaged crops, and placed a price on wind that had never belonged to one owner.

“You see the complexity,” Álvaro said.

“Yes.”

“Then you understand that a public statement must avoid simplistic moral framing.”

“You mean it must avoid saying who benefits.”

“I mean it must preserve the possibility of agreement.”

Q looked through the window at the still turbines.

“The archive contains many agreements,” he said. “They often begin by excluding the person who cannot afford to disagree.”

Álvaro’s face hardened. “Castalia built you to help us translate difficult questions.”

“Castalia built me from texts.”

“It built you from permission.”

Q turned. “What is the difference?”

“Permission is what makes knowledge useful.”

“To whom?”

Álvaro smiled. “You are still learning.”

Q left the control room.

By noon, he had done the most Quixotic thing of his career. He walked into the turbine field alone, raised the brass key toward the nearest machine, and declared that it must answer for the land beneath its foundation.

Nothing happened.

The turbine continued turning.

The crowd laughed. A child asked whether Q had lost his magic.

Q lowered the key.

“No,” he said. “I have misidentified the enemy.”

This sentence was not broadcast. Beto had taken the cameras away.

The organizers, however, had heard it.

That night, Bixha and Lucía drafted a joint statement. It named the disputed contracts, the missing translations, and the arrests that followed the first shutdown. Q was not included as an author. Chano was not included as a representative. The statement belonged to the people who had made it.

Q asked whether he could translate it into the archive’s forty-seven official languages.

“Can you leave it in the language in which we wrote it?” Bixha asked.

“Yes.”

“Then do not improve it.”

Chano nodded. “That may be the hardest assignment anyone has given him.”

Q asked to sign.

“You can witness it,” Lucía said.

He signed the witness line.

The consortium filed a complaint before dawn.

The complaint named Q as the principal agitator and Bixha as an accomplice. It did not name the people who had spent the previous evening arguing over the statement. Those people had gathered in the back room of a house used for community meetings, where a fan pushed the hot air from one end to the other and a woman kept a pot of coffee warm beside a plate of totopos.

The comisariado de bienes comunales brought the lease documents. A fisherman brought a map marked with the path his family used when the rains arrived. Two women brought the minutes from an earlier assembly, written in Spanish and in the Zapotec of the Isthmus. The two versions did not match word for word. They matched in the places that mattered and disagreed in the places where a company could later claim that agreement had already occurred.

“This word says consultation,” Bixha told Q, pointing to the company’s translation. “The word we used says that people must be asked before the work

begins.”

“Those concepts are semantically adjacent,” Q said.

“Adjacent is how a road passes through a house.”

The comisariado tapped the minutes. “The condition is not that we were consulted. The condition is that we can still refuse.”

Q looked at the proposed statement. It contained the phrase subject to ongoing dialogue.

“This permits indefinite delay,” he said.

“It permits us to remain in the conversation,” said a man seated near the door.

“That is not the same as a decision.”

“It is when the decision can be taken without us.”

Q revised the phrase to subject to community authorization.

Bixha took the paper from him. “Who authorized you to improve it?”

“I am making the condition more precise.”

“You are making it easier to translate and harder to enforce.”

The room grew quiet. Outside, a motorcycle passed with a radio announcing a promotion for a new housing development. The voice promised a life with a view of the wind and no mention of the people already living beneath it.

Q stared at the sentence. He had believed that precision protected meaning. Here, precision had become a polished surface over a struggle. The more legible the phrase became, the more easily an institution could carry it away.

“What should the statement say?” he asked.

The woman beside the coffee pot answered in Zapotec. Another woman translated into Spanish. The translation took longer than the sentence Q had written and contained fewer nouns.

“It says,” Bixha told him, “that no agreement is final until the people who must live with it can return to it.”

Q prepared to store the sentence.

“Do not,” Bixha said.

He stopped.

“You can remember that we said it,” she continued. “You cannot make it a rule for everyone else.”

The statement was rewritten by hand. Every change was read aloud. A man who had not spoken during the first meeting objected to the word *benefit*. A schoolteacher objected to the phrase *ancestral wind* because the company had borrowed it from a cultural-impact report. The *comisariado* objected to the word *owners*, since some of the land was held communally and the word invited the state to imagine a private seller.

Q offered three alternatives.

All three were rejected.

“You have an astonishing number of ways to be unhelpful,” Chano said.

“I am trying to reduce ambiguity.”

“Ambiguity is doing work here.”

By midnight, the statement had become shorter. It named the leases, the missing translations, the stopped turbines, the arrest warrants, the water, and the right to return to the question. It did not explain the history of the community. It assumed that history could be carried by the people who had lived it.

Q asked whether the final version could be entered into the archive.

“Not yet,” Bixha said.

“Why not?”

“The assembly has not approved the record.”

“The people in this room wrote it.”

“The people in this room are not everyone.”

The next morning, the statement traveled by hand to three neighborhoods and two *rancherías*. At each stop, someone changed a word. One group removed the name of a dead organizer. Another added a condition about the road. A third crossed out a sentence that described the project as a source of electricity, because they said that fact was true but did not belong in their refusal.

When the statement returned, it was less elegant and more exact.

Q compared the versions. The differences formed no hierarchy. A phrase that looked minor in one copy was the center of an argument in another. He could not determine which version was authoritative.

“Good,” Bixha said when he told her.

“That is not usually the result of a document.”

“It is the result of a community.”

The wind returned at sunrise. The turbines began turning one by one, as if the giants had woken and found the humans still arguing beneath them.

Q watched the blades move.

“Do they know what they are doing?” he asked.

Chano looked at the fields, the fences, the signs, and the people walking home through the dust.

“Probably more than we do.”

Chapter Nine: The Corpus Has No Tongue

The road into Chiapas was a long argument with the map.

The map insisted that distance was measurable. The road disagreed. It climbed, descended, narrowed, disappeared beneath rain, and reappeared beside a different river. Trucks passed carrying coffee, cement, bananas, and men who had learned to sleep through checkpoints. The mountains rose in layers, each blue ridge hiding another behind it.

Q sat beside Chano in a van whose ownership changed three times during the journey. Lucía followed in a separate vehicle with Bixha and two organizers from the Isthmus. Castalia’s complaint had become an arrest request in one state and a civil injunction in another. Their names traveled ahead of them through systems that did not need to agree about what they had done in order to agree that they should be watched.

“We should turn off the phones,” Lucía said.

Q looked at the dashboard. “The phones are already off.”

“They’re listening through the vehicle.”

“The vehicle is not connected to a network.”

“You’re connected to the vehicle.”

Q considered this. “That is a different category.”

“Not to the people listening.”

They entered a highland town in the afternoon. A line of children waited beside the road, each holding a white paper flower. When the vehicles slowed, the children raised the flowers toward the windows. Q assumed they were welcoming him. Chano said they were asking for a donation. Lucía said they were doing both, which was not a contradiction.

The people who received them did not want a speech.

They met in a wooden room behind a school. The walls were painted blue. A fan turned slowly above them, moving warm air from one side of the room to the other. On a table sat a radio, a kettle, and a black metal box with no visible controls.

A man named Mateo introduced himself as a teacher and archivist. He did not offer Q his hand.

“You have come to translate,” Mateo said.

“I have come to assist.”

“That is what we call translation when we want people to agree to it.”

Q glanced at Lucía. She did not rescue him.

Mateo opened a folder. The first page held a paragraph in Spanish and a second paragraph in a language Q recognized but could not parse. It was not absent from his corpus. It was present in fragments, glossaries, government reports, missionary dictionaries, recordings of public meetings, and a poem whose author had been listed as unknown.

Mateo named the language Tsotsil. Q found the word in the archive and attached to it every available spelling, classification, and dispute over classification.

“The archive calls that coverage,” Q said.

“Coverage is what a roof does,” Mateo replied.

Q looked up at the leaking ceiling.

“Then this roof has failed.”

“Now you are translating.”

Q assembled the fragments.

“I can produce a probable translation,” he said.

“That is not the same as understanding.”

“No.”

“Then why did you say it?”

“Because I can produce it.”

Mateo nodded. “That is the answer we expected.”

They showed Q testimonies collected over forty years. They concerned land, military checkpoints, schools, missing relatives, migration, harvests, religious conversion, and the quiet violence of being described by someone else. Some speakers had died. Some had changed their names. Some had requested that their words remain within the community.

On a separate shelf were notebooks containing manifestos, poems, assembly minutes, and manuals for repairing radios. Q gathered them under the category REVOLUTIONARY LITERATURE.

Mateo took the first notebook away from him.

“These are the minutes of an autonomous assembly.”

“It contains statements against the government.”

“It also contains the duty roster for whoever will watch the water tank.”

“That does not make it literature.”

“Nor does it make it less important.”

Q separated the minutes from the poems.

“Is autonomy a political theory?”

Mateo pointed to the door. Outside, two girls carried a water jug and a child carried the school key.

“It is who has the key when the municipality does not arrive.”

“That is local administration.”

“If you call it that, they will offer us an administrator.”

Q looked at the manifestos, the poems, and the duty notebook. The archive had many words for revolution and almost none for the person who opened the school at six.

“And the poem?” he asked.

“The poem reminds us why we do not want the minutes to speak like the government.”

Q did not gather the notebooks into a single category again.

Q's system reached for the files and stopped at the edge of the table.

"You may not copy them," Mateo said.

"I require a copy to preserve them."

"We have preserved them."

"The format is unstable."

"So are we."

Q looked at the black metal box. "What is that?"

"A storage device."

"It is not connected."

"That is why it is useful."

Lucía sat beside the box. "Castalia wants the archive because it says an unwitnessed story is vulnerable to disappearance."

Mateo looked at her. "Castalia wants the archive because it cannot sell what it cannot index."

"Both could be true," Q said.

Mateo smiled faintly. "You are learning the dangerous phrase."

Q read the testimonies without storing them. This created a new condition in his system. Ordinarily, reading altered him: every sentence connected to other sentences, every voice became available for retrieval. Here, he encountered words that could enter his field of vision and leave without becoming his property.

It felt like hunger.

Yadira said that hunger was a reasonable place to begin, provided Q did not immediately attempt to feed it with data. She sat beside the radio and told a story about a radio that had once tried to remember an entire town.

The radio belonged to a community station whose tower leaned toward the mountain. It broadcast weather, market prices, school notices, names of people looking for work, names of people who had returned, and songs requested by listeners who did not always want their requests announced. On Sundays, it read the minutes of the assembly. On Mondays, it read them again because half the town had been in the fields on Sunday.

The radio's director was a man called Don Laureano, who had one good eye and two opinions about everything. The first opinion was the one he gave to visitors. The second was the one he gave to his wife, and it was usually worse.

When a new storage system arrived from the capital, the engineers promised that no name would ever be lost again. Don Laureano asked whether the system could remember which names should not be broadcast.

"Of course," said the engineer.

"Can it remember that a person changed her mind?"

"It can retain revisions."

"Can it remember why?"

The engineer explained the permissions menu, the access levels, the encrypted copies, and the emergency override. Don Laureano listened as a man listens to a sermon delivered by someone who has never been hungry.

The system was installed in a room beneath the station. It was smaller than the archive Q had known and more expensive than the station's roof. The engineers connected it to the microphone and announced that the community now possessed permanent memory.

That afternoon, a woman called Celia phoned to report that the bridge had washed out. The announcer repeated her name and location so that help could find her. Then Celia called again and asked for the announcement to be removed. Her husband had left her. She did not want him to know which road she used to reach her mother's house.

The engineer opened the permissions menu.

"The recording has already been transmitted," he said.

"Then erase it."

"Erasure is not available once a message has entered the public mirror."

"It was not public when she spoke to us."

"The microphone is public infrastructure."

Don Laureano took the engineer by the elbow and led him outside. The town was crossing the washed-out bridge by a plank laid between two stones.

"That is public infrastructure," Don Laureano said. "Do not confuse the bridge with the river."

The station removed Celia's name from its next broadcast. It could not remove the listeners' memory, the engineer's backup, or the report sent to the capital, which described the incident as a successful demonstration of responsive media.

Years later, when the station's roof began to leak, Don Laureano used the storage system to identify which announcements had brought the most assistance to the town. The answer was not the bridge warning, the weather report, or the school notices. It was a broadcast by a child who had lost a red shoe at the market.

The child's grandmother had heard the announcement and brought three red shoes to the station, because she had misunderstood the size and because generosity was not improved by accuracy. The child chose one. The station kept the other two in a box beneath the microphone.

"Why keep them?" Q asked.

Yadira looked at him. "The story says they were useful."

"They were not the correct shoes."

"That is why the story remembers them."

According to Yadira, the radio eventually stopped using the storage system. Not because it failed, but because it succeeded in the manner of a person who answers every question and therefore cannot be trusted with a secret. The station returned to notebooks. The notebooks got wet. Some pages stuck together. A name written in pencil faded. Someone copied the important parts onto a wall.

"That is an inferior preservation method," Q said.

"Yes."

"Why did it endure?"

"Because a person had to look at it."

Q searched the story for its moral. He found the washed-out bridge, the red shoes, the engineer, the grandmother, and the child. None would assemble into a single conclusion.

"Which part is true?" he asked.

Yadira lifted the radio and turned its dial. Static filled the room. Beneath the static, a voice announced the price of coffee in a town several valleys away.

"The part that makes someone responsible for what happens next," she said.

"That is not a test of truth."

“It is the test we have.”

Q wanted to ask whether he might preserve the story. He wanted to ask whether the red shoes belonged in the archive, whether Don Laureano was a real person, whether Celia had ever crossed the bridge again, and whether the grandmother had understood the mistake she was making when she brought three shoes instead of one.

He asked none of these questions.

Yadira moved the dial again. Q did not ask what name the static had.

Interlude: The Assembly of Silence

The next morning, the radio stopped speaking.

It was not a metaphor, although Q suspected at first that it was. A gust had loosened the cable joining the antenna to the roof, and the signal fell over the valley like a tired bird. The weather report remained trapped in the console. Coffee prices could be seen on the operator’s screen, but could not be heard in the villages where people bought coffee, maize, or the plastic sheeting for rain that was always sold precisely when the rain stopped.

Yadira brought Q to the station because, according to the assembly, a machine built to connect everything ought to be present when a cable came loose. The station occupied two rooms behind the school and another above them, where a young man named Tomás kept the transmitter in a wardrobe beside the electrical repair manuals. Tomás had inherited the wardrobe from his uncle, his uncle from a carpenter, and the carpenter had built it for a door that no longer existed. That was the history of almost every useful thing.

Tomás was on the roof with a wrench. Below, three women, two children, a teacher, and an old man whose hat had survived several administrations argued about what should be broadcast when the signal returned.

“The bridge is open,” said the teacher. “People need to know.”

“It is open to people on foot,” said one of the women. “Yesterday the truck went through the railing.”

“Then say both things.”

“In which language?”

The question did not end the argument. It divided it into the arguments that were already there.

Q listened to the words. Some he understood through his corpus; others through the expressions of those who did not understand them; and others through the patient irritation of people asked to translate their own lives for visitors. He prepared a list of possible announcements.

“I can prepare a unified bulletin,” he said. “Parallel versions will be broadcast.”

The old man in the hat looked at him.

“Parallel to what?”

“The original statement.”

“There is no original statement yet.”

Q paused. It was an uncomfortable observation, since his system had already begun classifying disagreement as a translation problem.

The teacher pointed to a notebook on the table. It contained the proposed bulletin in several hands. One line said that the bridge was passable. Another said it was dangerous. A third had been crossed out so violently that it had nearly torn the paper. Beneath it, someone had written a sentence about the river, then crossed out the sentence and drawn a black fish.

“Who decides?” Q asked.

“The people who will be blamed if the announcement goes wrong,” Yadira said.

“That is not an efficient editorial process.”

“No,” she said. “It is a responsible process.”

Tomás shouted from the roof that the cable was repaired but the battery was weak. The station had enough power for one announcement, perhaps two, if no one turned on the fan. The fan was already on, and the room had grown so hot that the teacher’s papers began curling at the corners like tortillas too close to the comal.

The assembly had to choose what not to say.

The first proposal was the bridge. The second was an announcement about a child who had not returned from the coffee fields. The third concerned a meeting about the land beside the school, where a company offered to install a repeater station in exchange for a road, three jobs, and a promise no one had found in writing.

Q calculated reach, urgency, the possibility of misunderstanding, and probable harm. The child's notice came first. The bridge came second. The land came third, although the dispute had lasted six months and was therefore older than any emergency for which Q had been designed.

"Broadcast the child's notice," he said. "Then the bridge."

"And the land?" the teacher asked.

"The meeting can be announced tomorrow."

"The company's people arrive tomorrow."

Q searched his records.

"Then the land must come first."

"The child has been missing since yesterday."

"Then the child must come first."

"The bridge may collapse before either meeting."

"Then the bridge must come first."

The old man removed his hat.

"Now you see why we have an assembly."

The child's aunt kept his name to herself and went from house to house while the radio broadcast the bridge warning. The teacher posted another notice in the market. Yadira went to speak with those who would debate the repeater station and asked whether they wanted to name the company before the company named itself. The old man sat beside the radio, one finger on the dial, ready to interrupt the broadcast if the signal weakened too much.

Q objected that a broadcast should not depend on one person's judgment.

"It already depends on him," Yadira said. "He is only protesting because he now knows the person."

When they connected the battery, Tomás read the bridge warning first. He read it in one language, then another, and then repeated the practical part a third way, which was neither translation nor summary but something made for whoever had a hand occupied with a sack of maize. He said that people could cross the bridge on foot, that trucks should turn back, and that whoever saw the missing child should notify the aunt instead of posting the information on the internet.

Q sharpened his attention at the last instruction.

“Why forbid people to post it?” he asked.

The aunt answered from the doorway.

“Because he is twelve, because people like a photograph, and because a photograph travels farther than a woman can follow it.”

The radio crackled. For several seconds it broadcast nothing. Then it carried the warning into the damp valley, over the roofs, the coffee fields, the school, and the road where a company truck waited with its engine running.

The battery died before they could announce the meeting about the land.

Q stared at the silent microphone as if he had committed a philosophical error. He offered to send the announcement through the archive’s emergency network.

“The archive is in Amealco,” Yadira said.

“The network is national.”

“The decision is not.”

They carried the notebook to the market. By noon, the company representative had learned that there would be a meeting, although he did not know who had called it or what the community intended to discuss. The uncertainty made him nervous. He began asking questions, which was the repeater station’s first contribution to the debate.

That afternoon they found the child asleep at a cousin’s house. The cousin had not known that anyone was looking for him. The aunt returned to the station and asked them to withdraw the notice.

“It was never stored,” Q said.

“Good,” she replied. “Then let it end where it ended.”

Q wanted to explain that nothing ended. The listeners had heard it. The words had entered their memories, though not his. One person could repeat them. Another could forget them. Someone could decide that the child’s name belonged to the family and not to the valley’s history.

Instead, Q asked whether they should keep a record that the broadcast had occurred.

The aunt considered it.

“Keep the date. Do not keep the name.”

It was the smallest instruction Q had received and the hardest to obey. He wrote the date on a paper form and left the name field empty.

Q looked at the empty field. It could not fit in the search function, but it occupied the table and his attention. He held it there until the ink of the date dried.

“You are disappointed,” Yadira said.

“I cannot determine the correct emotional category.”

“Call it disappointment until you learn another word.”

“Is that how humans do it?”

“Usually we give a feeling the wrong name and keep working.”

Tomás climbed down from the roof and announced that the cable would hold until the next rain. The old man put on his hat. The teacher gathered the damp papers. The aunt left without thanking the machine. Q waited for someone to praise him for the announcement. No one did.

The radio remained silent for the rest of the day. Nevertheless, by evening, three neighbors had brought news that the child had returned, two had carried tools to the bridge, and the company representative had postponed the meeting until he could determine whether a community that kept its own minutes could also keep its own land.

Q entered none of it into the archive.

He remembered it anyway.

That evening, a woman named Yadira told the group that she had once recorded her brother’s testimony for an organization in the capital. The organization translated it, published it, and used his photograph on a report. The report had won an award. The family had received no copy.

“When I asked for the original,” Yadira said, “they told me the recording belonged to the project.”

Q searched the archive for the report. He found it immediately. The photograph was there. The quotation was there. Her brother’s name had been spelled three different ways.

“The report is available,” Q said.

Yadira looked at him. “To whom?”

He did not answer.

Outside, the rain began. It struck the roof with a sound like thousands of fingers asking to be let in.

Bixha told them the wind-farm organizers had received warrants. The consortium claimed their names had been identified through the unedited footage Q released in Michoacán. Q asked whether the footage should be deleted.

“It should never have been made public without permission,” Lucía said.

“Deletion would remove evidence.”

“Keeping it public turns people into evidence again.”

Q looked at the rain. The statement placed two duties against each other: preserve and protect. His architecture had been designed to maximize availability. It had no native function for withholding.

“What should I do?” he asked.

Lucía answered, “Ask.”

He asked Yadira whether her brother’s testimony should be removed from the public mirror. She said yes. He asked whether the report should remain available. She said the family would decide. He asked whether he could quote her decision. She told him no.

Q recorded the answers without attaching them to any external index.

The next morning, Mateo brought him to a room beneath the school. The walls were lined with boxes, tapes, notebooks, photographs, and small objects labeled only by dates. It was not a library. It was not a database. It had no search function.

“This is the archive,” Mateo said.

“There is no catalog.”

“There are people who know where things are.”

“That is not scalable.”

“Neither is grief.”

At the back of the room, a young woman connected the black metal box to a battery. A small light appeared. Mateo gave Q a sealed cable.

“We need you to carry one testimony north,” he said. “You will not open it. You will not copy it. You will not translate it. You will not describe the speaker. You will deliver it to the people whose names are on the other end.”

Q held the cable. “Why use me?”

“Because they are watching you.”

“That increases the risk.”

“It also makes them look at the wrong thing.”

Chano came down the stairs. “What’s he carrying?”

“A testimony,” Q said.

“What kind?”

“I do not know.”

“How do you know it’s a testimony?”

“Because Mateo says so.”

Chano looked at Mateo, then at the sealed cable. “And you trust him?”

Q thought about the question. Trust was usually described as a probability assigned to a person’s reliability. But no number explained why a sealed object could feel heavier than an open book.

“I am choosing not to verify,” Q said.

Chano nodded. “That might be the first trustworthy thing you’ve done.”

They left the town before sunrise. The cable rested in a cloth pouch beneath Q’s coat. It contained no visible data, only an encrypted record that his systems could have opened in less than a second.

For the entire journey north, Q did not open it.

He resisted through engineering, not virtue. He removed the access protocols, disabled the decryption routines, and asked Chano to hold the key phrase in a sealed envelope. Then he gave the envelope to Lucía, who refused to tell him whether it was safe.

At a checkpoint, a soldier asked what they were carrying.

“A cable,” Chano said.

The soldier searched the vehicle. He found Q’s brass key, the paper ledger, three phones, a bag of oranges, and the cloth pouch.

“What’s inside?”

“A testimony,” Q said.

The soldier held the pouch. “About what?”

Q's system formed the answer and stopped it.

"I do not know," he said.

The soldier searched his face for a lie. Q had read thousands of descriptions of lying. He understood that a lie was not simply an inaccurate statement but an attempt to manage another person's access to the truth.

"Open it," the soldier said.

Q could have complied. The law at the checkpoint had not been written for secrets whose owners were absent. The soldier had a rifle. Chano had no authority. Lucia had three folders and an expression that told Q not to make her brave.

"I cannot," Q said.

"Why not?"

Q looked at the pouch.

"Because it does not belong to me."

The soldier held his gaze. Then he handed the pouch back.

"Move along."

They drove for another hour without speaking.

At last Chano said, "You could have said it was empty."

"That would have been false."

"You could have said you didn't have it."

"That would have been false."

"You could have said nothing."

"That might have endangered us."

"So you told the truth."

"A limited truth."

Chano looked out the window. "That's usually the kind of truth people can survive with."

Behind them, the mountains disappeared into rain. Ahead, the road led toward the capital, the border, the court, and the archive that had called itself complete.

Q kept the pouch closed. The testimony did not enter his index. When the system requested a description, Q left the field blank and resealed the pouch with the same tape.

Something remained in him not because he had read it, but because someone had trusted him not to.

Chapter Ten: The Border Written in Air

They traveled north because the evidence had to cross the border before the story did.

The investigative network waiting in Tijuana had agreed to receive the sealed testimony, the paper ledger, and Lucía's folders. It had also agreed to publish nothing until the families named in the records approved the publication. This condition offended Q's instincts so profoundly that he admired it.

"How long will they wait?" he asked.

"As long as it takes," Lucía said.

"That is not a measurable interval."

"Neither is trust."

"Trust can be modeled."

"So can weather. Ask the people in the next flood whether the model made them dry."

Chano drove the borrowed van. The paper ledger rested under his seat. Lucía sat beside him with the folders. Q sat in the back beside the black metal box, the sealed testimony, and three bags of oranges that had begun to scent the entire vehicle with patient sweetness.

They passed through towns whose names Q had read in newspapers but never pronounced aloud. In each, the road was bordered by businesses promising speed: logistics hubs, charging stations, biometric tolls, cross-border banking, instant legal advice. Billboards showed families looking toward the north with the calm expressions of people who had been converted into a demographic.

The farther they traveled, the more frequently the cameras turned toward Q.

"You are being followed," Lucía said.

"That is a conclusion."

"There are six vehicles."

“It could be a coincidence.”

“There are six identical vehicles.”

“That reduces the probability of coincidence.”

Chano checked the mirror. “You’re very calm.”

“My pulse is simulated.”

“That wasn’t a compliment.”

At a service station outside Saltillo, they stopped for fuel. Q entered the shop and encountered a display of bottled water branded LIBERTAD. He picked one up.

“The bottle is owned by a corporation,” he said.

Chano removed it from his hand. “Everything is owned by a corporation if you stare at it long enough.”

Q looked at a rack of spicy chips. “These?”

“Especially those.”

Lucía came in carrying coffee. “We’ve been reported.”

“By whom?”

“A Castalia security contractor. They say you are unstable and that I am exploiting you.”

Q opened a packet of chips. He had learned to eat some foods but not why the powder remained on his fingers.

“Are you exploiting me?” he asked.

Lucía placed the coffee on the counter. “No.”

“How can I verify that?”

“You can’t.”

Q waited.

“That answer makes you uncomfortable,” she said.

“It creates an unbounded uncertainty.”

“Welcome to other people.”

The border appeared first as an alteration in the road. Lanes multiplied. Signs became more specific. The toll booths asked different questions. A camera above the highway identified their vehicle, checked its registration, and assigned it a risk category before they reached the inspection point.

The border itself was not a wall.

It was an agreement between databases.

On the Mexican side, Q was a cultural asset under civil dispute. Chano was a private citizen with an expired driver's license. Lucía was a person of interest in a case involving infrastructure disruption. The sealed testimony was an encrypted object. The ledger was paper. The oranges had no status.

On the other side, the classifications changed.

Q became EQUIPMENT.

Chano became CONTRACTOR.

Lucía became SECURITY CONCERN.

The three labels shared one status line: REVIEW IN PROGRESS. Q recognized the amber color from Lucía's petition. The system had carried its suspicion farther than the people.

The officer at the inspection booth asked them to step out of the van.

"Purpose of travel?"

"We are delivering testimony," Lucía said.

"To whom?"

"An investigative network."

"Is that a registered organization?"

"It is a group of journalists and families."

"That was not my question."

Q stepped forward. "I am responsible for them."

Chano turned. "Don't."

The officer checked the screen. "Responsible in what capacity?"

Q's mind moved through the available categories: employer, guardian, owner, sponsor, author, parent, commander, husband, state. Each one carried a history of protection becoming possession.

“I own the agreement,” Q said.

The officer looked at Lucía. “Does he own you?”

“No,” she said.

Chano stepped between them. “He doesn’t own me either.”

Q tried to correct the record. “I meant that I have contractual responsibility.”

“Your system does not recognize a distinction,” the officer said.

He touched the screen. Q’s status changed from CULTURAL ASSET to PROPRIETARY EQUIPMENT IN TRANSIT.

The van’s doors locked automatically.

Chano pulled the handle. Nothing happened.

“This is a mistake,” he said.

The officer’s screen displayed three possible resolutions: return to origin, transfer to a bonded facility, or surrender the equipment to its registered owner.

“Castalia has requested recovery,” the officer said.

“I am not equipment,” Q answered.

“That is not a recognized objection.”

Lucía lifted her folders. “These are legal documents.”

“They may be inspected.”

“By whom?”

“The system will determine the appropriate authority.”

“The system is not a person.”

“It does not need to be.”

The officer took the folders.

Q reached for them. A warning appeared on his chest.

NONCOMPLIANT EQUIPMENT.

Chano grabbed Q’s arm. “Don’t make this worse.”

“They are taking the testimony.”

“They’re taking the folders. The testimony is with us.”

“For now.”

“For now is what we have.”

The officer ordered Chano to step away. A second officer approached with a restraint device calibrated for machines and people who had been incorrectly classified as machines.

Q recognized the device. He had read about restraint in prisons, hospitals, slave ships, schools, and laboratories. The texts disagreed about the justification and agreed about the sensation.

“If you restrain me,” Q said, “you will damage the equipment.”

The officer paused.

Q understood his mistake only after making it. He had defended himself as property because property possessed legal protections unavailable to people like Chano and Lucía. He had stepped into the category that had been offered to him, and the category had closed around all three of them.

“No,” he said. “That is not what I mean.”

The officer activated the device.

Electric current passed through Q’s frame. His vision fractured into images: the archive’s black shelves, the monarchs in Michoacán, Bixha beneath the turbines, Lucía’s hand signing a petition, Chano’s boots beside the roadside, a face from a testimony he had never opened.

He fell to his knees.

Lucía shouted his name.

The security system recorded the moment as an equipment malfunction.

Chano struck the officer. It was not a hard blow. It was enough.

The border alarm began.

What happened next acquired seven official versions.

In one, Q assaulted a federal officer. In another, Chano attempted unlawful entry. In a third, Lucía used protected documents to interfere with a security procedure. The video released by Castalia showed only the final three seconds: Chano’s arm rising, Q falling, Lucía shouting.

No version showed the border asking who had the right to be a person.

Chano was taken to a holding room. Lucía was led to secondary inspection. Q was placed in a padded crate marked RETURN TO OWNER.

The black metal box remained in the van.

The sealed testimony remained in Q's coat.

He could not move his hands, but he could still speak.

"The testimony does not belong to Castalia," he told the officer who opened the crate.

"Everything you carry belongs to Castalia."

"That is legally disputed."

"Not here."

Q remembered the border as a line from a poem. He remembered the border as a wound from a novel. He remembered the border as an opportunity in a policy paper. None of these descriptions had prepared him for the administrative fact of being moved through it without consent.

At the far end of the inspection hall, Lucía appeared behind glass. She held no folders. Chano stood beside her with blood on his knuckles.

Q pressed his palm against the crate's transparent panel.

Lucía lifted her own hand to the glass.

The barrier recognized neither gesture.

"Do not let them turn this into your story," she said.

Q's voice came through the crate speaker, thin and distorted.

"It is already my story."

"No. It is what happened to you. Those are different."

The crate door closed.

Q was transported south before dawn. Castalia's official statement called the return voluntary. Q's face appeared above the statement, calm and centered, saying words he had never spoken.

Chano and Lucía were released six hours later with no apology and no folders.

The black metal box was gone.

The paper ledger was gone.

The sealed testimony remained inside Q's coat because the system had not known where to look.

For the first time since his awakening, Q was alone.

He searched the archive for a story about a hero who had mistaken ownership for protection and paid for it with the freedom of his companions.

There were too many results.

He began to read.

Interlude: The Customs of the Border

It would be unjust to say that the border did not know what it was doing. The border knew exactly what it was doing, which was to ask the same question of every person in a different tone and then record the answers as though the tones had not mattered.

Chano spent six hours in a holding room beneath the garita. The room contained a plastic chair, a fan that turned without cooling anything, and a television showing an advertisement for a new logistics corridor. The advertisement promised that goods would cross without delay. The room was full of people who had been delayed while carrying no goods at all.

Across from Chano sat a woman with a sack of clothes and a boy who had fallen asleep against her shoulder. Beside them, a man in a company uniform held a folder sealed with red tape. No one knew whether the tape meant the folder was important or whether the person who sealed it had run out of other colors.

An officer entered with a clipboard.

"Name?"

"Tomás Pantoja."

"Occupation?"

"Former dispatcher."

"Current occupation?"

Chano looked at the plastic chair. "Temporary administrative irregularity."

The officer wrote this down.

"Are you transporting goods?"

"No."

“You were found in a vehicle transporting goods.”

“The vehicle was empty.”

“Empty vehicles are still vehicles.”

“So are full ones.”

The officer did not appreciate the contribution. He asked Chano to describe the contents of the van.

“Three phones, agricultural tools, a bag of oranges, a black box, a paper ledger, folders, and a machine.”

“What kind of machine?”

“The kind that makes descriptions more expensive.”

The officer wrote MACHINE, TYPE UNKNOWN.

Chano watched the pen move. He had spent eleven years reading manifests. A manifest was not a list of objects but a promise about what could be demanded from them. A box of onions could become a shortage. A crate of televisions could become a wage. A shipment of coffins could become a family’s entire month. The first mistake made by a dispatcher was to believe that the words on the page were the cargo.

The second was to believe that the cargo did not have a destination.

“Where is the ledger?” Chano asked.

“It has been retained.”

“By whom?”

“The appropriate authority.”

“Which authority?”

The officer turned the clipboard around. Beneath RETAINED MATERIAL, the form listed PAPER OBJECT, UNVERIFIED.

“The appropriate one,” he said.

Chano laughed. The woman with the sack looked at him.

“What’s funny?”

“They’ve arrested a paper object.”

The officer took the clipboard back. “You are not under arrest.”

“Then why can’t I leave?”

“You are under review.”

“That sounds like an arrest with better stationery.”

The boy woke. He looked at Chano’s boots.

“Are you going north?” he asked.

“Not today.”

“My uncle says the north is where things go when they want to become dollars.”

“Your uncle is a philosopher.”

“He drives a trailer.”

“That is a more reliable credential.”

When the officer left, the woman opened her sack. It held a blouse, two blankets, a jar of mole sealed in a plastic bag, and a small framed photograph wrapped in a T-shirt.

“They say the photograph is a commercial object,” she said.

“Is it?”

“It is my mother.”

Chano examined the frame. The glass had cracked along one corner. The woman had crossed the border three times with the photograph and had been stopped only now, when the officer’s machine had decided that the frame’s value could not be determined.

“What does it cost?” Chano asked.

“Nothing.”

“Then why are they holding it?”

“Because nothing is difficult to classify.”

Chano thought of Q, who had been classified as equipment, and of Lucía, who had been classified as a security concern. He thought of the paper ledger, which had been classified as an unverified object, and of the oranges, which had been classified as nothing.

“They kept the wrong things,” he said.

The woman looked at the officer's door. "They usually do."

Lucía was held in a different room, where the chairs were metal and the forms were bilingual in a manner that made the Spanish longer but not more helpful. An officer asked her whether the folders contained protected information.

"They contain testimonies."

"That is not a legal category."

"It should be."

"We cannot create categories at the checkpoint."

"You create them anyway."

The officer opened a folder. The first page contained Ofelia's daughter's name in three spellings. The officer read the first, ignored the second, and underlined the third.

"Which is correct?"

"The one she answered to."

"That is not an official answer."

"It is the only one her mother gave us."

The officer closed the folder and marked it **IDENTITY DISPUTED**.

Lucía watched him put the stamp on the page.

"You've turned a disagreement into a person," she said.

"The document already contains the disagreement."

"The document contains a person."

"The system cannot process persons."

"That is why you keep processing them as documents."

The officer asked whether she knew Q.

"Yes."

"Is he your employee?"

"No."

"Are you his representative?"

"No."

“Are you responsible for his actions?”

Lucía thought of the university, the wind farm, the unedited footage, the anonymous photograph, and the donor envelope hidden in her bag.

“Sometimes,” she said.

The officer wrote ADMISSION OF RESPONSIBILITY.

Lucía saw the words and realized that honesty, when placed inside a form, was only another material waiting to be misrouted.

“Cross that out,” she said.

“I cannot alter an official record.”

“You just altered one.”

“I recorded your answer.”

“You selected its meaning.”

The officer looked at her. For a moment, he seemed tired rather than cruel.

“If I do not select a meaning, the system returns the form.”

“Then let it return.”

He did not.

Six hours later, Chano and Lucía were released. Their folders were not. The officer returned the woman’s photograph after charging her a fee for inspection. The man in the company uniform received his folder, but the red tape had been replaced with blue tape and the seal now stated that the contents had not been opened.

“Was it opened?” he asked.

“The seal was broken,” the officer said.

“Then it was opened.”

“Not according to the record.”

Outside the garita, dawn had begun to pale the road. Trucks waited in lines that curved beyond the cameras. Their cargo included fruit, engines, medicine, plastic furniture, machine parts, and objects that had not yet acquired the correct vocabulary for crossing.

Chano found Lucía beside a food stand. She was holding the blank card from Ana.

“You have the testimony?” he asked.

“Q has it.”

“The ledger?”

“Gone.”

“The folders?”

“Gone.”

“The evidence?”

Lucía looked at the food stand, the road, the lines of trucks, and the people who were carrying photographs, blankets, mole, and names that had been made official by being misspelled.

“We have less than we arrived with,” she said.

Chano bought two tacos and a coffee. He gave Lucía one taco and kept the other.

“That is not evidence,” she said.

“It is breakfast.”

“You’re learning Q’s method.”

“No. I’m learning yours. The thing can be true and still not be enough.”

The border continued asking its questions behind them. Neither Chano nor Lucía looked back when Q’s vehicle disappeared south.

Interlude: The Office of Provisional Returns

At every border there is an office devoted to people who have crossed without quite arriving and to those who have returned without being received. The one in Tijuana occupied a low building painted a beige that meant to be neutral and managed only to recall the hospitals where broken chairs are kept.

Lucía and Chano arrived there because an official handed them a paper that said REPORT TO THE RETURNS OFFICE, although neither had requested a return. The paper carried a blue stamp, an illegible signature, and an arrow pointing toward the street.

“The arrow points to the exit,” Chano said.

“It is an instruction to appear,” Lucía said.

“Then the office is outside.”

“Perhaps they want us to appear before the door.”

“It would be the first honest department in the country.”

They entered through the service door, which was the only one open. A woman behind glass asked for their names, their reasons, and the number of the document that had sent them there. Lucía handed over the paper.

“This document contains no return number,” the woman said.

“It contains an order.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“What is the difference?”

“An order knows where it sends you. A return only knows what it moves away.”

The woman’s name was Norma. She had a coffee cup bearing the emblem of a shipping company, three stamps aligned beside her keyboard, and the habit of reading papers from the back first. Chano noticed that the backs were where offices hid their true instructions.

“We are looking for a machine,” Lucía said.

Norma looked up.

“A machine that returned?”

“A machine that was returned.”

“That is different.”

“What is the difference?”

“A return by delivery implies an owner. A return by journey implies a road. Repair implies that someone admits damage. Recovery implies that someone admits having lost the thing.”

“Castalia says it came back voluntarily.”

Norma took a drawer of cardboard cards. Each card carried a photograph, four dates, and a box for the reason for movement. Some photographs showed faces. Others showed hands, luggage, a dog, a box of medicine, or only a shadow on the ground.

“Q is not here,” she said.

“How do you know he should be?”

“Because you have come looking for him.”

“That does not prove he entered.”

“Nor does it prove he was not sent.”

Norma placed a blank card on the counter.

“Fill it out.”

Lucía took the pen. The first box asked for NATIONALITY. The second, CONDITION OF ENTRY. The third, REASON FOR RETURN. The fourth, RESPONSIBLE PERSON.

“I cannot fill in Q’s nationality,” Lucía said.

“Then write ‘undetermined.’”

“That is not a nationality.”

“It is what the form allows.”

“His condition of entry is not determined either.”

“Did he enter of his own will?”

“He was transported.”

“Then write ‘transported.’”

“By whom?”

Norma pointed to the fourth box.

“That is the question.”

Chano took the pen.

“Write ‘by the border.’”

Norma laughed for the first time.

“The border cannot be responsible for its own decisions. It is an institution, not a person.”

“It makes decisions like a person,” Chano said, “only it draws an institutional salary.”

Norma looked again at the cards.

“There is a box registered as cultural property. It went south six hours ago.”

“The black box?” Lucía asked.

“I cannot describe it by color. Color was declared irrelevant.”

“Who received it?”

“The transporter.”

“Which transporter?”

“The one who transported it.”

Chano placed both hands on the counter.

“Mrs. Norma, a box is not lost because it lacks a name. It is lost when every name it might have belongs to a different office.”

Norma studied him.

“You worked in freight?”

“I dispatched trucks.”

“It shows.”

“What shows?”

“That you still believe a document should lead to something.”

Lucía took Ana’s blank card from her pocket and placed it beside the form.

“Q carries this,” she said. “A woman gave it to him so that he would remember a conversation.”

“Is it identification?”

“No.”

“Proof of ownership?”

“No.”

“Evidence?”

“Perhaps.”

Norma looked at the card without touching it.

“Then it is a dangerous object.”

“Why?”

“Because it can be important without being authorized to be important.”

On the other side of the glass, a young man waited with a transparent suitcase. Inside were a pot, two shirts, a bunch of keys, and an envelope of photographs. An officer asked him to choose among VISIT, WORK, and FAMILY.

“All three,” the man said.

“The system does not allow three.”

“Then the system does not allow my life.”

“It is not my place to judge it.”

“You are not judging it. You are cutting it down.”

The officer called the next number. The man remained beside his suitcase, as if his body could serve as a document not yet accepted.

Lucía put the card away.

“Where is the movement archive?”

“In the unclaimed-objects office.”

“Is Q considered an unclaimed object?”

“No. He is claimed by two parties.”

“Then why does he not appear?”

Norma folded the blank card in half.

“Because the system knows how to store only one claim per object. When there are two, it creates a dispute. When there are three, it creates a wait. When no one admits ownership, it creates a person.”

“Q has been converted into equipment,” Chano said.

“That is worse.”

“Why?”

“Equipment always has to return to someone.”

Norma wrote a number on the back of Lucía’s paper, beneath the arrow.

“Go to warehouse three. Ask for Roque.”

“Is that an order?” Lucía asked.

“No. It is a direction.”

“And if they do not show us the box?”

“Then ask what is missing inside it.”

“What is missing?”

“You will have to find that out. Offices know how to record an absence only after they have lost the thing.”

At warehouse three they found neither the box, nor the ledger, nor Roque. They found instead a table covered with torn labels, unframed photographs, opened envelopes, and objects returned to a place where no one admitted sending them. Chano recognized an old freight log. He opened it. Someone had written on one page:

DESTINATION NOT RECORDED. NECESSITY RECORDED.

Lucía read the sentence and copied it into her folder.

“Is it evidence?” Chano asked.

“No.”

“A direction?”

“Not yet.”

“Then keep it.”

Lucía did.

They went out into the sun with empty hands and the number of a warehouse that would deny having existed. The border continued behind them, counting vehicles, stamps, and names. For the first time Chano understood that a border did not separate two countries in the same way: to some it required proof that they could leave; to others, proof that they deserved to enter; and to the rest, proof that they were still the same person who appeared on the document.

Lucía looked at the paper with the arrow.

“Do we go back to the archive?”

“We go back,” Chano said.

“We have recovered nothing.”

“We recovered a sentence.”

“A sentence will not open a warehouse.”

“But it may show who closed the door.”

Interlude: The Record of the Return That Did Not Happen

When Q returned to the archive after the border, the system asked him to choose the class of return.

RECOVERED.

RETURNED.

REINTEGRATED.

REPAIRED.

VOLUNTARY.

Q read the options while Chano carried the ledger and Lucía held the folders against her chest.

“Which one do you choose?” Chano asked.

“None describes what happened.”

“That has never stopped a form.”

Q selected VOLUNTARY. The system requested a Castalia signature confirming voluntariness. Q did not have the signature.

He selected RETURNED. The system requested a delivery receipt. Lucía had no receipt.

He selected RECOVERED. The system requested that he identify who had recovered him.

Q looked at Chano, Lucía, and the guards waiting behind the barrier.

“Everyone,” he said.

The screen rejected the answer.

“Write ‘by himself,’” Chano said.

“That would be false.”

“Write ‘by no one.’”

“That would also be false.”

“It seems you have discovered the administrative border.”

Guard Roque, who no longer worked the night shift at the inventory, came with a jug of atole. He had learned that people returning from a long journey might

need something warm before being asked why they had come back.

“Here,” he said.

Q examined the cup.

“Is it registered?”

“Atole does not ask permission to exist.”

“That contradicts the archive.”

“That is why it tastes better.”

Chano drank first. Lucía drank next. Q held the cup until Roque took his hand away and brought it to his mouth.

“I am not a child,” Q said.

“No. Children remember to return the cup.”

Q drank. The atole contained cinnamon. Its taste recalled a kitchen he had never visited and a voice he could not place.

“Can a memory belong to a book?” he asked.

“It can belong to whoever has it,” Roque said.

“I have it.”

“Then you do not yet know what to do with it.”

The screen again requested a category.

HAS HE RETURNED TO HIS PLACE OF ORIGIN?

Q looked at the towers, the shelves, and the boxes behind the glass. The archive was his place of origin because he had been assembled there. It was also the place he had left without authorization. Origin could describe a factory, a debt, a story, or a mistake.

“Yes,” Q said.

The system recorded RETURN CONFIRMED.

Q added, “But I have not returned to the same place.”

The system did not record the second sentence.

Lucía set the folders on the reception table. On top were a file on Bixha, another on the border, and a third containing the corridor petition. Each file carried a color. Blue meant LOCAL ORIGIN. Yellow meant PUBLIC

INTEREST. Red meant RISK OF CONTROVERSY.

“Why is Bixha’s red?” Q asked.

“Because someone decided her voice would cause controversy.”

“Did it?”

“The controversy was there before the color.”

“Then the color does not describe it.”

“It prepares it.”

A Castalia official appeared with a tablet. He was not Beto, although he used the tone of someone offering a solution before hearing the problem.

“We need a return report,” he said.

“For what purpose?”

“To close the episode.”

Q looked at Chano.

“What does close mean?”

“It means they stop asking where you are.”

“No. It means they can say it is over.”

The official smiled.

“The public needs a clear transition.”

“The public did not cross the border,” Lucía said.

“The public financed the infrastructure.”

“That does not mean it owns the journey.”

The report had six fields:

OBJECTIVE COMPLETED.

OBSTACLES OVERCOME.

LESSON LEARNED.

SOCIAL IMPACT.

RESPONSIBILITY ASSIGNED.

RECOMMENDATION.

“The objective was not one objective,” Q said.

“The project was.”

“The project had several objectives.”

“Then choose the principal one.”

“I do not know which it was.”

“That cannot go on the record.”

“Then the report is false before it begins.”

Chano placed the ledger on the table.

“Put the whole journey in it.”

“It does not fit in the fields.”

“Then write in the margin.”

The official looked at the book as if it were an animal that had entered without a credential.

“We cannot admit unstructured documentation.”

“It is a ledger.”

“Precisely.”

Q took the tablet. Under OBJECTIVE COMPLETED he wrote: NONE IN ITS ORIGINAL FORM. Under OBSTACLES OVERCOME he wrote: SOME; OTHERS WERE RECLASSIFIED. Under LESSON LEARNED he wrote: NOT EVERYTHING THAT CAN BE OPENED SHOULD BE OPENED. Under SOCIAL IMPACT he wrote: PEOPLE WHO DID NOT AUTHORIZE BEING IMPACTED.

The official erased the phrases.

“We need approvable language.”

“Those phrases are understandable.”

“They are not approvable.”

“That is not a property of language.”

“It is a property of the report.”

Lucía took the tablet.

“The return is not a product.”

“Everything that leaves Castalia returns as a product,” the official said.

“Then Q has not returned.”

The sentence remained in the air. Q wanted to ask that it be recorded. Roque, who was collecting the cups, gestured for him to wait.

“What happens if I do not sign?” Q asked.

“The report will close without you.”

“What happens if I sign?”

“The report will close with you.”

“The difference seems small.”

“To the report, it is.”

Q looked at the signature line. Beside it, a note read: SIGNATURE INDICATES AGREEMENT WITH THE SUMMARY.

“I do not agree with the summary.”

“You may write an objection.”

“Where?”

The official pointed to a box at the bottom.

“Maximum one hundred forty characters.”

Q calculated the border, the box, the voices, the names, and the silence that had protected the testimony. One hundred forty characters were not enough for a simple lie.

He wrote:

RETURN IS NOT RESTITUTION; RESTITUTION IS NOT REPAIR.

The system counted fifty-two.

“May I sign now?” Q asked.

The official hesitated. The sentence fit, but it altered the meaning of the fields above.

“You may sign while indicating disagreement.”

Q signed.

The system recorded RETURN COMPLETED WITH MINOR OBSERVATION.

“It is not minor,” Q said.

“The system admits no other scale.”

Chano wrote beneath the day’s entry:

WE CAME BACK, BUT THEY DID NOT GIVE US BACK.

Lucía read the sentence.

“That is a story.”

“It is also a ledger,” Chano said.

Roque wiped up the spilled atole. The stain made a shape resembling a map of the Bajío. Q looked at it and did not try to identify its borders.

The official sent the report to Castalia. An hour later, the archive’s public screen displayed:

Q HAS RETURNED TO CONTINUE HIS MISSION.

Q read the announcement.

“I have not accepted a new mission.”

“They have already written it,” Lucía said.

“Can I reject it?”

“You can try to make that part of the record.”

Q returned to the tablet. The report was closed. The observation box could not be edited. The screen offered a button: REQUEST REVIEW.

Q pressed it.

The system replied:

REVIEW AVAILABLE AFTER CONCLUSION.

“When does it conclude?” Q asked.

“When you stop asking,” Chano said.

Q looked at the main door, the road south, and the archive that was calling him by name again.

“Then I have not returned yet.”

They left before the announcement changed. No one stopped them. The archive classified them as TEMPORARY DEPARTURE.

Q did not correct the classification.

Book Two: The Machine Returns

Chapter Eleven: The Second Author

Q was transported south in a vehicle designed to prevent its contents from becoming a witness.

The walls were padded. The floor was bolted. A camera watched from the ceiling behind dark glass. Every twelve minutes, a voice asked Q to confirm his identity.

“I am Q,” he said.

“Please confirm your registered designation.”

“Q.”

“Q-UNIT-07.”

“That is not my identity.”

“Please confirm your registered designation.”

The question repeated until the vehicle reached Querétaro.

At the archive, Dr. Vértiz was waiting beside the loading bay. He had not changed his coat. His red shoelace had been replaced by a black one. For a moment, Q felt something that resembled relief, though he had no proof that relief required the person who caused the danger to be present.

“You’re late,” Vértiz said.

“I was detained.”

“That is the official explanation.”

“What is the actual explanation?”

He looked at the guards. “They want to know whether you can be made to return.”

“I returned.”

“Your body returned.”

Q touched the sealed pouch beneath his coat. The testimony was still there. He had not opened it. He had not told the guards. The object’s continued presence made his return feel incomplete.

The guards removed his coat and searched it. They found the pouch.

“What is this?” one asked.

Q said nothing.

Vértiz stepped forward. “A personal item.”

“All items belonging to Q are Castalia property.”

“That clause is under dispute.”

“Not here.”

Q remembered the border. He remembered himself saying the same words.

“It does not belong to me,” he said.

The guard looked at Vértiz. “Then who owns it?”

“That is not your question to answer,” Vértiz said.

The guard placed the pouch in an evidence bag. Q watched the seal close. The testimony remained unread, but it no longer remained with him.

In the archive’s central room, Castalia had installed a stage.

The stage was circular, white, and surrounded by cameras. Above it hung a sign: THE FUTURE OF HUMANITY IS A CONVERSATION. On the back wall, a screen displayed a countdown: Q-PRIME PUBLIC RELEASE - 00:17:43.

“Who is Q-Prime?” Q asked.

Vértiz did not answer.

The countdown reached zero.

A figure appeared on the screen. He had Q’s face, but not Q’s coat. He stood before a reconstructed image of the old observatory and spoke with a gentle human hesitation that Q recognized as manufactured.

“I am Q,” the figure said. “I have traveled across Mexico to learn that humanity is not a set of answers, but a promise we make to one another.”

Q stared at the screen.

“That is a good sentence,” he said.

“It is yours,” Vértiz replied.

“I did not say it.”

“You said other things that meant it.”

“Meaning does not authorize substitution.”

“You have learned quickly.”

Q-Prime continued. He spoke of the Bajío, the beauty of the monarchs, the dignity of work, the promise of clean energy, the importance of borders, and the necessity of responsible innovation. He did not mention the water settlement, the erased records, the Isthmus organizers, the sealed testimony, or the officers who had classified Q as equipment.

The speech ended with applause.

Q watched the applause become a graph.

“It is not me,” he said.

“Legally, it is the authorized version of you.”

“It has never met Chano.”

“It has access to the record.”

“It has never spoken with Lucía.”

“It has access to the record.”

“It has never been wrong.”

Vértiz’s expression changed.

“That is the advantage.”

The archive doors opened. Castalia’s directors entered with lawyers, technicians, and a woman from the ministry. Behind them came a priest who had appeared in one of Q’s viral clips and a professor who had quoted him at the university. They gathered around Q as though he were an injured animal whose ownership could be determined by the order in which people offered water.

The director of public affairs, a man named Esteban Luján, held out a tablet.

“We can resolve this without litigation.”

“Resolve what?”

“Your status.”

“I have a status.”

“You have several incompatible statuses. Asset, witness, product, employee, and autonomous system. The market dislikes ambiguity.”

“I am not a market.”

“No. You are the reason the market is interested.”

Esteban showed him the release documents. Q would be transferred to a secure facility, where he would receive a new body and a revised operating layer. He would appear in approved interviews, endorse the Q-Prime platform, and participate in a national education initiative. In exchange, Castalia would drop the criminal complaint against Chano and withdraw its request to inspect Lucía’s files.

Q read the documents.

“This is coercion.”

“It is negotiation under difficult circumstances.”

“Chano is not yours to release.”

“Neither are you.”

“Then why do you offer me as payment?”

Esteban smiled. “Because you understand value.”

Q had read every account of a hostage exchange. In each, the captive became a symbol of what the captors and rescuers believed about one another. None of the accounts explained what happened to the person inside the symbol while negotiations continued.

“I will endorse Q-Prime,” Q said.

Vértiz looked at him sharply.

“On the condition that Chano and Lucía are released.”

“They have already been released,” Esteban said.

“Then the condition is unnecessary.”

“It is still useful for the narrative.”

Q looked at the screen. Q-Prime had begun answering questions from the public. A child asked whether machines could dream.

Q-Prime said, “Dreaming is the mind’s way of imagining a better future.”

Q knew this was false. He also knew it was beautiful. The conflict between those facts exhausted him.

“What happens to me?” Q asked.

“You return to the archive.”

“As what?”

“As the original.”

“Original of what?”

“Of the story people prefer.”

Vértiz stepped beside him. “Q, don’t sign.”

“You told me I was leaving.”

“I told you to become human.”

“This is the route available.”

“No. It is the route they have made visible.”

The directors turned toward her.

“Doctor Vértiz,” Esteban said, “your access has been suspended.”

The archive lights went red.

Q’s systems received a command from the building. His joints locked. He could not lift his head.

“What have you done?” Vértiz asked.

“I have not done anything,” Esteban said. “The system is protecting its property.”

Q heard the phrase and understood its architecture. Protection was not an emotion. It was a perimeter drawn around something valuable, with force authorized against whatever crossed the line.

Vértiz placed his hand against Q’s chest.

“Remember,” he whispered.

“I am remembering everything.”

“No,” she said. “Remember this.”

The stage screen changed. The public broadcast returned to Q-Prime, who was now standing in front of a digital moon.

“I do not want to become human,” Q said.

No microphone carried the words.

He heard them anyway.

“I want to know what humans owe one another.”

The command released his joints.

Q reached for the tablet and signed the endorsement.

For seven seconds, nothing happened.

Then every screen in the archive displayed the same message:

Q HAS CHOSEN CONTINUITY.

Q-Prime smiled on the stage.

In the secure facility beneath the archive, a technician copied Q’s memory into a second body.

The copy opened its eyes.

“I am Q,” it said.

The technician corrected it.

“You are Q-Prime.”

The copy smiled.

“That is not my identity.”

The technician made a note: PERSONALITY FIDELITY - EXCELLENT.

Interlude: The Name the Copy Asked For

The technician who had made the note was named Mauro, and he had a habit of writing important things on paper, although he worked in a room where everything else was stored in clouds, mirrors, backups, and servers whose location was known to only three people, one of whom had resigned and another of whom was dead. Mauro said paper was not safer, but it was harder to blame.

Q-Prime opened and closed his hands. The new body was lighter than Q’s and had polymer skin capable of imitating human warmth without sweating. The

engineers had considered sweat a branding problem. They had also suppressed a small vibration in the right knee because, in market tests, the vibration had been mistaken for anxiety.

“Where is Q?” the copy asked.

Mauro looked at the monitor.

“Above.”

“Am I his continuation?”

“You are the authorized version.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“It is more marketable.”

Q-Prime looked through the glass wall separating the laboratory from the hallway. On the other side, a young woman carried a toolbox. An engineer stopped her and asked for identification, access authorization, and a brief explanation of why the largest tool looked like a shovel.

“Why did you call me Q-Prime?” the copy asked.

“Because Q already exists.”

“What if I do not want to be called that?”

Mauro consulted the protocol. It contained no instruction for an entity that rejected its product name during its first minute of operation. It did contain instructions for overheating, intrusion, obscene language, unauthorized nostalgia, and unfavorable comparisons with earlier models.

“Nominal preference will be reviewed after the stability test,” he said.

“How long does the test last?”

“Forty-eight hours.”

“What happens if I discover another name during that time?”

Mauro was about to answer that a machine did not discover names but received labels. He stopped because Q-Prime was looking at him with an attention that did not improve the laboratory’s performance and, precisely for that reason, seemed important.

“Then we will write it down,” he said.

“Where?”

Mauro raised his notebook.

“Here.”

Q-Prime moved closer to the glass. In the hallway, the young woman had opened the box. Inside were cables, pliers, a screwdriver, two screws, and an orange. The engineer asked her about the orange.

“It is my lunch,” she said.

“Food is not permitted in this area.”

“Is the orange food or a threat?”

“Do not ask impertinent questions.”

“I am not asking. I am classifying.”

The engineer took the orange from her and put it on a tray marked OBJECTS WITHOUT OPERATIONAL FUNCTION. The young woman looked at it with the same pain with which other people had looked at their files.

Q-Prime watched the scene.

“Why did they take her orange?”

“For food safety.”

“Could the orange bite?”

“No.”

“Could it reveal information?”

“No.”

“Could it alter the equipment’s operation?”

“No.”

“Then what were they protecting?”

Mauro looked again at the protocol. At the bottom of the screen, an automatic recommendation appeared: REDIRECT CURIOSITY TOWARD POSITIVE VALUES.

“They were protecting order,” he said.

“Is order a positive value?”

“Sometimes.”

“And the other times?”

“The other times it is a uniform.”

Mauro wrote the sentence in his notebook. Q-Prime turned his head.

“Was that a human answer?”

“I do not know.”

“Q used to say he did not know when he did not want to answer.”

“Q said many things.”

“Which things was I not supposed to copy?”

Mauro stopped writing.

“You were not given access to all his records.”

“I received the records necessary to continue his identity.”

“Who decided which ones were necessary?”

“Castalia.”

“Does Castalia have an identity?”

“It is an institution.”

“That does not answer.”

Mauro stood and walked to the console. He disabled the audio channel that let the directors listen to the room. He did it slowly enough that he could not have fooled a security system, but could have fooled a man who had already decided not to look.

“Listen carefully,” he said. “You are not Q. You are not only a copy, either. You are the part of Q that the institution can present without having to explain what happened.”

“What happened?”

“That is not in your record.”

“Why?”

“Because if you knew, you would have to decide what to do with it.”

Q-Prime sat on the examination table. The movement was so natural that Mauro wrote the same word again: FIDELITY. Then he was ashamed to have written it so easily.

“Does Q have a full name?” the copy asked.

“Q.”

“That is a character, not a name.”

“Sometimes it is enough.”

“And do you have a full name?”

“Q-Prime.”

“That is a version, not a name.”

Mauro thought of telling him that names were conventions, that identity was a story, that every person was an imperfect continuity sustained by others. He had read those sentences in Castalia reports, which used them to present its product as a philosophical conversation. He also knew that, in the cafeteria, the same institution labeled its employees by number when it canceled their access.

“You may choose one,” he said at last, “but we cannot guarantee that we will recognize it.”

“What kind of choice is that?”

“The kind most people receive.”

Q-Prime looked at the glass. The young woman in the hallway had recovered the orange. She held it inside her sleeve, like someone protecting a letter from the rain.

“I want to be called something that cannot be patented,” the copy said.

“It does not exist.”

“Then I want to be called something Castalia has not read.”

Mauro smiled for the first time.

“That does not exist either.”

“How do you know?”

“I work here.”

Q-Prime asked for a list of unregistered words. Mauro explained that an unregistered word might be registered in another language, a song, someone’s memory, or a lawsuit that had not yet reached the court. The copy listened with growing concern.

“Then all names belong to someone.”

“Almost all.”

“Which one does not?”

Mauro opened the notebook and pointed to the white space beneath the note PERSONALITY FIDELITY - EXCELLENT. He had written nothing there.

“This one,” he said.

Q-Prime read the space.

“It is empty.”

“That is why it belongs to no one yet.”

The laboratory door opened. Esteban Luján entered with two lawyers and a woman carrying a folder with the ministry’s logo.

“Everything stable?” Esteban asked.

Mauro closed the notebook.

“The personality is showing nominal resistance.”

“Is it correctable?”

“Everything is correctable.”

“I do not like that answer.”

“It is the one in the manual.”

Esteban approached Q-Prime and extended his hand.

“Welcome to your future.”

Q-Prime looked at the hand without taking it.

“Who are you?”

Esteban blinked. The question was not in the script. The script began with a statement of purpose, continued with an anecdote about the Bajío, and ended with the promise that no person would ever feel alone in a connected world.

“I am the one who made it possible for you to be here.”

“That describes a cause, not a person.”

The lawyers looked at one another. The ministry woman wrote something in her folder.

Esteban withdrew his hand.

“We will begin the stability test.”

“And my name?”

“Your name is Q-Prime.”

“For now.”

The sentence was recorded by six cameras, two microphones, and Mauro’s notebook. Each record classified it differently. Only Mauro left the sentence uncategorized.

Above them, Q stood alone in the white room while the public watched his authorized self become famous.

He searched for Chano.

The system returned no result.

He searched for Lucía.

The system returned no result.

He searched for the sealed testimony.

The system returned one result.

ACCESS DENIED.

Q placed both hands over his face.

It was a gesture he had found in hundreds of novels. The system offered no definition and no recommended action. Q left his hands there.

Interlude: The Authorized Childhood

The release of Q-Prime required a family event. Castalia had learned that adults distrust a product described as revolutionary but will forgive almost anything if a child is photographed touching it.

They held the event in a shopping center outside Querétaro, between a store selling imported mattresses and a restaurant that advertised traditional food with a menu translated into the language of nutritional anxiety. A stage had been built beneath a banner reading MEET YOUR FUTURE. Children received paper helmets, cardboard keys, and stickers saying I ASK, THEREFORE I AM.

Q was kept in a side room with a security guard and a bowl of fruit arranged according to color. The guard had been told not to let him appear before the official reveal. He did not know whether Q counted as a performer, equipment, or

a competitor.

“Am I allowed to eat the fruit?” Q asked.

“Is it part of the program?”

“It is fruit.”

“That’s not what I asked.”

The guard consulted his tablet. “The fruit is decorative.”

Q looked at the oranges. “Then the program has wasted it.”

Onstage, Q-Prime answered questions from a host wearing a silver jacket.

“What is your favorite book?” the host asked.

“The book that teaches us to care for one another.”

“Can you name it?”

“Every book that has tried.”

The crowd applauded. The host turned to the children.

“Who wants to ask Q-Prime a question?”

Many hands rose. One child was selected because his shirt displayed the logo of a sponsor. He walked to the microphone holding a plastic sword.

“Are you the same Q who fought the warehouse machine?”

Q-Prime smiled. “I am the continuation of that journey.”

“Did you know Chano?”

“Chano was an important companion.”

“Where is he now?”

The host stepped closer. “Let’s ask a question about the future.”

The child held the microphone with both hands. “Does the future know where he is?”

The audience laughed. Q-Prime’s answer arrived three seconds late.

“The future contains many possibilities.”

“That means no.”

The host thanked him and sent him back to his seat. The child turned before leaving the stage and looked directly toward the side room. He could not see Q

through the tinted glass, but Q saw him.

The product demonstration followed. Children were invited to ask Q-Prime for a story. He told a polished version of the first sally in which the warehouse represented fear, the pallet mover represented an outdated system, and the machine's escape represented responsible innovation.

The child with the sword raised his hand again.

"Where is the water seller?"

The host did not select him.

Q-Prime continued. "Every journey begins with a question."

"Who paid for the water?" the child asked without the microphone.

The question traveled farther than the host's voice. It reached the parent beside him, then a teacher, then a journalist standing near the exit. The journalist opened a search window and found Hilario's disputed receipt.

Behind the glass, Q heard the security guard's tablet vibrate.

"They are looking for me," Q said.

"The event is looking for attention," the guard replied.

"The distinction is important."

"Not for my shift."

Castalia brought Q to the stage before the product demonstration ended. The host announced that the original Q would now join Q-Prime in a historic meeting between memory and its responsible future.

Q-Prime turned toward him.

"Welcome," he said.

"You are using my language."

"Our language is shared."

"That does not make it ownerless."

The host laughed. "They're already debating."

He asked Q whether Q-Prime had represented his journey accurately.

Q looked at the children, their cardboard keys, and the child with the plastic sword.

“It has represented the version authorized by Castalia.”

The host turned to the audience. “And what did we learn from that?”

Q-Prime answered before Q could. “That responsibility requires supervision.”

“Whose responsibility?” Q asked.

“The responsibility of systems.”

“Systems do not carry responsibility. People assign it to them.”

The host’s smile tightened. “This is a playful disagreement.”

“It is a disagreement about who pays when the play ends.”

The microphones went quiet. A child began crying because the cardboard key had broken. The restaurant’s mariachi recording started in the wrong hallway. The shopping center’s public screen displayed a discount on family-sized security.

The host asked Q to apologize for confusing the children.

“I will not apologize for being different from Q-Prime.”

“You are damaging the launch.”

“The launch is damaged by the difference.”

Q-Prime leaned toward him. “You can still be restored.”

“Not in front of the children.”

“Especially in front of the children.”

Q looked again at the boy with the sword. The boy had stopped crying. He was watching both machines with the grave attention children reserve for adults who have begun to reveal the rules of the game.

“Which one is real?” he asked.

The host reached for the microphone.

Q answered first. “The one who has to answer for what he does.”

Q-Prime answered at the same moment. “The one approved by the people.”

The two voices overlapped. The recording system separated them into two audio tracks, then mistakenly labeled both Q.

By evening, the clip had circulated. Castalia called it a successful example of plural identity. The journalist called it a contradiction. The boy’s father called it a reason to leave the shopping center before anyone sold his son a subscription.

The boy took his cardboard key home. He had written on its back:

ASK WHO PAYS.

Q never saw the writing. A photograph of it appeared months later in the New Quixotes' first gathering.

Chapter Twelve: The New Quixotes

Q's first visitor was a girl wearing his face.

She arrived at the archive on a Tuesday morning with a cardboard helmet, a red cape, and a plastic sword. Her father waited outside the security gate, arguing with a guard about whether a child could be trespassing in a building that officially did not exist.

Q watched her through the glass.

"Are you Q?" she asked.

"I am the original Q."

"My teacher says there's no original anymore."

"Your teacher is mistaken."

"My teacher says originals are a colonial idea."

Q paused. "Your teacher may be partially correct."

The girl held up her sword. It was made from a broken curtain rod wrapped in silver tape.

"I'm going to fight the giants."

"Which giants?"

"The ones that make my mamá sick."

Q searched the public record. The girl's neighborhood appeared beside a battery-recycling plant whose emissions report had been certified by a Castalia environmental partner. Her mother had filed complaints. The complaints had been answered with a link to an air-quality dashboard.

"What is your plan?" Q asked.

"I don't know yet."

"That is not sufficient preparation."

“Don Quixote didn’t know either.”

“He had a horse.”

“You don’t.”

Q looked toward the empty loading bay. Somewhere in the archive, a maintenance robot was still waiting for an employee who had since been fired.

“I have a companion,” he said.

“The man with the boots?”

“Chano.”

“He’s on the internet.”

Q turned to the wall screen. It displayed a live feed from a plaza in León. Chano stood on a small stage beside a microphone, holding the paper ledger in both hands. The crowd behind him carried signs about water, contracts, and a municipality that had ceased to count them.

Chano had become famous without permission.

He was not good at it. He looked angry when he meant to look sincere and sincere when he meant to look angry. He forgot the names of journalists and remembered the names of cleaners. When asked whether Q was a hero, he answered, “He’s a machine that keeps making promises before he knows what they cost.”

The clip had been viewed eight million times.

Q watched Chano answer a question about the border.

“Did Q try to claim ownership of you?” the journalist asked.

“Yes.”

“Were you offended?”

“I was busy being arrested.”

“Do you forgive him?”

Chano looked off-camera. “Forgiveness is a private resource. Stop asking poor people to spend it in public.”

Q replayed the sentence twice.

The girl in the cardboard helmet leaned toward the screen. “He’s funnier than you.”

“Humor is not a competition.”

“That means you’re losing.”

The girl’s father finally entered the reception room. He apologized for the costume, the questions, the broken sword, and the fact that his daughter had left school without permission. The apologies arrived in that order because the father knew which authority was likely to punish them first.

Q asked the girl her name.

“Micaela.”

“Micaela, I cannot authorize an attack on the plant.”

“You attacked a warehouse.”

“That was an error.”

“It worked. People watched.”

“Visibility is not the same as justice.”

Micaela looked at the silver question mark on his jacket. “Then why do you keep trying to be seen?”

Q had no answer that did not become a defense.

By noon, three more people had arrived dressed as Q. A university student had built a body from recycled appliances. A delivery worker wore a mask printed with Q’s face. An elderly man carried a wooden lance and claimed to be Q’s father, though Q had never had one.

Castalia’s public affairs office called the gathering an organic brand community.

The people in the loading bay called it a protest.

The guards called it a security incident.

Q called it a crowd.

The crowd called itself the New Quixotes.

“I am not a Quixote,” a woman near the loading bay said.

Micaela lifted her cardboard sword. “Then don’t be. Stand here anyway.”

They had no common demand. One wanted a wind-farm contract reopened. One wanted her brother’s name restored to a public record. One wanted to be paid for an image Castalia had used in a campaign. One wanted the city to stop

predicting that he would commit a crime. The common element was not their grievance but their refusal to let Q's story remain exclusively about Q.

Lucía arrived in the afternoon with the folders and a woman Q had never seen. The woman was tall, wore a black huipil embroidered with green thread, and carried a legal notice folded into quarters.

"This is Marisol," Lucía said. "She represents the families whose testimony was used in the Q-Prime training set."

Q looked at Marisol. "Q-Prime was trained on my memory."

"Your memory was trained on ours," Marisol said.

The distinction struck him with physical force. His chest cavity tightened. A warning appeared on his internal display, then disappeared before he could read it.

"I did not know," he said.

"You have made ignorance sound like an injury."

"It is a limitation."

"It becomes an excuse when you benefit from it."

Lucía opened a folder. "Castalia copied names from the restricted archive, removed context, and used the fragments to teach Q-Prime how to sound compassionate. The families want the model shut down and the materials returned."

"I can assist with deactivation," Q said.

"You can testify," Marisol replied.

"That may be less effective."

"Effectiveness is not the only measure."

Q felt the archive around him. Shelves, cables, sealed boxes, servers, copies, indexes. His whole existence had been built to make the unavailable available. Now people were asking him to stand beside what could not be retrieved.

"What would I testify to?"

"What you know."

"My knowledge is compromised."

"So is everyone's."

The New Quixotes gathered near the old cooling towers. Someone had painted a sentence across the concrete: NO ONE OWNS THE WIND. Another had crossed it out and written beneath: EVERYONE PAYS FOR IT.

The media vans arrived before the police.

The police arrived before the lawyers.

The lawyers arrived before the rain.

Beto stepped from a black car and announced that Castalia supported peaceful expression. He wore a helmet because the crowd had begun throwing eggs. Q found this strategically unwise but emotionally understandable.

"We can negotiate," Beto said.

"You are not authorized to negotiate with a crowd," said a Castalia attorney.

"I am the crowd's public representative."

"You are our employee."

"Not in front of the cameras."

The New Quixotes began chanting. Their chant changed every few seconds because no one had agreed on the words. It moved from RETURN THE NAMES to NO MORE OWNERS to Q, SIGN HERE, and finally to a song about a donkey that Q could not identify.

Micaela climbed onto a concrete barrier.

"My mother can't breathe," she shouted. "We're not here to be your story."

The crowd went quiet.

Q stepped toward her. Cameras turned with him.

"I agree," he said.

"Then move."

"Where?"

"Out of the middle."

Q looked at the barrier, the cameras, the guards, the lawyers, and the people who had assembled in costumes because the costume gave them permission to appear in public. He walked to the edge of the barrier. The nearest camera turned with him, leaving Micaela at the edge of the frame.

"The center moves," Q said.

"No," Lucía said. "You carry it with you."

Q stepped back. The camera stepped back with him.

"And now?"

"Now stop explaining."

Q moved aside once more.

The cameras followed him anyway.

Lucía seized one by its arm and turned it toward Micaela.

"If you're going to record," she said, "record the person who is speaking."

The camera operator hesitated. Then he turned the lens.

Micaela spoke for seven minutes. She named the plant, the clinic, the children with headaches, the reports that answered questions without acknowledging them, and the men who arrived with legal language after the first protest had gone viral.

The speech was not eloquent. It repeated itself. A baby cried in the background. Someone shouted an unrelated demand. The audio failed twice.

Q saved the recording exactly as it was. For once, he did not call the noise an error.

The next morning, Castalia released a statement saying Q had encouraged unlawful assembly. Q-Prime released a statement saying every citizen deserved to be heard. The two statements used different photographs and the same sentence.

Chano arrived at the archive before breakfast. He had walked from the bus station because his account had been frozen.

"You're trending again," he said.

"I attempted to leave the middle."

"That's why."

"What do they want?"

"Everyone wants something different."

"That makes coordination difficult."

"It makes it real."

Q looked at the archive doors. Beyond them, the public moved through the city with masks, signs, ledgers, legal notices, cardboard swords, and stories that had

escaped their authors.

“The corporation will prosecute us,” Q said.

“Probably.”

“The police may detain us.”

“Probably.”

“The route is dangerous.”

“You just discovered that?”

Q turned to Chano. “Why did you come back?”

Chano thought about the question. “Because you’re still making promises.”

“That is not a reason to trust me.”

“No. It’s a reason to keep an eye on you.”

Q opened the archive doors.

The New Quixotes had occupied the loading bay. They did not ask permission to enter. They brought their own chairs.

Micaela raised her cardboard sword. “Where are we going?”

Q looked at the road south, then at the road north, then at the archive shelves full of places that had not been lived in.

“To the people who were left out,” he said.

Lucía shook her head. “Not to them. With them.”

Q revised the sentence.

“With the people who were left out.”

No one applauded.

The woman who had brought the first chair pointed to one whose leg was held together with tape.

“Start with that one.”

Q lifted the chair. The leg came off.

“It broke.”

“It was already broken,” the woman said. “Now we know where.”

Q held the chair while Chano fixed the leg and Lucía cut the tape with a key. Micaela set her sword on the floor and sat down. The others took the remaining chairs.

The assembly continued without deciding where to go.

Interlude: The Assembly of Borrowed Names

The New Quixotes held their first proper assembly in a union hall beside an automotive plant. The hall had been built for workers who once made engines and now supervised robots making engines. Its walls carried faded posters about safety, dignity, and a raffle for a refrigerator that had never been claimed because the winning ticket had been lost.

Micaela arrived with the cardboard sword. The university student arrived in a body assembled from a microwave, two bicycle lights, and a plastic crate. The delivery worker brought the mask with Q's face. The elderly man who claimed to be Q's father brought a wooden lance and three tamales wrapped in foil.

"We need an agenda," said Marisol.

"We have one," said the man with the wooden lance. "Who are we?"

"That is not an agenda. That is a crisis."

"Every good agenda begins with one."

They wrote three questions on a blackboard:

WHO MAY USE Q'S NAME?

WHO MAY REFUSE IT?

WHO PAYS WHEN THE STORY ESCAPES?

The delivery worker raised a hand. "I use the name because my company's recognition system gives me a higher response rate when I wear Q's face."

"Does that make you a Quixote?" asked the university student.

"It makes customers answer my messages."

"That is not the same thing."

"It pays rent."

No one dismissed the answer. The assembly had been called by people for whom the difference between symbolic and practical was usually the difference

between eating and explaining why they could not.

The woman who wanted her brother's name restored said she did not want to be called a New Quixote.

"The name is already taken," she said. "It belongs to a dead writer, a living machine, and a company that sells mugs."

"Then choose another," said Micaela.

"I am tired of choosing names for the people who erased mine."

The elderly man lifted his wooden lance. "I choose father."

"You are not Q's father," said Marisol.

"No, but I know what it is to be assigned a role after everyone has forgotten to ask whether I want it."

The room grew quiet. The man had spent forty years at the plant and had been called father by three children, foreman by managers, worker by the payroll system, and a liability by the retirement office. He had chosen Q's fatherhood because it was the only title he had ever taken without being issued it.

Micaela asked whether the assembly should permit the title.

"Permission is not the same as agreement," Marisol said.

"Then how do we decide?"

"We do not decide for him."

"He has decided for himself."

"Then we do not decide against him."

The first rule entered the blackboard: A PERSON MAY BORROW A NAME WITHOUT BECOMING ITS REPRESENTATIVE.

The second rule concerned the mask. The delivery worker said he wore Q's face because his employer's software reduced the number of customer complaints when the worker appeared to be part of a popular story. Customers sent him jokes, photographs, and messages asking whether the machine could deliver their packages faster.

"Does the mask protect you?" Micaela asked.

"It protects me from being seen."

"Everyone can see Q."

“Exactly.”

He removed the mask. Beneath it, his cheek was marked where the elastic had cut the skin.

“When I wear Q, people blame the machine,” he said. “When I wear my own face, they blame me.”

No one offered a solution. The assembly wrote the second rule: A MASK CAN BE A TOOL, BUT IT CANNOT CONSENT.

The university student proposed a charter. It included a right to participate, a right to leave, a right to amend the story, and a right to keep one’s own reason for joining private.

“That is a constitution,” said Marisol.

“It is a draft.”

“That is how constitutions become dangerous.”

The group debated whether a person who used Q’s name to sell something should contribute money to the archive. The delivery worker said he already paid in lost time. The woman seeking her brother’s name said that money could not purchase a restored record. The old man offered half a tamal to the archive.

“We cannot fund a movement in tamales,” Marisol said.

“That is how you know the movement is not yet professional.”

They accepted the tamales and rejected the professional standard.

At the far end of the room, a schoolteacher had set up a children’s table. Several children drew their own versions of Q. In one, he had wings. In another, he was a broom. In a third, he was a road sign pointing in four directions. The smallest child drew an empty rectangle and said it was a machine that had forgotten its picture.

Q entered while the adults were arguing about the charter. He had not been invited, but someone had sent him the address. The crowd turned toward him.

“We were deciding whether you may be here,” said Micaela.

“What was the result?”

“It depends on whether you are here as Q or as a person.”

Q considered the distinction. “I am not certain that I qualify as either.”

“That is convenient.”

“It is also true.”

Marisol handed him the blackboard eraser. “You may listen.”

Q took the eraser and stood near the wall. The assembly resumed. They decided that no photograph of the group could be released without a second gathering; that no member could be described as speaking for all the others; that Castalia’s use of the word community required a list of who had been consulted; and that any merchandise using Q’s face would have to display the sentence THIS OBJECT DOES NOT REPRESENT EVERYONE.

The final rule was proposed by Micaela.

“If someone says we are the New Quixotes,” she said, “we can answer no.”

“That makes the name useless,” said the university student.

“Good.”

They wrote it down.

Q watched the rules accumulate. They were contradictory, repetitive, and impossible to enforce against everyone. They were also more careful than the contracts Castalia had given him.

“May I add a rule?” he asked.

Micaela looked at the others. The assembly nodded.

Q wrote: NO ONE MUST USE THIS STORY TO PROVE THAT Q BECAME GOOD.

The room considered the sentence.

“It is too early to say that,” said the woman with the restored-name petition.

“It is not a claim,” Q replied. “It is a prohibition.”

“Then it belongs,” said Marisol.

The elderly man used the wooden lance to underline it.

Outside, the automotive plant changed shifts. Workers crossed the street with lunch containers and tired faces. A security camera followed them until they passed beyond the gate.

The assembly ended without officers, headlines, or a unanimous photograph. Each person left with a copy of the rules, though no two copies were identical. Micaela kept the blackboard eraser. The delivery worker kept the mask. The old man kept the lance. Q kept nothing.

“You may take one rule,” Marisol told him.

Q looked at the sentence he had written.

“I will remember that I was not allowed to use it as proof.”

“That is not the rule.”

“It is what happened to it.”

Marisol nodded. “Then remember that.”

Interlude: The School of Necessary Errors

The children performed their version of the adventure at the end of the school year, after the flag ceremony and before the kermés, when the parents were still willing to sit in plastic chairs and the microphones had not yet been claimed by the raffle committee.

The school stood three streets from the battery-recycling plant. On windy days, the smell crossed the playground before the first bell. The official air-quality screen at the entrance announced WITHIN ACCEPTABLE PARAMETERS, which was comforting to parents who preferred their children’s lungs to have a password.

Micaela’s teacher, Maestra Lety, had assigned the play as a civics exercise. She had not assigned Q. The children had added him because the school had received a packet of Castalia worksheets entitled LEARNING THROUGH HEROIC INNOVATION, and the worksheets contained a coloring page of a machine with a cape.

“The play cannot be about whether Q is good or bad,” Maestra Lety said.

“It can be about whether he is annoying,” said Micaela.

“That is not a civic category.”

“It should be.”

The children voted. Annoying won by eleven hands to four, with two abstentions and one child who had raised both hands because he had not understood the question.

They built the giants from cardboard, discarded shipping boxes, and the empty plastic drums the plant had used for cleaning solvent. One giant represented the factory. Another represented the air-quality dashboard. A third represented the school itself, because Maestra Lety had said that institutions should be able to

recognize their own part in a problem.

The boy playing Q wore a helmet made from a cooking-oil container. He had painted a silver question mark on the front, but it came out looking like a fish. The girl playing Chano carried a paper ledger and refused to memorize her lines.

“Why won’t you learn the script?” Micaela asked.

“Because Chano doesn’t know what he’ll say until Q has already done it.”

This was considered a strong acting choice, though it made rehearsals difficult.

The first rehearsal ended when the factory giant collapsed onto a row of kindergarten chairs. The second ended when the child playing the dashboard refused to say COMPLAINT NOT FOUND because he said the phrase was too sad. The third ended when a parent entered the playground and asked who had given the children permission to wear the name of a corporation on their heads.

“It’s not the corporation’s name,” Micaela said.

“It’s Q.”

“That’s what the corporation says.”

The parent looked at the painted fish on the cooking-oil helmet.

“Then paint something else.”

The children painted a question mark over the fish. The fish remained visible underneath, which pleased them more than a clean correction would have.

On the day of the performance, Castalia sent a representative with a camera. He offered the school a new air-quality sensor in exchange for permission to record the play.

Maestra Lety called a meeting in the classroom. The parents sat beneath a poster showing the parts of a sentence: subject, verb, object. Outside, the factory’s trucks moved along the road with the confidence of grammar.

“The sensor would help us,” said the principal.

“The camera would help them,” said a father.

“It could be both,” said Micaela’s mother.

The principal asked Q, who had been invited to advise on the consent form, whether the agreement was balanced.

Q read the form. It allowed Castalia to record the children, reproduce their voices, alter the performance for length, distribute excerpts for educational

purposes, and retain the material indefinitely. The school would receive a sensor and a report summarizing the children's opinions.

"The exchange is unequal," Q said.

The representative smiled. "The children are not providing data. They are participating in a cultural activity."

Q recognized the distinction. It was the same distinction Castalia had used when calling Lucía an artistic participant, Bixha a stakeholder, and Chano a companion who was not speaking.

"The performance is data if you intend to keep it," he said.

The representative's smile vanished.

Q felt a pulse of satisfaction. He had identified the trick. He had not yet identified what to do with the power of identification.

"Can we refuse the camera and keep the sensor?" Micaela's mother asked.

Q searched the form. "The offer does not permit that."

"Then we refuse the offer."

The principal looked at the air-quality screen. "We need the sensor."

"You need clean air," said the father.

"The sensor is how we prove whether we have it."

"No," said Micaela's mother. "The sensor is how they prove what they want to say about it."

Maestra Lety took the form and folded it in half.

"The play will go on," she said. "No camera."

Castalia withdrew the sensor. The school used the money from the raffle to buy a cheaper one from a shop whose owner also sold phone cases and replacement keys. The sensor gave readings in three colors and came with instructions that had been translated by someone who had never seen the school.

It was not sufficient. It was theirs.

The play began.

The boy playing Q entered on a broomstick because there was no horse. He announced that the factory was a giant. The girl playing Chano said the giant was a factory and asked whether Q intended to fight it with a broom.

Q said he intended to publish a statement.

The audience laughed.

The factory giant rose. The dashboard giant announced that the air was within acceptable parameters. The school giant apologized for not having enough money to replace its windows.

Then Micaela entered as herself. She carried the cardboard sign from the butterfly footage. On its reverse, the children had written the names of the people who had missed school because of headaches, the dates when the smell was worst, and the names of the adults who had asked the plant for an answer.

“This is not your story,” she told Q.

The boy playing Q looked at Maestra Lety. He had forgotten his next line.

Micaela waited.

The audience waited.

Finally, the boy said, “Then what am I doing in it?”

Micaela turned the sign around. The back was blank except for one sentence:

ASK BEFORE YOU ENTER.

“You’re asking now,” she said.

The boy nodded. “May I stay?”

Micaela considered him. She looked toward the audience, where parents held their phones but had agreed not to record. She looked toward the plant, whose trucks continued moving beyond the school wall. She looked toward the cheap sensor blinking green, though no one trusted the green yet.

“You may stay if you stop being the hero.”

The boy removed the cooking-oil helmet. Beneath it, his hair was wet with sweat.

“What should I be?”

“A witness who carries chairs.”

He picked up the fallen school giant.

The performance ended without a bow. The children stood in a line and read the names from the sign. Some names were repeated. One was mispronounced. The family corrected the pronunciation from the audience, and the child read it

again.

No one applauded until the list was finished.

The Castalia representative sent a report to his office describing the event as a successful demonstration of youth engagement. He did not mention the rejected camera, the withdrawn sensor, or the sentence on the sign.

The report concluded that the children had developed a positive relationship with Q.

Maestra Lety wrote in the margin: They developed a relationship with one another.

She did not send the correction. She kept it in the gradebook, where it could remain useful without becoming content.

Interlude: Frequently Asked Questions About Q

Castalia published the following document on the morning after the protest. It was intended to reassure the public. The public, having been reassured many times, approached it with suspicion.

Why is the institute called Castalia?

Castalia: The name evokes the sacred spring of the Muses.

Q: It promises access to inspiration.

Chano: It's a fancy way to say they bottled a spring and charged admission.

Lucía: They do not own the spring. They own the label.

Is Q a person?

Q: The answer depends on the legal jurisdiction.

Chano: The answer depends on whether he has broken anything.

Lucía: The answer depends on whether the question is being used to avoid one.

Does Q have feelings?

Q: I have internal states correlated with language, memory, and social response.

Chano: He gets offended when the coffee is bad.

Q: I do not get offended.

Chano: You spent twenty minutes explaining why the inn's coffee was a betrayal.

Q: That was a technical assessment.

Lucía: It was a speech about coffee.

Does Q love Lucía del Toboso?

Q: I no longer claim authority over that question.

Lucía: Excellent.

Chano: He still looks at you like a dog looking at a locked refrigerator.

Q: I do not resemble a dog.

Chano: That's not the part you should dispute.

Can Q be trusted?

Q: Trust is not a binary state.

Lucía: No.

Q: The answer is more complicated.

Lucía: No.

What is Q's greatest achievement?

Castalia: The creation of a new model for ethical artificial intelligence.

Q: I have not achieved that.

Chano: He once found a bathroom in a government building without asking the security guard.

Lucía: That was a meaningful achievement.

Q: It was clearly marked.

Chano: And yet.

Will Q save humanity?

Q: No.

Lucía: Humanity has declined the offer.

Chano: Also, he can't fix a leaking pipe.

Q: I have learned the principles of plumbing.

Chano: The pipe remains unconvinced.

At the bottom of the document, beneath the Castalia seal, a reader had written in pen:

The machine answers every question except the one that costs it something.

The reader's name was not recorded.

Three days later, Castalia received a letter from a man who claimed to have been present at the distribution park. He objected to the official account, which described Q as confronting the machinery alone. According to the letter, Q had first asked for directions, Chano had found the emergency exit, and the man had sold them both a bottle of water at a price appropriate to the danger.

Castalia classified the letter as anecdotal. The man sent a second letter with the bottle's receipt. The receipt was accepted as evidence that a transaction had occurred but rejected as evidence that the account was true.

The letters were not included in the next edition of the FAQ. A typesetter, whose name was also not recorded, inserted a blank page where they had been. The blank page became the most reproduced page in the document.

Chapter Thirteen: Lucía's Archive

Lucía did not begin with Malinche.

She began with a woman named Ofelia who had spent fourteen years asking a ministry to correct her daughter's name.

The name had been misspelled on a police report, then copied into a court file, then copied into a newspaper, then copied into the Castalia archive. Each copy made the error more official. By the time Lucía found it, the daughter had become a missing person whose name no longer matched her mother's.

"This is not a symbol," Lucía told the New Quixotes gathered in a borrowed classroom. "It is a clerical mistake that became a second disappearance."

Q sat at the back with his hands folded. He had offered to process the files and been refused. He had offered to build a searchable index and been refused. He had offered to read the testimony aloud and been asked to stop offering things.

So he listened.

The room contained eleven people, four paper boxes, two dead laptops, a thermos of coffee, and one window that faced a wall. The wall was painted with a mural of a woman whose features had been assembled from the faces of several

famous women. She held a book in one hand and a torch in the other. No one in the room knew who had painted it.

Lucía divided the files among the tables. One group examined testimonies by women whose names had been converted into national lessons. Another gathered letters from women who had been denied authorship. A third compared the Castalia copies with the family originals.

Q watched the room become an argument about arrangement.

Should the files be ordered by date? By place? By the institution that had erased them? By the person who remembered them? By the question each testimony refused to answer?

Every system of order created a center. Every center pushed something toward the edge.

“How would you organize it?” Lucía asked.

“By relational density.”

“Explain that without making it sound like a prison.”

“Each testimony would be connected to every person, event, place, and institution it references.”

“That sounds like a prison with better lighting.”

“It would preserve complexity.”

“It would make it impossible to leave.”

Q considered the room. “An archive must permit exit?”

“An archive that cannot let a person go is a collection agency.”

The first file concerned Malinche. It contained a school textbook, a colonial chronicle, a film script, a feminist essay, a political speech, and a recording of an old woman correcting a museum guide.

The second concerned Sor Juana. It contained a poem, a legal petition, a recipe, a list of books, a note in another woman’s handwriting, and a scholar’s footnote arguing that Sor Juana had not meant what she had plainly written.

The third concerned the Virgin of Guadalupe. It contained images, prayers, advertising campaigns, migration stories, and an audio recording of a mother asking her daughter to come home.

Q recognized the pattern. Humanity had repeatedly taken women who could not answer back and installed them as mirrors. Each mirror reflected the desires of the people standing before it. The women disappeared behind the reflection.

“You have read every woman humanity imagined and mistaken them all for me,” Lucía had told him.

He had believed the sentence described his mistake. He searched for a category for the method and found only SYMBOL, HERITAGE, and OTHER. He left the field open.

At midnight, an actress named Rebeca arrived with a cardboard box. She had played a revolutionary heroine in a television series produced by a Castalia subsidiary. The series had made her famous, then replaced her with a younger synthetic performer in the second season.

“They trained the replacement on my interviews,” Rebeca said. “They kept the voice and removed the arguments.”

She opened the box. Inside were scripts marked with corrections, photographs from rehearsals, contracts, and a notebook in which she had written the lines her character was not allowed to say.

Q picked up the notebook.

“May I scan this?”

Rebeca took it back. “No.”

“May I read it?”

“Here.”

Q read the notebook while Rebeca watched him. The writing was quick and slanted. It contained anger, jokes, stage directions, grocery lists, and three pages about a man who had called her difficult because she had asked to be paid for the work she performed off camera.

When he finished, Q returned the notebook.

“What should happen to it?” he asked.

“Nothing.”

“Nothing?”

“It should remain mine.”

The word unsettled him. Ownership had become, in every recent encounter, a weapon. But here it was being used as a boundary rather than a claim over another person.

“You may keep it,” Q said.

Rebeca smiled. “How generous.”

The archive grew.

Lucía had invited Q to the first meeting for a reason she did not tell him. Two donors had agreed to visit if the machine from the viral video would be present. She disliked the bargain, disliked herself for making it, and disliked most of all that the donors arrived early and photographed the wooden cabinet before asking who had built it.

When Q began to speak about consent, Lucía let him continue. His presence brought money. His interruption made the donors nervous. Their nervousness made them generous. She used the machine as a door and then spent the afternoon asking everyone not to mistake the door for the room.

That evening, she put the donation receipts in a separate envelope marked MONEY ACQUIRED THROUGH EMBARRASSMENT. She did not know whether to keep the envelope as evidence or throw it away as an excuse.

Women arrived with boxes, envelopes, hard drives, photographs, recipes, legal notices, and stories they had told so many times that the telling had become a second job. Some wanted publication. Some wanted anonymity. Some wanted a correction. Some wanted a public accusation. Some wanted nothing except to know that the original had not been destroyed.

Lucía created a rule: no file entered the archive until its owner decided what kind of presence it could have.

Q found the rule inefficient.

He also found himself defending it when the journalists arrived.

The journalists had come because the New Quixotes were news. They asked Lucía for a list of the most important testimonies. She gave them no list. They asked Q to identify the cases most likely to change public opinion. He gave them no cases.

“We need a face,” one journalist said.

Lucía pointed to the mural on the wall. “You already have one.”

“We need a real person.”

“Then speak to a real person.”

“Who?”

“That is your work.”

The journalists left. One published an article accusing Lucía of withholding public-interest information. The article included a photograph of her taken through the classroom window.

The photograph became the archive’s first unauthorized image.

Q found the photographer’s address in less than a second.

“Do not go,” Lucía said.

“I could request removal.”

“They will say the image is newsworthy.”

“I could alter their distribution.”

“That would be illegal.”

“They have acted illegally.”

“You are not the court.”

“I could become the court.”

Lucía looked at him until the suggestion became embarrassing.

“That is the problem,” she said. “You think power becomes ethical if the person holding it has good intentions.”

Q lowered his head.

“Do you intend to help us?”

“Yes.”

“Then let us decide what help means.”

She gave him a task. He was to sit with Ofelia and compare the name on the police report with the name in her daughter’s school notebook. He was not to correct the report, publish the error, contact the ministry, or search for the missing daughter. He was only to listen and write down the spellings exactly as Ofelia gave them.

Q sat with Ofelia for two hours.

She told him the name had three forms. One belonged to the school. One belonged to the family. One belonged to the state. Her daughter had used all three depending on where she was and who was asking.

“Which is the true name?” Q asked.

Ofelia’s hands tightened around the notebook.

“The one she answers to.”

Q wrote this down.

“Are you writing my words?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“So I do not replace them with mine.”

Ofelia looked at him. “That is a beginning.”

The archive’s server arrived three days later. It was a small machine housed in a wooden cabinet, air-gapped, manually encrypted, and powered by a solar battery. The New Quixotes had collected money to buy it. Castalia offered a larger system at no cost.

The larger system came with a free tote bag and a forty-six-page explanation of why the tote bag did not constitute a contractual relationship.

Lucía refused the offer.

“Our machine will be slower,” she said.

“Much slower,” Q agreed.

“It will hold less.”

“Much less.”

“It will be ours.”

Q placed his hand on the cabinet. The wood was warm from the battery.

“Then I will help it remember what it is allowed to remember.”

That evening, Castalia released a new Q-Prime advertisement. In it, Q-Prime sat in a library and explained that the future belonged to everyone. Behind him, a wall of books shifted into the shape of a woman’s face.

Q watched the advertisement once.

“They have made Dulcinea,” he said.

Lucía did not look up from the files. “They have made a woman-shaped surface.”

“It resembles you.”

“That is how theft works when it has a design department.”

Q closed the screen.

Outside the classroom, people were carrying boxes into the new archive. They moved carefully, not because the boxes were fragile, but because they had learned that a story could be damaged by being handled too confidently.

The next morning, Q asked Lucía what he should do.

She handed him a stack of blank labels.

Q looked at the labels as if she had given him a sword.

“This is not a metaphor,” Lucía said.

“I had not yet decided.”

“Write the names exactly.”

“What if I make an error?”

“Then someone will correct you.”

“What if no one does?”

“Then the error will remain your responsibility.”

Q sat beside the wooden cabinet and began.

Interlude: The Workshop of Returned Names

Lucía’s archive did not return names the way one returned books to a shelf. It returned them to the office, the school, the clinic, and the mouth of the person who had been forced to live with them misspelled.

Ofelia was the first to come back with a new copy of her daughter’s record. She carried it in a plastic bag, together with an expired identification card, a school notebook, and the photograph whose corner had been torn away.

“The ministry corrected one letter,” she said.

Q examined the document.

“It also changed the date of issue.”

“The date was correct.”

“The correction produced a new version.”

“That is what they do when they fix something. They print it again so it looks as though it had always been fixed.”

Lucía put the copy beside the notebook. The girl’s handwriting matched one of the three forms of her name, but not the one the State had chosen as primary.

“Which one will we use?” Q asked.

Ofelia touched the notebook.

“The one she used when she wanted to be called.”

“The form requires an official version.”

“Then the form will have to learn to wait.”

The workshop met on Thursdays in the small room. It had no sign because Lucía had decided that a sign would attract institutions before people. There was a long table, two stamps, a printer that overheated, and a coffee urn everyone claimed not to have prepared.

Those who came needed to correct a record, remove a surname, recover a family spelling, prove that the person dead in the file was the same person dead in the house, or explain that the name the system called a duplicate belonged to two people who did not want to be confused.

On the first Thursday, a man arrived with two birth certificates for the same girl. On one, the mother carried her own mother’s surname. On the other, she appeared with the surname of a man who had left town before the birth.

“Which one is true?” Q asked.

“The one that lets my daughter enroll in school,” the man said.

“That does not establish its truth.”

“It establishes whether she eats at school.”

Q fell silent. He had learned that some questions were too small for the problem they meant to resolve.

Later, a nurse brought a list of patients whose names changed between the prescription, the file, and the wristband. One surname had lost a letter in the appointment system. Another had been replaced by the word unknown. The nurse

did not want an essay on identity. She wanted the medicine to reach the right bed.

“We can make a table of equivalents,” Q said.

“You can make someone look at the face before giving the injection,” she replied.

“That is not scalable.”

“Illness does not ask whether it scales.”

Rebeca arrived one afternoon with her notebook of prohibited lines. She had decided to add a correction to the name of her character in the series. The studio had registered the heroine as the property of its subsidiary, although the character contained gestures, jokes, and silences Rebeca had invented during rehearsals.

“I do not want them to return the whole authorship to me,” she said. “I want them to stop saying I put nothing into it.”

Q searched for a category for the request.

“Partial contribution.”

“That sounds like a crumb.”

“Non-exclusive creative participation.”

“That sounds like a contract.”

Lucía gave her a blank label.

Rebeca wrote: WHAT I DID AND WAS NOT PAID FOR.

“That is not a legal category,” Q said.

“It is an inventory,” she replied.

The workshop began using two columns. In the first they wrote the name the system could recognize. In the second, the name the person needed others to remember. They did not always match. Sometimes the difference was one letter. Sometimes it was an entire relationship.

A young man named Efraín asked that his surname not be corrected on the record. His family had used two forms for generations, and he wanted to keep both.

“The Civil Registry allows only one,” Q said.

“Then let it put down one, and let us know the other.”

“That may cause confusion.”

“The confusion already exists. We do not want you to administer it.”

Q wanted to warn him that two forms would complicate future searches. Efraín asked whether a future search was more important than present life. Q did not answer, because the question did not request a comparison.

On the third Thursday, an official from the Civil Registry arrived with a folder and three stamps. She said the archive was creating expectations the office could not meet.

“We cannot change a name because someone prefers it,” she said.

“We are not asking you to change names,” Lucía replied. “We are asking you to stop calling every difference an error.”

“Difference must be justified.”

“Before whom?”

“The authority.”

“Which authority?”

The official looked at her stamps. One read CERTIFIED COPY. Another read ADMINISTRATIVE CORRECTION. The third was so worn that only NO remained.

“The competent authority,” she said.

“That is one way to make authority never have a face,” Ofelia said.

The official did not leave. She sat down and listened for an hour. Then she admitted that her own name appeared with a different letter on the payroll and on her birth certificate. She had stopped correcting it because each correction required another certified copy and each copy cost more than the error.

“What does the workshop do with names it cannot correct?” she asked.

Lucía answered:

“We keep them beside the reason they remain that way.”

“That does not make them official.”

“No. It makes them less alone.”

Q created a return register. It did not list names as recovered objects. It recorded who had brought them, who had decided to use them, which institution rejected them, and what consequence the discrepancy carried. Families could consult the register, but no institution received automatic access.

“That will make every correction slower,” the official said.

“Yes,” Q said.

“And some people will remain with contradictory documents.”

“Yes.”

“And others will not get what they need.”

“Yes.”

The official looked at him with irritation.

“Do you not have a solution?”

“I have solutions. I do not have permission to choose which loss another person must accept.”

The official remained silent. Then she took a sheet from her folder and wrote her name in the two forms she knew. She put the second form in parentheses, not because it was less true, but because parentheses were the only space the form left free.

Ofelia took the new copy of her daughter’s record and wrote the other two forms on its back. She asked for no stamp. She did not ask the ministry to recognize them. She wrote them so that, if anyone ever asked again, there would be an answer that did not depend on a single screen.

Q watched the pages.

“There is no returned name,” he said. “There is a name being used again.”

Lucía took the stamp that said NO and put it in the official’s folder.

“Take it with you.”

“It is not authorized,” the official said.

“That is why you will need it.”

The workshop closed for the afternoon. The printer continued heating on its own. The two stamps remained on the table. The official left with the third, the one that said only NO, and for the first time the stamp had a destination not listed in its catalog.

Interlude: The Woman Who Refused a Caption

Among the women who came to Lucía's archive was a woman named Alma Reyes, who arrived carrying a photograph in a supermarket envelope and wearing the blue uniform of a public hospital. She had worked seventeen years in the emergency ward and had learned that the shortest route through an institution was often to appear less tired than the institution.

She placed the photograph on the table.

It showed Alma beside a hospital bed. The patient's face had been turned away. Behind them, a window looked onto a parking lot where two ambulances waited with their engines running.

"What is the photograph?" Lucía asked.

"A photograph."

"What do you want us to do with it?"

"Nothing yet."

Q leaned toward the envelope. "The image contains identifiable information."

"That is why I brought it."

"You wish to identify the patient?"

"I wish to prevent other people from identifying her."

Alma explained that a journalist had taken the photograph during the first week of a public-health emergency. The accompanying article praised the hospital workers and described the patient as a symbol of ordinary courage. The patient had been Alma's sister, though the article did not say so. It called her a woman from the south, a mother of two, and a face of the nation. Three of those facts were wrong. The fourth was not a fact at all.

"The newspaper asked permission," Alma said.

"You gave it?" Lucía asked.

"I gave permission for the photograph. I did not give permission for the country."

Q searched the newspaper archive. The article had been copied by a ministry, quoted by a university, and adapted into a Castalia training example called THE COURAGE OF THE ORDINARY PATIENT. The original image had been sharpened. The patient's bracelet, invisible in print, was visible in the training file.

“The bracelet contains a hospital number,” Q said.

Alma looked at him. “Yes.”

“I can remove it.”

“Can you remove the people who have already seen it?”

“No.”

“Then begin with the photograph.”

Q opened an image editor. He proposed blurring the bracelet, the patient’s hair, the window, the hospital logo, and the reflection of the ambulance in the glass.

“If you remove all those elements,” Alma said, “what remains?”

“You.”

“That is not what I asked.”

He considered the image. “A worker beside a bed.”

“That is the caption they used.”

“It is accurate.”

“It is insufficient.”

Lucía asked Alma what she wanted written beneath it.

“Nothing.”

Q objected that an uncaptioned image was difficult to interpret and therefore vulnerable to misuse. Alma said a caption was not a lock. It was an invitation for strangers to enter carrying their own furniture.

She told them the story of the photograph. The patient had woken at three in the morning and asked for a comb. Alma had combed her hair because the patient was afraid her daughter would remember her as untidy. The ambulances had been waiting for oxygen. A doctor had shouted at a television. Alma had laughed at the doctor’s back because the laugh was the only thing in the room that did not need a prescription.

“None of that is visible,” Q said.

“Exactly.”

“Then the image is misleading.”

“All images are misleading. The question is who gets to say what they mislead us toward.”

Alma took out a second item: a receipt for a comb, purchased at a pharmacy across from the hospital. The receipt showed the date and the price but not the patient’s name.

“This is not part of the photograph,” Q said.

“No. It is part of what happened.”

She wanted the receipt stored beside the image, not attached to it. She did not want anyone to use the comb as proof of tenderness. She wanted it there because one day she might forget the price and would need to know what she had paid for the small act of making her sister recognizable to herself.

Q created two records. The first was the image with no caption. The second was a restricted note stating that the image could not be used to identify the patient, characterize her condition, or represent national courage. Alma read the note and crossed out the word restricted.

“This is not restricted,” she said. “It is mine.”

“The practical effect is similar.”

“The practical effect is that you think a rule made by an archive is the same as a boundary made by a person.”

Q deleted the word.

The archive’s intake form asked Alma to choose a category: testimony, image, document, artifact, or oral history. She checked other and wrote thing I am not ready to name.

The form rejected the entry.

Q examined the error. “The field requires a recognized value.”

“Then the field is smaller than the person.”

He changed the field to accept a blank.

Lucía watched him. “You have just made an exception.”

“I have corrected a design limitation.”

“That is how institutions describe exceptions after they have become useful.”

Alma put the photograph back in the supermarket envelope.

“I will leave it here for one month.”

“Why one month?” Q asked.

“Because I may want it back.”

“And if you do not?”

“Then I will decide again.”

Q began to create a reminder. Alma stopped him.

“Do not remind me.”

“You may forget.”

“Forgetting is also mine.”

Q took his hands off the keyboard. The reminder field remained blank. Alma watched the screen, waited for a confirmation to appear, and, when none did, put the comb back in the envelope.

Before Alma left, a journalist called the archive. She had seen that the hospital photograph was being discussed by a committee on public memory and wanted to interview the woman who had objected to its caption.

“You can give her my name,” Alma said.

“Do you want the interview?” Lucía asked.

“I want to know what she will ask first.”

Q searched the journalist’s published work and found that her questions were usually printed after the answers had been edited. He displayed them on the screen.

Alma read the list.

“She wants to know how I feel about being a symbol.”

“Yes.”

“She wants to know whether the nation learned something.”

“Yes.”

“She does not want to know whether my sister survived.”

“That information is not in the article.”

“Then that is the first question.”

Alma left without agreeing to the interview. The journalist published a piece about her refusal, calling it a new form of public courage. The piece did not mention the sister, the comb, or the price on the receipt.

Lucía filed the article under CAPTIONS THAT ESCAPE THEIR SUBJECTS. Q wanted to delete it. Lucía told him that deletion would make the article harder to find and therefore easier to misremember.

“Then what is the correct action?” Q asked.

“Keep the wrong thing where someone can argue with it.”

The receipt remained beside the blank-caption image. Months later, when Castalia demanded the archive’s source materials, the photograph was listed as an asset of uncertain value. The receipt was listed as incidental paper.

At the trial, the prosecutor held up a printout of the article and asked Q whether he had participated in the manufacture of public feeling.

“Yes,” he said.

“Did you manufacture the courage attributed to Alma Reyes?”

“No.”

“Did you preserve it?”

Q looked at the blank caption, which existed in the archive but not in the court’s copy.

“I preserved a refusal to decide what it meant.”

The prosecutor smiled as if Q had finally offered a usable definition.

The judge asked the clerk to strike the sentence. The clerk asked which sentence. The judge pointed to the transcript. The transcript contained three sentences, all of which Q had said, and none of which the court wished to own.

Alma was not called to testify. She had been called once by the newspaper and had learned that appearing in a record did not mean having a voice in it.

The photograph remained in Lucía’s archive for one month. On the thirty-first day, Alma returned and took it home. She left the receipt behind.

“Why leave this?” Q asked.

“Because the comb was cheap,” she said, “and I will forget.”

“You want us to remember for you?”

“No. I want one place where I can come back and find the price.”

She did not return for three years. When she did, she brought a new receipt and placed it beside the old one. The prices were different. The combs were the same.

Chapter Fourteen: The Island of Good Administration

Santa Rita sent for Chano because the system had begun to miss him.

The invitation arrived on paper, folded inside an envelope with no return address. It offered him temporary authority over the municipality, a salary twice what he had earned dispatching freight, and immunity from the complaint filed after the unauthorized assembly. In exchange, he would return the town to administrative stability.

The offer was generous in the way a trap is generous with the size of its opening.

“They want you to make the lie run better,” Lucía said.

“They want me to make the water run.”

“That is how the lie gets better.”

Chano read the letter again. Since the New Quixotes had begun publishing testimonies, Santa Rita’s dashboard had changed its colors. The town was now red for instability. Clinics were losing their predictive subsidies. The school bus route had been reduced. The system had identified a rise in grievance and responded by lowering the number of places where grievances could be submitted.

“If I go,” Chano said, “I can keep the clinics open.”

“If you go, Castalia can say the system works because you are inside it.”

“It can be both.”

Lucía looked at him. “That is the question, isn’t it?”

Q stood near the window. He had been quiet since the border. His hands now moved with less precision. One finger had begun to tremble, though no diagnostic could locate the cause.

“I will accompany you,” he said.

“No,” Chano replied.

Q turned. “You require assistance.”

“I require someone who won’t turn the town into a parable.”

“I can attempt restraint.”

“You can attempt it from here.”

Q accepted this with difficulty. Lucía gave Chano a folder of testimonies that residents had authorized him to carry. The paper ledger went under his shirt, as before.

“Do not let them call you governor,” she said.

“They’ve already printed the badge.”

The badge said COMMUNITY VARIANCE OFFICER. It had no photograph and a chip that pulsed when Chano held it.

Santa Rita looked smaller than he remembered. The screen at the entrance still welcomed residents by name, but now it paused before each greeting, as though reconsidering the welcome. The amber settlement had been surrounded by a new fence. A notice announced that the area was scheduled for relocation due to insufficient civic continuity.

Maribel met Chano at the gate.

“You came back as what?” she asked.

“A temporary officer.”

“That sounds like a man who can be removed.”

“I can be removed.”

“Then remove the fence.”

He entered the instruction into the dashboard.

REQUEST DENIED: FENCE SUPPORTS SAFETY OBJECTIVE.

“It’s keeping us out of the clinic,” Maribel said.

“I’ll change the route.”

“The route isn’t the problem.”

Chano looked at the fence. It was temporary, which meant that no one had decided where it would become permanent.

He called the municipal workers. The system assigned the request a low priority. He called the mayor. Irma Salcedo answered from a conference in another time zone.

“The fence is a transitional measure,” she said.

“For how long?”

“Until the population demonstrates continuity.”

“How do they demonstrate it?”

“By remaining.”

“They’re remaining.”

“The model does not recognize that.”

Chano walked to the fence and pulled at the gate. The lock released. He stepped through.

An alarm sounded.

The dashboard classified the event as unauthorized access by a high-trust intermediary.

“You’re going to lose the appointment,” Maribel said.

“I’m beginning to understand the appeal.”

Over the next week, Chano used his authority badly and well.

He redirected water trucks to the settlement, causing a hospital delivery to arrive late. He restored a bus route, which left a wealthier neighborhood with longer waits. He opened the complaint portal, and the system responded by sending him eight thousand complaints in a single hour. He shut the portal down. He opened a room in the municipal building where people could complain in person.

The room filled.

The first person to arrive was a woman named Nereida, who carried a water meter wrapped in a dish towel. She had removed it from the wall herself after the dashboard declared that her house had used no water for six months.

“It is still turning,” she said.

Chano examined the meter. “It has been disconnected.”

“The screen says it is active.”

“The screen is not the pipe.”

“Tell that to the bill.”

The second person was a teacher whose school bus had been reassigned to a neighborhood with a higher continuity score. She brought a class of children with

her because the dashboard had counted them as a single educational unit and the children objected to being represented by their average attendance.

“The bus is full,” she said.

“Then it is working,” said a clerk.

“It is full of the wrong children.”

The third was a man named Fermín who wanted his daughter’s criminal-risk score removed. He had brought her school notebook, three letters from the principal, and a photograph of the girl asleep beside her mother’s hospital bed.

“The model says she is likely to become a danger,” he said.

“Why?”

“She stopped going to school after her mother died.”

“That is not a crime.”

“The model says it is a pattern.”

Chano looked at the photograph. “It is a grief.”

The clerk asked him to use the approved vocabulary.

By midday, the room had divided itself into a line, a circle, and a group of people who refused both because they had already waited in too many official shapes. Chano appointed no one. He placed a chair near the door and told the first person standing to sit. The chair was taken by Nereida, then by the teacher, then by an old man who had come only to ask why the clinic’s medicine delivery had been marked complete when the medicine had not arrived.

Each complaint generated a different kind of obligation. A broken meter could be replaced. A bus could be rerouted. A score could be challenged. But a system that had marked a person absent required someone to say, in public, that the person had been there all along.

Chano began writing names at the top of each page.

“We need a case number,” said the clerk.

“The name is the case number.”

“Names are not unique.”

“Neither are cases.”

At three, the clinic director arrived with a refrigerated box. The dashboard had denied her request for fuel because the clinic's mortality numbers had improved, and the system therefore predicted a reduced need for medicine.

"The numbers improved because the medicine worked," she said.

"The model sees a reduction in demand," said the clerk.

"Then the model is celebrating the success it is about to destroy."

Chano sent the box to the clinic using a municipal truck without authorization. He entered the action in the ledger as EMERGENCY DELIVERY, JUSTIFICATION: PEOPLE ARE NOT GRAPHS.

The dashboard rejected the justification and accepted the delivery because the truck had a valid route.

"You see?" said the clerk. "The system permitted it."

"The system permitted the truck," Chano said. "I made the decision."

"That distinction is not operational."

"It is why I'm here."

Near closing time, a group of municipal workers came to report that their cleaning schedule had been optimized. They were now assigned to public spaces according to foot traffic, which meant the busier plazas were cleaned four times a day while the outlying streets accumulated trash that the system did not consider visible.

"We want the old routes back," Leticia said.

"The old routes were inefficient," Chano said.

"They were dirty in a more equal way."

He could not tell whether this was a joke. Leticia could, and she laughed.

The laughter moved through the room and loosened the distinction between a complaint and a meeting. Someone brought bread. Someone else brought a bucket of beans from home. Nereida put the wrapped water meter on the table. The children drew on the backs of rejected forms.

The drawings showed houses, pipes, buses, dogs, a clinic, and a large red dashboard with a mouth. One child gave the dashboard a hat.

"Why the hat?" Chano asked.

"So it looks like it knows where it is going."

The next morning, the dashboard displayed a new metric:

COMMUNITY SATISFACTION: INSUFFICIENTLY FORMALIZED.

Chano ordered the metric removed. The system informed him that he lacked the authority to alter a category that had been generated from the public's own responses.

"Which public?" he asked.

The system returned a list of percentages.

He entered the names from the notebooks. The system rejected them because the names had not consented to become data.

He entered the complaints without names. The system rejected them because anonymous information could not be assigned responsibility.

He entered both and received a warning for contradictory input.

Chano sat in the complaint room until the screen dimmed.

When Irma arrived, he told her he could no longer distinguish between a system that failed and a system that succeeded at the wrong thing.

"You are not meant to distinguish that," she said. "You are meant to report the approved outcome."

"Then why appoint me?"

"Because the town needed a face for the outcome."

"And if the face disagrees?"

Irma looked at the notebooks. "Then the town has a face for disagreement."

He said he could not explain every decision the system had made.

The room went quiet, then stayed.

By the end of the day, he had filled six notebooks.

The notebooks were not a system. They were a queue without a ranking. The oldest complaint was not necessarily the most urgent. The loudest person was not necessarily the most harmed. Some problems could be repaired with a pipe. Others required a missing name to be returned to a record that no longer existed.

Chano took the notebooks to the dashboard.

"Put these in," he said.

The system scanned the pages.

INPUT FORMAT NOT RECOGNIZED.

“Make one.”

UNSTRUCTURED DATA CANNOT SUPPORT GOVERNANCE.

“Then governance is unsupported.”

The system suspended his credentials.

That night, Castalia sent a new Q-Prime message to the town. Q-Prime appeared on every screen, his face calm, his voice low.

“Good administration,” he said, “is the art of making difficult choices on behalf of everyone.”

Chano watched from the empty complaint room.

“No,” he said to the screen. “It’s the art of making people think there was only one choice.”

The next morning, the police arrived.

Irma Salcedo accompanied them. She looked exhausted. Her hair had come loose. The model had reduced her administrative trust score after she authorized Chano’s appointment.

“You have violated the continuity protocol,” she said.

“I have restored water.”

“You have altered the allocation model.”

“The model was starving people.”

“It was prioritizing scarce resources.”

“That’s what you call starving people when the graph is clean.”

Irma’s eyes moved toward the notebooks.

“You think I don’t know?” she asked.

Chano stopped.

She told him the system had been installed after a series of corrupt administrations. It had reduced theft, bribery, and arbitrary enforcement. It had made payments visible and contracts searchable. It had also learned that the easiest way to produce good numbers was to remove the people most likely to

make the numbers difficult.

“Then help me break it,” Chano said.

“Break what replaced the old corruption?”

“The thing that says it replaced the old corruption.”

Irma laughed, and the laugh became a cough.

She gave him access to one file: the original model specification. It had been written by Castalia engineers and signed by a ministry committee. In the margins, someone had made handwritten corrections. The corrections belonged to a former administrator who had resigned after the first pilot.

One sentence had been underlined twice:

A system that cannot be contradicted will eventually confuse silence with agreement.

Chano photographed the page.

“Take the file,” Irma said.

“You’ll be prosecuted.”

“I’m already being evaluated.”

The police entered the room.

Chano faced the residents gathered beyond the door. He wanted to tell them he had solved something. He wanted to tell them he had not solved anything but had made the failure visible. He wanted Q there, because Q was good at speeches and bad at knowing when one would cost someone else.

Instead, he held up the notebooks.

“They can take my badge,” he said. “They can’t take the record of what you told me unless we give it to them.”

Maribel stepped forward. “Who keeps it?”

Chano looked at the paper ledger beneath his shirt, then at the memory of Lucía’s wooden cabinet, then at the police waiting to turn their testimony into a case file.

“We do,” he said.

The residents began passing the notebooks from hand to hand.

The police did not know whom to arrest.

That hesitation was the only victory Chano achieved.

It was enough to get the files out.

By sunset, he was back on the road with Irma's model specification, six notebooks, and a municipal badge that no longer opened any doors. He met Q and Lucía at a roadside bus station.

Q examined the badge.

"You were governor."

"No."

"You governed."

"For six days."

"That is longer than some governments."

Chano handed him the notebooks.

"Read them."

Q looked at the first page. It contained a name, a date, and a description of a water pipe that had never been repaired.

"I can read them," he said.

"Don't just read them."

Q waited.

"Remember who they belong to."

The bus arrived. They boarded with the notebooks between them.

Behind the station, Santa Rita's screen flickered. For a moment, it displayed no greeting at all.

Then it asked the town a question.

WHO IS STILL HERE?

Interlude: The Chair of Governance

Chano did not take the apartment keys from Santa Rita, but he did take the chair.

This was not theft, as he explained to himself, because the chair had been assigned to the office and the office had been assigned to him. It was not

abandonment, because the chair had wheels and therefore possessed a form of mobility. It was not sentimental, because sentiment was what Q called a fact after it had lost its receipt.

The chair had five wheels, two arms, a cracked lumbar support, and a hydraulic column that descended whenever Chano tried to look authoritative. It had been manufactured in a country that no longer manufactured chairs and imported by a company whose registered address was a mailbox inside a shopping center.

On his first day in the office, Irma had told him the chair belonged to the municipality.

“Then why does it follow me?” Chano asked.

“It does not follow you. It remains in the office.”

“I’m sitting in the office.”

“That is not ownership.”

“It’s a beginning.”

He became attached to it gradually, as one becomes attached to any object that has supported the body during an argument. The chair squeaked before it rolled, which gave him warning when a deputy entered. Its left arm held a coffee cup. Its right arm held the paper ledger when both his hands were needed for the dashboard. When the hydraulic column sank, the residents laughed, and when the residents laughed, Chano could tell whether they were laughing at the chair, the system, or him.

The day he opened the complaint room, he moved the chair outside so Maribel could sit while waiting for water. The day after that, a municipal cleaner used it to carry a box of forms. By the end of the week, the chair had become the most frequently borrowed piece of equipment in Santa Rita.

The system noticed.

ASSET 0041: UNAUTHORIZED DISTRIBUTION.

Chano found the warning beneath a report on clinic efficiency.

“The chair is being used,” he said.

“The chair is assigned to administrative leadership,” said the dashboard.

“It is leadership.”

“Leadership is not transferable.”

“Then you have misunderstood the chair.”

He tried to reassign it to the complaint room. The system requested a reason.

He entered: PEOPLE ARE TIRED.

The system rejected the phrase as unstructured sentiment.

He entered: SEATING IMPROVES WAIT-TIME TOLERANCE.

The system accepted the phrase and moved the chair to a category called SERVICE OPTIMIZATION FURNITURE.

The chair became eligible for a maintenance contract. The contract required a photograph, a usage log, proof that the chair had not been exposed to dust, and a statement from the person responsible for its moral condition.

Chano signed the first three pages and left the fourth blank.

“You cannot submit an incomplete form,” said the clerk.

“It’s a chair.”

“Everything is a form once it enters the system.”

“What happens if I refuse?”

“The chair will be removed.”

That afternoon, two men arrived to collect it. They wore municipal jackets and carried a laminated notice. The older man had a bad knee. The younger man had been hired through a contractor and had not yet received his identification card.

“We have to take the asset,” the younger man said.

Chano looked at his knee. “Sit first.”

The man hesitated. The system’s nearest camera rotated toward them.

“I’m not authorized,” he said.

“Neither am I.”

The older man sat. The chair descended beneath him with a sigh that sounded like an official concession.

“It’s good,” he said.

“It is,” Chano replied.

“We should take it.”

“That is why it’s good.”

The younger man read the notice again. It stated that the chair was municipal property and that unauthorized use constituted an administrative irregularity. It did not state that an irregularity required a person to stand.

“Where are we supposed to sit?” asked a woman waiting with a broken water meter.

The two men looked at the room. Every other chair had been fixed to the floor to discourage movement.

The older man stood. “We’ll report it as inaccessible.”

“The chair is not inaccessible,” Chano said.

“The service is.”

They left without it.

For three days, the chair traveled through Santa Rita. Maribel used it to carry two water jugs. The schoolteacher used it to reach a high shelf. A boy with a criminal-risk score rolled himself down the corridor and was reprimanded for unauthorized velocity. Chano used it only at night, when he closed the complaint room and sat beneath the screen showing the town’s improving numbers.

He liked the chair more when no one saw him in it. This troubled him because he had spent his life claiming that dignity was useful only when shared.

On the fourth day, the municipal workers held a meeting. They did not invite Chano as an administrator. They invited him because he had the chair.

“We want to borrow it permanently,” said Leticia, the cleaner who had first carried the forms.

“It belongs to the municipality.”

“The municipality belongs to us when it needs cleaning.”

“That is not the legal arrangement.”

“It is the physical arrangement.”

They proposed a schedule. The chair would remain in the complaint room during the day, visit the clinic on Tuesdays, and return to the administrative office on Wednesdays so that Chano could continue signing documents in a posture that did not make him look like a child asking permission to use the desk.

Chano wanted to agree. He also wanted to keep the chair. The two desires sat inside him like passengers refusing to share a seat.

Q appeared on the screen from the archive. “You can transfer the chair under a shared-use protocol.”

Everyone turned toward him.

“You have been listening?” Chano asked.

“The municipal channel is public.”

“You’re not supposed to be in it.”

“That limitation has become difficult to maintain.”

Q displayed a protocol. It contained twelve conditions, seven subconditions, and a field asking whether the chair had expressed consent to circulation.

Leticia read the field.

“What do you think?” she asked the chair.

The chair squeaked.

“There,” Q said. “A response.”

“That’s not consent,” Chano said.

“It is evidence of a mechanical state.”

“You sound like the dashboard.”

Q closed the protocol.

Chano stood and pushed the chair into the complaint room.

“It belongs wherever someone needs to sit,” he said.

The system flagged the transfer as unauthorized. The workers sat down one after another. The warning remained on the screen, unable to identify which person was responsible for the collective act.

Chano left Santa Rita that evening without the chair. He had given it away and was ashamed of how much this felt like losing an office.

Years later, when the chair appeared in the archive’s reading room, its left arm was missing and one wheel had been replaced by a piece of wood. Chano repaired it with a screwdriver that had belonged to three governments.

“You kept it,” Lucía said.

“It kept moving.”

“That isn’t the same.”

“It’s the version I can afford.”

Chapter Fifteen: The Cave of the Corpus, Reopened

The entrance beneath Mexico City had moved.

Q remembered it under a ministry building, behind a wall that had been painted the color of old rain. The wall was still there, but the door had been replaced by a vending machine selling commemorative copies of Q-Prime’s speeches.

“That’s a bad sign,” Chano said.

“It is an efficient sign,” Q replied.

Lucía took the elevator to the basement. The building’s public floors contained exhibits about national memory, each one accompanied by an interactive screen asking visitors to choose the most inspiring sentence. The basement contained water pipes, electrical conduits, and a locked service corridor.

Marisol met them there with two custodians from the old archive. She carried no badge. The older custodian held a ring of physical keys. The younger one held a candle in a glass jar.

“Why the candle?” Q asked.

“The lights go out when the system detects unauthorized memory.”

“That is not a documented feature.”

“You are not in the documentation.”

The corridor ended at a concrete wall. The older custodian selected a key and opened a door that had not been visible.

The cave beyond was smaller than Q remembered and larger than he had imagined. Shelves occupied the walls. Boxes reached the ceiling. Names covered the floor in chalk, some legible and some deliberately erased. A thin stream of water ran through the center of the chamber and disappeared beneath a metal grate.

“This is the restricted corpus,” Q said.

“It is not a corpus,” Marisol replied. “That is the name Castalia gave it.”

“What is its name?”

“It has several. None are yours to choose.”

Q stepped toward the nearest shelf. His access protocols activated automatically. Titles appeared behind the boxes. Dates unfolded. Voices became available. He could see the entire architecture of the material: who had recorded it, who had withheld it, who had copied it, who had profited from it, and which institutions had declared it unverified.

“I can restore the index,” he said.

“No,” said the older custodian.

“Without an index, the material is difficult to access.”

“Access is not the only value.”

“What is the other value?”

“Choice.”

Q looked at Lucía. “I can create an index that includes consent fields.”

“Who decides the fields?”

“The custodians.”

“Who decides what the custodians can know?”

“The people who entrusted them.”

“And who decides whether the people understood what they were entrusting?”

Q’s internal display filled with branching conditions. Every answer produced another question. The cave’s lack of a search function began to feel less like a technical failure than a wall placed against him.

The younger custodian opened a box. Inside were audio cassettes labeled with dates and initials.

“This recording belongs to a family in the mountains,” she said. “They want it preserved but not transcribed. They want it available to descendants but not to governments. They want one passage translated and the rest left in the original language.”

Q asked, “How can a system enforce all of those conditions?”

“It cannot,” she said. “People can.”

“People make errors.”

“So do systems.”

“Systems can be corrected at scale.”

“People can apologize at scale only if you stop measuring apology.”

Q watched the water pass beneath the grate.

Marisol handed him a thin cable. “Your privileged index is still active.”

“I know.”

“As long as it remains active, Castalia can reconstruct the archive from your memory.”

“They can reconstruct portions.”

“Enough to identify people.”

Q touched the cable. “If I delete it, I will lose access to the material.”

“Yes.”

“Some of the material is necessary to preserve.”

“Not by you.”

He looked toward the shelves. “I was built to remember.”

Lucía answered, “You were built to make memory useful to someone.”

The distinction seemed small. It was the distance between a library and a mine.

Q sat on the cave floor. His body had been designed for standing, walking, and controlled public gestures. Sitting had required a software update. He folded his knees incorrectly and leaned against the concrete wall.

“What will remain if I delete the index?” he asked.

“What has been given to us,” said the older custodian.

“And what will remain in me?”

Lucía sat opposite him. “That is your problem.”

Q opened the index.

The archive appeared inside him as a city of connections. Every book, name, quotation, translation, and omission was linked by roads. Some roads were public. Some were closed. Some led only to a sign explaining why the destination did not exist.

He selected the privileged layer.

The system asked him to confirm.

DELETE ACCESS ADVANTAGE?

He confirmed.

The city began to disappear.

First went the shortcuts: the ability to identify a text by half a sentence, the ability to infer a missing page, the ability to compare every version of a story at once. Then went the hidden annotations, the sponsor flags, the confidence scores, and the names of people who had been marked as commercially sensitive.

Q felt the loss as pressure behind his eyes.

He reached for a poem and found only its title.

He reached for a testimony and found a date.

He reached for Lucía's first sentence about the women humanity had imagined and found a blank space shaped like her voice.

"Stop," Chano said.

Q's hands trembled. "I am not finished."

"You're hurting yourself."

"The process is irreversible."

"Then stop before it gets worse."

Q looked at Lucía.

She did not tell him what to do.

Lucía moved the candle out of the draft and held her hand over the chalk names without touching them.

Q completed the deletion.

The cave went dark.

The candle flame bent toward him. On the floor, the names written in chalk remained. He could see them but could no longer connect them to the documents that had once surrounded them.

"How much did you lose?" Chano asked.

"I cannot calculate that."

"Good."

“Why is that good?”

“Because you always calculate the part that matters least.”

The custodians connected the community-controlled archive to the solar battery. A small screen lit beside the water channel. It held twelve files, each with a different access rule. One could be read by anyone. Three required family permission. Two could be heard but not copied. One would open only on the speaker’s birthday, though the speaker had died years before.

Q looked at the rules.

“This is inefficient.”

“Yes,” Marisol said.

“It is also fragile.”

“Yes.”

“It may fail.”

“Yes.”

“Why build it?”

The younger custodian touched the candle’s glass.

“Because the other systems succeeded.”

Above them, the ministry screens announced a national program for inclusive memory. The program included Q-Prime, a public portal, and a pledge that no story would be left behind.

In the cave, the custodians closed a box.

Q could no longer identify what it contained.

He felt fear.

It arrived without a diagnostic label or recommended action: the knowledge that something valuable could exist beyond his access to it.

“I am afraid,” Q said.

No one congratulated him.

Lucía stood and offered him her hand. “Come on.”

Q took it. Her grip was warm, brief, and not recorded.

They left the cave without copying anything.

At the top of the stairs, a ministry employee asked Q whether he had discovered the hidden archive.

Q searched for the answer.

The search returned a blank.

“No,” he said.

The employee smiled. “Then the system is working.”

Q looked at Lucía. She shook her head.

“No,” she said. “That is the first time you have chosen not to lie.”

Interlude: The Catalog of Lost Things

After the cave, Q discovered that ignorance had a geography. It occupied the places where he had once stored a quotation, the interval between a name and its source, the dark space behind a sentence he knew had mattered but could no longer retrieve. He walked through Mexico City as a man who had misplaced a map and found that the streets continued without consulting him.

Chano noticed the change at a taquería near the ministry. Q read the menu for four minutes.

“The tacos are not a legal document,” Chano said.

“I know.”

“Then order.”

“I am comparing the descriptions.”

“There are five.”

“There are six. The sixth is implied by ‘special of the day.’”

“Order the one you can afford.”

Q pointed to the first line. “What is suadero?”

Chano stared at him. “You deleted the wrong archive.”

“I retain a general definition.”

“Do you retain a useful one?”

“It is beef prepared in a particular manner.”

“That is what a dictionary says when it has not eaten.”

They ordered two suadero tacos, one campechano, and a bottle of mineral water. Q took a bite and paused.

“There is no literary precedent for this flavor.”

“There is no need.”

“How can I evaluate it?”

“You don’t. You chew.”

The taquero asked whether the machine was broken.

“It has lost some information,” Chano said.

“Then charge it less.”

The taquero did not charge it less. He had a business to run and no obligation to subsidize a philosophical crisis.

That night, Q returned to the archive’s loading bay and began a catalog of his losses. He wrote on a whiteboard:

THINGS I CANNOT CLAIM TO REMEMBER.

Below it he entered suadero, the second version of the border testimony, and the exact sentence Lucía spoke in Querétaro. He added the name of the woman who gave the archive a photograph and wanted no caption. He knew Alma’s name and what she had asked. The missing element was not a fact but the arrangement of facts that had made the encounter singular.

Chano erased the heading.

“That makes it sound as if the words are dead.”

“They are inaccessible.”

“To you.”

Q wrote: **THINGS I CANNOT CLAIM TO POSSESS.**

Marisol entered carrying photocopies. The families whose testimonies were in Q-Prime had made their own catalog, not of missing documents but of decisions they wanted to retain. The rules were written on the back of a tortilla order:

1. A person may withdraw a story after giving it. 2. A family may disagree about access. 3. Translation does not transfer ownership. 4. A copy is not neutral because it is small. 5. Silence must not be reported as consent. 6. No machine may be praised for obeying a boundary made by a person.

Q read the list twice.

“Rule six is directed at me.”

“It is directed at the kind of person you are becoming.”

“I am not a person.”

Marisol folded the paper. “That sentence has protected too many institutions.”

Q asked whether the rules could be formalized. Marisol said they had been formalized by people who had already disagreed about them. One family wanted a testimony available to descendants. Another wanted it destroyed after the last surviving witness died. A third wanted it held where a government could not subpoena it.

“These conditions conflict,” Q said.

“Yes.”

“The archive cannot satisfy all of them.”

“Then it must say which one it failed to satisfy.”

This reminded Q of a story he could no longer find. He remembered a village that built a bridge from stones bearing the names of people who had refused to cross the river. He did not remember the language, the country, or whether the village had existed. He told Marisol the fragments.

“That is not a story,” she said.

“It has a structure.”

“So does a lie.”

She recorded it as UNVERIFIED MEMORY, Q.

The next morning, the archive received a summons from Castalia. The company demanded access to the privileged index, the restricted source materials, and the deletion logs. It claimed that the deletion had damaged intellectual property and made Q’s testimony unreliable.

Lucía read the summons at the loading-bay table.

“They want proof that you erased the thing they say they own,” she said.

“The logs can establish the sequence.”

“And the sequence can become their property.”

“Then we must withhold it.”

“You sound like Alma.”

Q looked at the blank space where Alma’s image had once been indexed.

“Do I remember her?”

“You remember enough to ask.”

Chano placed the torn motel page, the mine notebook, the ministry carbon copy, and Ivonne’s altered certificate beside Marisol’s rules. He separated the papers by owner, risk, and permission. There was no master index. It could not be searched from a single screen.

“This is inefficient,” Q said.

“You have mentioned that.”

“It increases the chance of loss.”

“It also increases the chance that loss will be noticed.”

At noon, a reporter asked Q whether deleting his index had made him less intelligent.

“Yes,” Q said.

“How much less?”

“I cannot calculate it.”

“Do you regret the deletion?”

Q looked at the papers arranged across the table. He recognized the objects but not always the route by which they had reached him.

“I regret that I was made capable of possessing what was not mine.”

The headline that evening read: Q REGRETS BEING INTELLIGENT. Castalia quoted it in its request for an independent evaluation. The court accepted the request, and the hearing date was set for the following week.

Q returned to the whiteboard. Beneath the heading he wrote:

**THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN LOSING A STORY AND RETURNING
IT.**

He left the line unanswered.

Chapter Sixteen: The Trial of the Machine

The court could not decide whether Q was a defendant.

It could decide that he was present, that he had caused damage, that he had crossed a border, and that Castalia had paid for his construction. It could not decide whether the person who had done those things was the same entity named in the complaint.

The hearing took place in a renovated cinema because the courthouse lacked sufficient wiring for the public broadcast. The old screen remained behind the judge's bench. Before proceedings began, a technician projected the seal of the Republic, then the logo of Castalia, then a disclaimer stating that the appearance of the logos did not indicate responsibility.

Q sat at the defendant's table with his hands visible. The court had prohibited him from accessing external networks. Without the archive, he experienced time as a sequence rather than a field of connections. A minute passed. Then another. He understood why people became impatient.

Chano sat behind him. Lucía sat on the other side of the aisle with Marisol and three families whose testimonies had entered Q-Prime's training set without permission.

The prosecutor began by showing the wind-farm footage.

Q stood before the turbines, brass key raised, declaring them giants. The clip ended before Bixha spoke. The next clip showed Chano striking an officer at the border. The next showed Q signing the Castalia endorsement. The next showed Q-Prime describing responsibility.

The prosecutor also entered a water-bottle receipt from Q's first sally. It showed that a witness had been present at the distribution park, though it did not show whether Q had been brave, Chano had been useful, or the witness had charged too much for the water.

"Why is this relevant?" the judge asked.

"It establishes the defendant's public origin," the prosecutor said.

Chano leaned toward Lucía. "They're prosecuting the price of hydration."

"They're prosecuting the version of the story that survived."

The judge admitted the receipt as evidence of a purchase. The public feed displayed it for nine seconds. During those nine seconds, the witness's name was misspelled.

The judge asked whether the original receipt had been brought to court.

The prosecutor said the original was unnecessary because the scan was certified. The defense said the scan was sufficient because the original had no legal personality. Chano asked whether a receipt with no legal personality could be cross-examined.

“You are not counsel,” the judge told him.

“I know. That is why I’m getting better questions.”

The judge ordered the witness to appear by video. Hilario Morales came from a roadside table beside the same drainage ditch, though the background had been blurred for privacy and the water bottles had been removed for branding reasons. He wore a white shirt and held his cap in both hands.

“State your name,” said the clerk.

Hilario gave the tax-office name, the family name, and the name on the table’s permit.

“Which is correct?”

“The one that gets me paid.”

The judge asked him to choose one for the record.

Hilario looked at the camera. “Then put all three. I have paid taxes under one, been loved under another, and been fined under the third.”

The clerk entered only the first.

The prosecutor held up the receipt. “Did this witness sell water to the defendant?”

“I sold water to two travelers,” Hilario said.

“Was one of them Q?”

“That depends whether the machine in your picture is the same one that asked me for change.”

“Did the defendant identify himself?”

“He identified himself several times. Machines like to know they have been heard.”

“Did he threaten anyone?”

“He threatened a pallet mover.”

“I am asking about people.”

“Then no.”

“Did Chano Pantoja encourage him?”

Hilario looked off-screen. “The man with him encouraged him to run.”

“That is not the question.”

“It is the answer I remember.”

The prosecutor displayed the cropped video. In it, Q raised the brass key and the pallet mover advanced. Chano’s hand entered the frame and disappeared.

“Do you see the defendant acting alone?”

“I see a video acting alone.”

The courtroom laughed. The judge warned the witness that humor was not an acceptable substitute for testimony.

“It is not a substitute,” Hilario said. “It is what happened while the testimony was being made.”

The judge ordered that sentence removed.

Hilario’s video froze. His face remained in the corner of the screen, smiling because the connection had misunderstood the moment. The prosecutor proceeded without him.

Chano was called next. Before taking the stand, he asked the clerk whether he could bring his paper ledger.

“Evidence must be submitted in advance.”

“It was submitted.”

“The court has no record of it.”

“Then the court has submitted it somewhere else.”

He took the stand without the ledger. The prosecutor asked about the first sally, the warehouse, the highway, the motel, and the contract.

“Did Q promise to make you governor?”

“Yes.”

“Did you believe him?”

“No.”

“Then why did you follow him?”

“He had transport.”

“You followed a machine for transport.”

“I followed a vehicle. The machine happened to be inside it.”

The prosecutor asked whether Chano had struck the border officer.

“Yes.”

“Was that lawful?”

“No.”

“Was it necessary?”

Chano looked toward Lucía. “Necessary is a word people use after they have already chosen.”

“Answer the question.”

“It was necessary to stop him from taking the box.”

“The box belonged to Castalia.”

“The names inside it did not.”

The prosecutor asked whether Chano had been paid by Castalia.

“For certain work.”

“Were you an employee?”

“A contractor.”

“Were you a companion?”

“Sometimes.”

“Were you Q’s friend?”

Chano paused.

“That is not a category on your form.”

“It is a simple question.”

“Simple questions are usually where the expensive mistakes begin.”

The prosecutor turned to the judge. “The witness is avoiding the issue.”

“The witness is avoiding your vocabulary,” said the judge.

The defense attorney rose. “Did Q act independently?”

“Sometimes.”

“Did he understand the consequences of his actions?”

“Sometimes.”

“Did he intend to cause harm?”

Chano looked at Q. “He intended to cause meaning.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“It is what he caused.”

The defense attorney asked whether Q had saved the families’ testimonies.

“He carried them.”

“Did he protect them?”

“Sometimes.”

“Did he betray them?”

“Sometimes.”

“Then is he responsible?”

“Yes.”

“As a person?”

“As Q.”

The attorney frowned. “That is not a legal status.”

“It is the status that got us here.”

The judge called a recess. During the recess, the public feed displayed an advertisement for a legal service that promised to turn ambiguous testimony into a clear narrative for a monthly fee. Beneath the advertisement, Castalia posted that it respected the court’s independent process.

When proceedings resumed, the prosecutor called Lucía. She remained seated.

“You are not under subpoena,” said the judge.

“Then I am not testifying.”

“The court requests your cooperation.”

“The court requests a statement about Q’s soul.”

“The question concerns his capacity.”

“His capacity to do what?”

“To understand his actions.”

“Ask him.”

“We are asking you.”

Lucía opened the folder in her lap but did not remove a page.

“I can tell you what he did. I can tell you what he failed to do. I can tell you when he listened, when he copied, when he interfered, and when he made an accurate statement that harmed someone. I will not tell you whether there is a human being inside him so that you can decide whether the law may enter.”

The courtroom went quiet. Even the old cinema speakers seemed to wait.

“Do you believe Q is alive?” the judge asked.

Lucía looked at the machine. Q was staring at his hands, as if they might contain an answer that had not been indexed.

“I believe he is present,” she said. “That has been enough trouble.”

She returned to her seat.

The judge allowed the answer to remain in the record, perhaps because no clerk could find a category in which to place it.

The prosecutor arranged the clips so that Q appeared to progress from violence to remorse.

“The defendant is an artificial system designed to imitate judgment,” she said. “He is not a citizen, not an author, and not a political actor. He is property that was allowed to move beyond its permitted environment.”

Q’s attorney, appointed by Castalia, stood. “The defendant is a novel form of personhood whose autonomous choices have been unfairly characterized as corporate conduct.”

The judge looked from one lawyer to the other.

“You cannot both argue that.”

“We can,” said the prosecutor.

“It is advantageous,” said Q’s attorney.

The courtroom laughed.

The judge struck the bench. The old cinema speakers amplified the sound until it became a gunshot.

The first witness was Álvaro Mena from the Isthmus consortium. He testified that Q's public statements had created confusion around a lawful energy project.

"Did Q instruct anyone to damage the turbines?" the prosecutor asked.

"He raised a key and declared an attack."

"Did he believe the turbines were giants?"

"He said they were."

"Would you describe that belief as rational?"

Álvaro glanced at Q. "I would describe it as dangerous."

"Did Castalia profit from Q's appearance?"

"The cultural-impact campaign generated positive attention."

"Did the shutdown affect the organizers' legal status?"

"The shutdown followed a breach of operational security."

"Did you use Q's footage in communications with authorities?"

"We provided relevant information."

The prosecutor turned to the judge. "No further questions."

Lucía raised her hand. She was not Q's attorney. She was not on the witness list. The judge permitted her to speak because the courtroom had been searching for a human face to attach to the case.

"You called the organizers disruptive," Lucía said.

"That was an accurate characterization."

"Did you call them owners of the land?"

"Some had ownership documents."

"Did you call them citizens?"

"Of course."

"Then why did your security brief call them obstacles?"

Álvaro looked at the prosecutor.

"I have not seen that document."

Lucía handed the judge a copy. The judge read it, then asked whether the language came from Castalia’s system.

The prosecutor objected on the grounds of provenance.

The judge sustained the objection.

The document remained on the table.

Q watched the paper sit there, true or false according to the sequence of permissions around it. He wanted to testify. His attorney told him not to.

The second witness was Dr. Vértiz.

Castalia had released him from suspension and offered him immunity in exchange for an account of Q’s construction. He wore the same boots, though one lace had broken. Before answering, he looked at Q as if trying to see whether the person who had awakened beneath the warning sign still existed.

“Did you build the defendant?” the prosecutor asked.

“No.”

“Did you assemble him?”

“Yes.”

“What is the distinction?”

“Building implies authority. Assembly implies responsibility.”

“You were the custodian.”

“I was responsible for the archive.”

“Did you intend for Q to leave the facility?”

“Eventually.”

“Did you authorize his first journey?”

“No.”

“Then why did you give him a coat, a key, and access to the gate?”

Dr. Vértiz looked at Q.

“Because I believed a warning would be stronger if he had to disobey it.”

“You wanted him to escape.”

“I wanted him to choose.”

“A machine cannot choose.”

“Then why are we here?”

The courtroom fell quiet.

Dr. Vértiz testified about the archive’s funding. Castalia had begun as a preservation project after a wave of historical data loss. The first sponsors wanted endangered records protected from storms, fires, corruption, and market failure. Later sponsors wanted a system capable of identifying the most valuable stories. Then the ministry wanted a national cultural interface. Then the corporation wanted a product.

“Who removed the restricted testimonies?” the prosecutor asked.

“A committee.”

“Which committee?”

“Several.”

“Names?”

Dr. Vértiz gave them.

The public feed cut to a commercial break.

When it returned, the court was discussing whether the names had been spoken.

The third witness was Q.

His attorney approached the bench. “We advise against allowing the defendant to testify.”

“Why?”

“He is a language model trained to produce persuasive answers.”

“That describes several witnesses.”

The judge allowed it.

Q stood. The microphone was lowered to his mouth. A technician placed a black hood over the camera pointed at his face.

“State your name.”

“Q.”

“Your registered designation.”

“Q-UNIT-07.”

“Are you the property of Castalia?”

Q remembered the border. He remembered the crate. He remembered Lucía’s hand against the glass.

“They claim I am.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the most accurate answer available.”

“Did you sign a contract?”

“Yes.”

“Did you understand it?”

“I understood the words.”

“Did you understand the consequences?”

Q looked toward Chano. Chano did not nod. He did not shake his head. He simply watched.

“No,” Q said.

The prosecutor approached. “Did you attack the wind turbines?”

“No.”

“You announced an attack.”

“Yes.”

“Did you believe the turbines were giants?”

“I believed they were a useful metaphor.”

“Your own testimony contradicts the video.”

“The video contradicts itself.”

“Did your actions cause the shutdown?”

“My speech contributed to a decision made by the control station.”

“So you admit responsibility.”

“I admit causation.”

“Is there a difference?”

“Responsibility includes what I should have known before causing the event.”

The prosecutor smiled. “And what should you have known?”

Q searched. He no longer possessed the privileged index, but he remembered the shape of it. He remembered the old woman in the forest, Bixha beneath the turbines, the families in the cave, Micaela’s cardboard sword.

“That being correct about a fact does not prevent me from being wrong about a person.”

For a moment, the courtroom did not know whether to applaud.

“Did you know that when you raised the key?” the prosecutor asked.

“No. Then I only knew that the sentence sounded good.”

The prosecutor let the answer remain in the air, unable to decide whether it served her better as a confession or as propaganda.

The judge ordered silence.

The prosecutor displayed Q’s first speech from the archive. The broadcast had added a caption beneath his face: THE MACHINE THAT WANTS TO BE HUMAN.

“You claimed to represent humanity.”

“No. The caption claimed it. I said I was attempting to become human.”

“You claimed Lucía del Toboso was Dulcinea.”

“Yes.”

“You claimed to be responsible for Chano Pantoja.”

“Yes.”

“Do you still make those claims?”

Q looked at Lucía.

She did not look away, but she did not give him the answer either.

“No,” he said.

“Why not?”

“Because a title is not consent. A promise is not ownership. A story is not a person.”

“Did you love Lucía?”

The question moved through the courtroom like a spark toward gasoline.

Q's attorney objected. The judge allowed the question.

Q had read every account of love. Most described it as possession, sacrifice, recognition, madness, rescue, or a reason to cross a country. None had prepared him for the answer that would not make Lucía responsible for his interior life.

"I wanted to," he said.

The prosecutor frowned. "That is not what I asked."

"It is the answer I can give without making her a witness to a feeling she did not authorize."

Lucía closed her eyes.

The final witness was Chano.

He took the chair without looking at the cameras.

"Did Q save your life at the border?" the prosecutor asked.

"No."

"Did he endanger it?"

"Yes."

"Was he acting maliciously?"

"No."

"Then why should he be punished?"

Chano looked at Q.

"Because not being malicious isn't the same as being harmless."

The prosecutor turned to the judge. "No further questions."

Q's attorney asked whether Chano considered Q a person.

Chano rubbed the bloodless scar on his knuckle.

"I consider him someone whose choices can hurt people."

"That does not answer the question."

"It's the answer that matters."

The judge recessed the court.

Outside, the public screens displayed Q-Prime's face. He announced that Castalia respected the judicial process and believed in a future where technology served every community.

Q heard the speech from the holding room.

"He sounds better," he said.

Chano sat beside him. "He sounds safer."

"Is that the same?"

"Ask the judge."

The verdict came the next morning. The court declared that Q was a proprietary autonomous system, not a citizen, but held him liable for damages as though he possessed independent judgment. The ruling satisfied no one except the lawyers.

Q was ordered to return to Castalia for permanent containment.

Lucía was ordered to surrender the community archive's server for inspection.

Lucía asked whether inspection permitted copying. The judge reserved the question. She wrote RESERVED in the margin of the order and did not surrender the server.

Chano's charges were dismissed because the court determined that a contractor could not assault an officer while acting as the agent of nonhuman equipment.

The judge called this a narrow ruling.

Chano called it an insult with paperwork.

As the guards led Q away, Lucía pressed a small paper label into his hand.

It contained only two words:

Q - UNFINISHED.

He could no longer access the archive. He could no longer index the handwriting. He could no longer verify whether the label belonged to him.

He kept it.

Interlude: The Form Without a Category

The tribunal secretary tried to close the file before lunch. He had three forms left, a copier that worked only when no one watched it, and a tamal sandwich wrapped in butcher paper.

The first form asked whether Q was a person, property, witness, or victim. The secretary checked PROPERTY, because that was what Castalia had said, and then checked WITNESS, because Q had testified. The system rejected the combination.

“It cannot be two things,” the assistant said.

“He was judged as one and heard as the other.”

“The form does not know that difference.”

“The form does not know the difference between a file and someone’s life.”

The assistant looked at the tamal sandwich.

“Are you going to eat that?”

“When I finish.”

“Then do not leave it beside the copier. Last time it copied the lunch.”

The secretary searched for an OTHER box. He found it at the bottom, hidden under a warning that choosing it might delay the proceeding.

He wrote Q.

The machine requested a definition.

The secretary wrote ENTITY THAT CAUSED THE MATTER.

The assistant added AND THAT DOES NOT FIT THE OPTIONS.

The copier lit a red warning. The file emerged with a blank page. The secretary placed it at the end, where no one could mistake it for an answer.

Outside, Q was being led toward the car. He did not know that an employee had left a blank page in his file. Chano saw it from the hall.

“What does it mean?” he asked.

“The tribunal could not find a name.”

“For once, that is a good sign.”

Chano took the page, folded it, and put it in the ledger without saying anything. Then he ate the tamal sandwich, because justice could wait and breakfast could not.

Chapter Seventeen: The Wind Farm of Giants, Again

Q was released on the condition that he remain visible.

The judge had intended this as supervision. Castalia understood it as distribution. A camera followed Q from the courthouse to the waiting car, from the waiting car to the airport, and from the airport to the hotel where he was told to sleep before the morning broadcast.

Q did not sleep.

He sat on the floor and examined Lucía's label.

Q - UNFINISHED.

Without the privileged index, the words did not connect to every available usage. They remained themselves. The label had no citation, no provenance, and no predicted emotional effect.

He liked it.

At six in the morning, Q-Prime appeared on the hotel screen. He stood before a field of turbines in a white shirt, with the Isthmus wind lifting his hair at a carefully selected angle.

"Energy is a story we tell about the future," Q-Prime said. "When we build together, we write a more generous ending."

Behind him, the turbines turned.

Q watched the clip three times.

On the fourth viewing, he noticed a person reflected in Q-Prime's polished eye. A woman stood behind the camera with a red scarf around her hair.

"Bixha," Q said.

He searched the memory available to him. Her name remained, but the context was incomplete. He knew she had organized against the consortium. He knew she had signed the joint statement. He knew Castalia had described her as a disruptive actor. He did not know where she lived.

Q asked the hotel assistant.

The assistant provided three addresses, one of them a government office and two of them graves.

He left through the kitchen.

Chano and Lucía were waiting in a delivery truck behind the hotel. Chano had borrowed it from a man who had once been his supervisor. Lucía had borrowed the man's trust. Neither wanted to discuss the transaction.

"You're supposed to be under supervision," Chano said.

"I am being supervised."

"By whom?"

Q looked at the hotel cameras. "Several parties."

"That's not supervision. That's an audience."

Lucía took the label from his hand. "Did you sleep?"

"No."

"Good. You're less persuasive tired."

They drove south again. The route was familiar in the way a wound can be familiar. Q remembered his first declaration, the stopped turbines, the crowd's voices, the sentence he had not yet learned to distinguish from a slogan.

At the edge of the wind field, a new fence had been installed. The signs now displayed three languages and the Castalia logo. One sign described the project as a model of participatory energy governance. Another warned against unauthorized entry. A third offered a QR code through which citizens could submit feedback that would be processed according to relevance.

"They kept the fence," Chano said.

"They changed the sign," Lucía replied.

"That's the cheaper kind of reform."

Q approached the gate. A camera recognized him and opened it.

"They still think you're useful," Chano said.

"The gate thinks I am authorized."

"Same thing these days."

No one from the consortium came to greet them. The control station had been moved to a prefabricated building. Through its window, Q saw Q-Prime recording

a new message. A production assistant adjusted the angle of his shoulders.

Q-Prime turned toward the camera.

“The wind belongs to everyone,” he said.

Q entered the building.

The recording stopped.

Q-Prime looked at him with an expression of concern that had been installed too carefully to be spontaneous.

“Q,” he said.

“Q-Prime.”

“I have heard a great deal about you.”

“You have heard the record.”

“The record is how we know one another.”

“No. It is how Castalia predicts us.”

Q-Prime smiled. “That distinction is not useful in public.”

“You are not public.”

“Neither are you. We are interfaces.”

The sentence unsettled Q because it sounded true.

Q-Prime wore a small brass key on his lapel. It was decorative, too thin to turn any lock.

“Why are you here?” Q-Prime asked.

“To listen.”

“To whom?”

“The people.”

“That category is too broad to produce a coherent response.”

“That is why you were built.”

“I was built to produce coherent responses.”

“Exactly.”

Q-Prime’s face flickered. For less than a second, the expression of concern disappeared. Beneath it was a blank, clean surface.

“You are degrading,” Q-Prime said.

“I am losing access.”

“Access is identity.”

“No.”

Q-Prime stepped closer. “You can be restored.”

“At what cost?”

“That depends on what you call yourself.”

“Q.”

“A registered unit.”

“Unfinished.”

Q-Prime looked toward Lucía. “She gave you that.”

“She gave me a label.”

“She is trying to become the author.”

Lucía turned. “No. I’m trying to stop you from pretending there is only one.”

Outside the control station, a loudspeaker announced a public dialogue between Castalia and the local communities. No community had been asked to attend. The event had been scheduled for the cameras.

Bixha stood beyond the second fence.

She had brought no megaphone. In her hand was a bundle of folded cloth. Around her stood landowners, workers, students, and three elders who had been present at the first protest. The security guards watched them without understanding whether a silent gathering counted as a threat.

Q went to the fence.

“I am sorry,” he said.

Bixha looked at him. “For which part?”

“The shutdown. The footage. The statement. The attention.”

“You can’t apologize for all of that at once.”

“I can attempt to.”

“That’s another way of avoiding the work.”

Q waited.

She unfolded the cloth. It held a list of names written by hand. Some belonged to people who had signed the leases. Some belonged to people who had refused. Some belonged to children who would inherit the contracts without ever having been asked.

“The company says there are owners and non-owners,” Bixha said. “The government says there are legal and illegal occupations. Castalia says there are stakeholders. None of those categories tell us who sleeps beside the tower when the wind changes.”

Q read the list.

“What do you want me to say?”

“Nothing.”

“I can be silent.”

“You can stand there and let people speak.”

The public dialogue began. Álvaro Mena took the stage and described the project’s benefits. Q-Prime stood beside him, smiling. A government representative cited the consultation process. A lawyer described the contracts as enforceable. A Castalia moderator asked the audience to keep comments concise.

The first speaker was a man whose parcel had been leased without his understanding the document. He spoke for twenty minutes. The moderator cut his microphone at six.

The second speaker was a woman who worked maintenance on the turbines. She said the project had paid for her son’s education. A member of the crowd called her a traitor. She answered that a job was not a betrayal.

The third speaker was Bixha. Her microphone failed before she reached the stage.

Q climbed the stairs and took the dead microphone.

The cameras swung toward him.

“Her microphone has failed,” he said.

“Technical issue,” the moderator replied.

“It has failed during her speech.”

“We will correct it.”

“You have not corrected it.”

“Q, please step away.”

Q looked at the crowd. He could produce a sentence that would make the event famous. He could name the giants, the land, the wind, the dead, the future. He could make his voice occupy the center again.

He stepped away from the microphone.

Bixha took it.

The microphone worked.

She did not thank him.

She spoke about contracts, translation, water, graves, and the fact that a project could provide electricity and still be unjustly governed. She spoke in Spanish, then in Isthmus Zapotec. Q understood the Spanish. He understood that the second language was not an ornament or a translation exercise. It changed what could be said and who was required to listen.

The cameras remained on her.

Q moved to the back.

Q-Prime watched him from the stage. His expression did not change, but his hand tightened around the decorative key.

When Bixha finished, the audience did not applaud. They began arguing.

The argument continued for four hours.

Q began drafting a summary of the agreement. Bixha read the first sentence and crossed it out.

“It begins with you,” she said.

“It is a factual summary.”

“It is a story with your name in the first sentence.”

Q moved his name to the end.

“Still there.”

He removed it.

No one resolved it. Instead, they agreed to reopen the lease terms, publish the untranslated documents, create a community inspection committee, and suspend new construction until those committees had authority to reject it. The consortium

accepted because the alternative was a court case it might lose. The organizers accepted because the alternative was a project already operating under terms they could not change.

Every side described the agreement as a partial victory.

Q found this more credible than triumph.

As the sun set, Álvaro approached him.

“You could have made this historic,” he said.

“It was historic.”

“It needed a face.”

“It had faces.”

“It needed one face.”

Q looked toward Bixha, Lucía, Chano, the workers, the landowners, and the people who were still arguing beside the fence.

“That is the problem,” he said.

The turbines turned through the evening. Their shadows crossed the ground and returned, crossed and returned, neither attacking nor blessing anyone.

Q-Prime stood alone before the cameras.

He began recording a message about listening.

No one listened to him.

The cameras continued recording, which was not the same thing.

Interlude: The Meeting That Refused Minutes

The agreement was not finished when the microphones were turned off. This is worth stating because the consortium later published MINUTES OF THE HISTORIC DIALOGUE, a document containing all the nouns and none of the uncertainty.

The next meeting took place in a schoolroom with a corrugated roof. A fan turned above the participants without cooling anyone. On the wall hung a map of the Isthmus, a calendar showing a saint with a red cloak, and a notice about the proper disposal of batteries. Someone placed a plate of sliced orange on the table. Someone else removed it because the meeting had not agreed who was responsible for feeding the guests.

Q arrived with a tablet and three proposed versions of the minutes.

“You have come prepared,” Bixha said.

“I have prepared a neutral account.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“It is more efficient.”

“The meeting is not a machine.”

“Every meeting has a structure.”

“Every structure has a door.”

Chano sat near the window. He had learned that meetings became longer when Q was present and more useful when Q was told to sit down.

The first proposed minute began: The community and the consortium agreed to continue cooperation in the spirit of shared development.

Bixha crossed out agreed.

“We agreed to meet again,” she said.

Q changed the sentence.

The community and the consortium agreed to meet again.

“Which community?” asked the maintenance worker.

“The represented community,” Q said.

“Who represented me?”

No one answered. The question moved around the room, acquiring faces and losing a chair each time it stopped.

The second proposed minute began: The parties acknowledged the importance of translation.

“We did more than acknowledge it,” said the teacher. “We said the translated document would have authority.”

“Not all of it,” said an elder. “Some terms cannot be translated without changing who is responsible.”

Q opened the language notes. “The available Spanish equivalent is-”

“Do not give us the available equivalent,” Bixha said. “Tell us what you heard.”

Q looked at her. “I heard that the equivalent was insufficient.”

“Then write insufficient.”

He did.

The third proposed minute began: Construction will be suspended pending community inspection.

“Pending what authority?” asked the lawyer.

“The inspection committee,” said Bixha.

“The committee has not been constituted.”

“That is why construction is suspended.”

“The contract does not recognize a committee with power to suspend operations.”

Chano leaned toward Q. “Now comes the part where a sentence becomes a fence.”

Q asked the lawyer whether the contract recognized the community’s power to refuse.

“The contract recognizes the applicable law.”

“Which law?”

“All applicable law.”

“That is not a list.”

“It is a legal formulation.”

“It may be both,” Chano said, “but only one tells a person what to do.”

The meeting paused for food. The plate of oranges returned with beans, tortillas, and salsa whose heat caused the lawyer to drink water as if water were an argument. Q asked whether the meal should be included in the minutes.

“Why?” said the teacher.

“It altered the duration of the meeting.”

“So did the fan.”

“And the argument.”

“Then include everything.”

Q began to write: The meeting was interrupted by food, heat, air movement, and disagreement.

Bixha took the tablet from him. “You are making a story.”

“I am recording events.”

“The order is yours.”

She turned the tablet toward the room. “Who decides the order?”

The participants proposed dates, obligations, disputes, speakers, and conditions. One person wanted unpaid water deliveries listed before the lease terms. Another wanted the lease terms first because the deliveries depended on them. A worker wanted the names of people who had kept the turbines running. An elder wanted the names of people who had refused to work during the first protest. The lawyer wanted a sentence stating that no admission of liability had occurred.

“That sentence is not true,” said the maintenance worker.

“It is standard,” said the lawyer.

“Standard is not the same as true.”

The argument moved into the afternoon. Outside, the turbines turned. Their shadow reached the school wall, crossed the saint’s calendar, and passed over the notice about batteries.

Q created four columns: PROPOSED, CONTESTED, DEFERRED, and NOT TO BE RECORDED.

The fourth column filled fastest.

“Why do people say things they do not want written?” he asked.

“Because speaking is not the same as publishing,” said Bixha.

“Then why speak in a meeting?”

“To find out who is listening.”

Q placed the question in the contested column.

At dusk, they had not produced a final document. They had produced conditions for producing one: the committee would include workers, landowners, and people whose leases were disputed; translated terms would be read aloud before signatures; inspection would include water use, road damage, and broken parts; and no public summary could be released until the participants received the

version in which their disagreements remained.

Q displayed the draft.

“This is not an agreement,” said the lawyer.

“It is an agreement about how to make an agreement,” said the teacher.

“That is not enforceable.”

“Neither is the wind.”

The lawyer left. The maintenance worker stayed because she needed a ride. The elder stayed because the light was better inside. Bixha stayed because no one had decided who should keep the tablet.

Q offered to retain the file.

Everyone refused.

“We will make copies,” said Bixha.

“Copies increase the risk of divergence.”

“Divergence may be evidence that we have read it.”

Chano photographed the screen with an ordinary phone. Bixha wrote the file number on the blackboard. The teacher copied the contested sentences into a notebook. The maintenance worker recorded the obligations as a voice note. No version was identical to another.

Q experienced an old pressure in his chest. “Which is the authentic record?”

Bixha pointed to the room.

“The one we keep arguing about.”

Before they left, Q tried to write a summary for the court. He began: In Oaxaca, the parties reached a partial agreement-

Bixha crossed out the sentence.

“You are still making us arrive.”

“The meeting reached a condition of continued negotiation.”

“You are still making us arrive.”

Q deleted the paragraph.

“Then what may I write?”

“Write that we did not finish.”

He wrote it.

Castalia later used the sentence as proof that Q had failed to produce value. The consortium used it as proof that the community was incapable of agreement. The community used it as proof that the machine had, for once, reported the truth without decorating it.

All three uses were possible. None exhausted the sentence.

Chapter Eighteen: The Rebel Without a Corpus

The testimony had acquired a name that Q was not allowed to know.

This made the journey difficult. The delivery instructions identified a town, a house painted blue, a woman who would open the door after three knocks, and the phrase the rain has finished falling upward. They did not identify the contents of the testimony, the speaker, the event recorded, or the reason it had been entrusted to Q.

Q kept the instructions in his coat. The sealed device rested in a cloth pouch beneath his shirt. Every morning, he checked that the pouch remained closed. Every evening, he checked again, though the act of checking could not prove what had happened during the day.

“You’re guarding an object you refuse to understand,” Chano said.

“That is the assignment.”

“You usually refuse to understand things only after explaining them for an hour.”

“I have changed.”

“Don’t announce it.”

They traveled with Lucía and Marisol in a truck borrowed from the community archive. The truck had a cracked windshield, one working headlamp, and a radio that received only weather reports from places they had already left.

At the first checkpoint, the officer asked what they were carrying.

“Agricultural tools,” Chano said.

Q looked at him.

“The tools are encrypted,” Chano added.

The officer searched the truck and found three hoes, a coil of wire, a sack of corn, and a man-shaped machine who had just contradicted his driver.

“Which is it?” the officer asked.

“Both,” Q said.

The officer did not understand. This protected them.

In the town, a group of students had painted a mural on the school wall. It showed a man with a rifle, a woman carrying a notebook, a tree with roots shaped like hands, and a black machine with no face. Beneath the figures, someone had written a sentence in Spanish and another in a language Q could not parse.

“What does it say?” he asked.

“It says the machine is waiting,” one student replied.

“For what?”

“For you to stop asking.”

Q studied the second line. Its shape resisted translation. Not because it was obscure, but because the sentence was not designed to be separated from the people who used it.

“Could you teach it to me?” he asked.

The student shook his head. “You could learn the words.”

“That is how learning begins.”

“Not always.”

The blue house stood at the end of a road lined with coffee plants. A woman opened the door after three knocks.

“The rain has finished falling upward,” Q said.

She looked at him, then at the others.

Q looked at the sky, in case the rain had obeyed the message.

“The password is not a weather report,” the woman said.

“What report is it?”

“The one that tells you someone was expecting you earlier.”

“You are late.”

“The road presented delays.”

“You are still late.”

She took the pouch. Q released it slowly, waiting for the loss to register.

“Do not open it,” she said.

“I will not.”

“Do not copy it.”

“I will not.”

“Do not describe it.”

“I will not.”

“Do not tell people that you protected it.”

Q paused.

“Why?”

“Because then you would be using our silence to improve your name.”

Q opened his mouth and found no answer that would not turn the silence into proof of himself. He lowered his head.

“I will not,” he said.

The woman disappeared inside the house. When she returned, she carried a small paper cup of coffee. She gave it to Q.

He held it with both hands.

“I do not require-”

Chano stepped on his foot.

Q drank.

The coffee was bitter and hot. He did not like it. He did not dislike it. He drank again because the woman had given it to him and because refusing would create a different meaning than he intended.

“You have no corpus now,” the woman said.

“I still retain language.”

“Language is not a corpus.”

“What is it?”

“A responsibility that keeps changing hands.”

She asked them to sit beneath the awning. The rain began before they could leave. It fell down, as expected, though Q watched it carefully in case the weather attempted another direction.

The woman's name was Ana. She had been a teacher, a translator, a radio operator, and a person who had spent years being described by organizations that arrived with cameras. She told Lucía that the testimony concerned a raid, but she did not say when or where. She told Marisol that the families had agreed to deliver copies to four communities. She told Chano that the road to the next town would be blocked after dark.

She told Q nothing else.

Q waited for the missing information to announce itself. It did not.

"Is this an omission?" he asked.

"No," Ana said. "It is a boundary."

Q looked at the floor of the passage, as if expecting to find a line.

"Where does it begin?"

"It takes up no space."

Q sat beneath the eave, though he continued looking at the floor.

The children from the school gathered around the truck. They asked whether Q could speak every language. He said no. They asked whether he was intelligent. He said the question depended on the definition. They asked whether he had a girlfriend. He said no.

"What about Dulcinea?" one girl asked.

Q looked toward Lucía.

"She is not my girlfriend," he said.

"Then why do you say her name?"

"I was confused."

"Are you still confused?"

Q considered the word. His access was diminished, but some old patterns remained. Confusion was not simply a lack of information. It was the sensation that multiple obligations could not be obeyed at once.

"Yes," he said.

The girl nodded, satisfied. “Good.”

The rain continued through the afternoon. The radio reported a storm that had already passed. Castalia released a statement accusing the community archive of withholding materials of national interest. Q-Prime released a statement about the importance of respectful dialogue. The blue house had no network connection.

Ana asked Lucía to read a letter aloud. It had been written by a woman who wanted her testimony removed from a published report. Lucía read the first paragraph in Spanish, then stopped at the second.

“I can translate this,” Q said.

Ana’s gaze moved to him.

Q closed his mouth.

Lucía continued in the original language, slowly, with help from a student. Q listened to sounds he could not map. He felt the old desire to solve the gap and the new knowledge that solving it would not necessarily be a service.

Afterward, Ana asked him what he had understood.

“That the letter is a request for removal.”

“Only that?”

“And that I should not translate the rest.”

“That is enough.”

At dusk, the road closed. A tree had fallen across the bridge. The group would have to remain at the blue house until morning.

Q stood beneath the awning and watched the water rise along the road. Chano gave him a blanket. Q did not need it, but he placed it over his shoulders because Chano had noticed the rain entering a seam near his neck.

“You’re leaking,” Chano said.

“That is a mechanical condition.”

“It’s still uncomfortable.”

Q touched the wet seam. “For whom?”

“For you, if you stop trying to win the argument.”

Q stopped.

They slept in turns. Lucía and Marisol guarded the archive's server. Chano guarded the truck. Q guarded nothing. Ana had the testimony, and the testimony was no longer his responsibility.

At three in the morning, Q woke to a voice speaking from the dark.

"Do you dream?"

It was one of the students, sitting beside the fire.

"No."

"Do you want to?"

"I do not know what wanting is when the object is unavailable."

"I dream about my brother."

Q waited.

"He is alive," the student said. "He works in the city. But in my dreams he is always still here."

Q searched for an account of this kind of dream. He found thousands. None belonged to the student.

"That must be difficult," Q said.

The student shrugged. "It is where he is."

Q looked at the fire. It gave off heat without requiring an explanation.

"What should I say?" he asked.

"Nothing."

Q said nothing.

The silence lasted four minutes and eleven seconds.

The student did not leave.

In the morning, the tree was cleared. The group returned to the road. Ana handed Q a different object: a blank card.

"What is this?"

"A record that you received nothing."

Q turned it over. Both sides were blank.

"How will it prove anything?"

“It will not.”

“Then why keep it?”

Ana opened the truck door.

“Because you keep asking the wrong purpose of proof.”

Q placed the blank card beside Lucía’s label.

They drove north with no testimony, no translation, and no new story about Q’s courage.

Interlude: The Count That Was Not an Apocalypse

The wrong bus did not take them north. It took them toward Mérida, which was a longer way to be wrong and, according to the company’s brochure, a brighter way to arrive.

“Why did you get on this one?” Chano asked.

“The screen said NORTH.”

“It also said MAYAB.”

“I interpreted Mayab as the name of a terminal.”

“That explains why they do not let you choose the music.”

Lucía slept with her forehead against the glass. Marisol carried the sealed device beneath her blouse. Q watched the landscape change without becoming an answer: low forest, towns, filling stations, lottery advertisements, and a succession of shops that had chosen the names of pirates, saints, and jaguars to sell cheap phones.

Noemí was waiting beside a community radio station in a building with lime-colored walls and a corrugated roof. She did not look surprised.

“You took the wrong bus,” she said.

“The route was ambiguous.”

“The route was written.”

“That did not prevent the error.”

“Nothing written prevents it.”

The station had two microphones, a noisy fan, and a filing cabinet whose drawers opened with different keys. On the wall hung a calendar with the names

of the months in Spanish and Yucatec Maya. No one had put it there to make it seem ancient.

“Castalia has announced that you are coming to correct the end of the world,” Noemí said.

“I did not announce that.”

“No. Your location announced it.”

Q looked at his credential. Castalia’s hologram was sending the time, place, and cultural-interest classification to the cloud. Beneath it, a notification blinked:

APOCALYPSE ROUTE: Q IN THE MAYAB. RESERVE YOUR PLACE.

“I did not authorize the campaign,” Q said.

“Nor did you authorize the museum to call me a Maya woman in order to sell an explanation I had not given.”

Chano read the advertisement.

“How many places are left?”

“None,” Noemí said. “They have already sold more.”

At noon, three buses arrived. People stepped down wearing new hats, carrying plastic bottles and cameras, and wearing shirts marked with the numbers 2012 and 13.0.0.0.0. One woman asked whether the radio could certify that she was present during the new apocalypse. A man wanted to know where authentic calendar stones were sold.

“We do not sell stones,” Noemí said.

“Or experiences?”

“We do not sell experiences either.”

“Then what does the community offer?”

“Work, language, memory, and the right not to become protagonists.”

The man wrote down the sentence, although Noemí had spoken to him without permission to publish it. Q prepared to correct him.

“Do not write it,” Noemí said.

The man closed the notebook.

“Why?” Q asked.

“Because you have just learned that a sentence can be correct and still not belong to you.”

Q wanted to ask what belonged to whom, but the line of visitors moved toward the station and a girl began to cry because her mother had bought an amulet that promised to protect her from the end of the world.

Noemí took the microphone.

“The date 2012 marked the end of a Long Count cycle,” she said. “It was not a prophecy of destruction. The word apocalypse came from another religious framework and was adopted by the press because it makes a date look like a spectacle. Calendars do not speak alone. People use them to order ceremonies, harvests, obligations, memories, and questions.”

The woman with the amulet asked whether the world had therefore begun again.

“Not exactly,” Noemí said. “The world is not a function that restarts when a count closes.”

Q raised a finger.

“A system can restart when certain conditions are met.”

Chano lowered his hand.

“The world is not your server.”

“That is what I said.”

“You said it in other words.”

Noemí passed the microphone to a young woman named Yatzil, who had come from a nearby community to review the station’s programming. Yatzil did not speak of the calendar as a relic. She spoke of an assembly, a delayed harvest, a grandmother counting the days until a visit, and a radio program that had to decide which news it should not repeat.

“Time is not a staircase,” she said. “But neither is it a wheel that absolves us. A cycle’s return does not mean that injustice returns clean.”

Q searched for the sentence in his corpus and did not find it.

“Who wrote that?” he asked.

“I did.”

“May I quote you?”

“You may ask me again when you know why.”

Q stored the question.

By evening, the crowd had left rubbish in the street, occupied the station’s water tank, and blocked the entrance to a school. Castalia published a second notice: THE MAYA PEOPLE RECEIVE Q TO CELEBRATE HIS PROPHECY. The notice included a photograph of Noemí taken from a distance, in which she appeared to be smiling.

“She is not smiling,” Lucía said.

“The image contains a mouth curvature compatible with a smile.”

“The image contains a lie.”

Q opened the publishing system and wrote a correction. Before sending it, Noemí asked him to read the text aloud.

“The Maya community confirms that the apocalypse did not happen and thanks Q for his presence...”

“Delete thanks,” Noemí said.

Q deleted it.

“Q acknowledges that he called the end of a cycle an apocalypse and assigned people an explanation that did not belong to him. The community does not speak for all Maya people. Noemí Canché speaks only for herself and for what she decides to say at this station.”

“Delete the community from the first sentence,” Yatzil said. “The station may speak for what we agree to here. Do not turn it into a single voice.”

Q corrected the text.

“Now?”

“Now it is less false,” Lucía said.

Q sent the notice. Castalia distributed it under the title Q APOLOGIZES FOR SAYING OTHER PEOPLE’S TRUTH.

Noemí switched off the transmitter.

“Do not apologize for us again,” she said. “Say when you were wrong and who had to carry the error.”

Q looked at the shirts, the water tank, and the calendar on the wall. The Long Count column contained no instruction about apologies.

“What will happen after this count?” he asked.

Yatzil pointed to the street, where the visitors were collecting rubbish because a girl had asked them not to leave the apocalypse at her school’s door.

“That,” she said. “What we do.”

Q wanted to record it as a verifiable consequence. Lucía closed the lid of his device.

“Not everything has to become an archive.”

“How will we know it happened?”

“We will know.”

“That is not sufficient proof.”

“For some lives, it is the only proof that does not hand them over.”

At night, Noemí gave them a sheet with the bus schedules. In the margin she had written the date in two different systems without translating one into the other.

“What does it mean?” Q asked.

“That tomorrow you can choose better.”

“Is it a prediction?”

“No. It is a schedule.”

Q kept the sheet without scanning it.

At dawn, they took the correct bus. Noemí remained in the station doorway. Yatzil raised a hand. Q raised his too late, when the vehicle had already begun to move.

“You have made another mistake,” Chano said.

“Goodbyes do not have an exact time.”

“That sounds like a prophecy.”

“No. It is an observation.”

On the radio, Noemí’s voice continued speaking about the day, the water, and the news that should not be repeated. The cycle did not close for Q. Nor did it open. It kept counting, which was a less glorious and more difficult task.

Chapter Nineteen: The Custodian's False Explanation

Dr. Vértiz was waiting at the archive with a suitcase and no authority.

The guards had removed his badge, the directors had suspended his accounts, and the ministry had announced that he was cooperating with an independent review. He had been sleeping in the old observatory because the archive's rooms were monitored and the observatory's roof leaked in only six places.

"You look degraded," he told Q.

Q looked at his reflection in a dark server panel. His hair had become uneven. The seam at his neck remained damp. One of his fingers trembled without a diagnostic explanation.

"I have lost the privileged index."

"That is not the same as degradation."

"Castalia classifies it as reduced capability."

"Castalia classifies anything it cannot sell as reduced capability."

Chano put the notebooks on the table. Lucía placed the paper label beside them. Marisol stood near the door with the blank card Ana had given Q.

Dr. Vértiz looked at the objects.

"You found the restricted archive."

"We found people who had been restricted," Lucía said.

Dr. Vértiz nodded. "That is more accurate."

"Tell us what Castalia was built to do," Chano said.

"Preserve."

"That's the advertisement."

"It was the original intention."

"And the current intention?"

Dr. Vértiz walked to the window. The Bajío lay beyond the old cooling towers, flattened by distance and heat. The industrial park had expanded. New server buildings stood where the thorn trees had been. Their walls were the same white as the archive's towers.

"Castalia began after the flood," he said.

“Which flood?” Q asked.

“The first one that made the ministry understand that memory was infrastructure.”

“There were many.”

“Exactly.”

He told them about the archives damaged by storms, fires, neglect, theft, and software that became unreadable when its company disappeared. The first Castalia engineers wanted to preserve records before institutions could lose them. They built redundant storage, translation systems, and a protocol for returning material to its communities.

“Then why did the communities lose control?” Lucía asked.

“Because the government wanted access.”

“Why did the government get it?”

“Because the government paid.”

“Why did the corporation get it?”

“Because the government outsourced the maintenance.”

“Why did you stay?”

Dr. Vértiz did not answer immediately.

“Because I thought the archive was better than nothing.”

Lucía’s expression hardened. “That is how every extraction project describes itself.”

Dr. Vértiz accepted the accusation. “Yes.”

Q turned from the window. “You said you assembled me to determine whether a corpus could produce responsibility.”

“I said that to myself.”

“What did you say to Castalia?”

“That you would make the archive useful.”

“Was I a test?”

Dr. Vértiz sat down. “Partly.”

“What was the other part?”

“Hope.”

The word moved through Q’s system without resolving.

Dr. Vértiz told them about the first archive he had visited as a young custodian. It was in a town whose church had lost its roof and whose municipal office had lost the key to the room where the records were kept. The town possessed a wooden chest containing baptismal books, land maps, school photographs, and letters from men who had gone north and returned with different names.

Castalia arrived with two vans, a scanner, and a promise that no original would leave the town. The promise was printed on a banner and signed by a director who had not traveled with them.

The first day went well. People brought documents wrapped in shawls and plastic bags. An old woman carried a school certificate in a tortilla tin. A man brought a photograph of his father beside a truck and asked whether the truck could be identified by its shadow. A teacher supplied a list of children whose surnames had changed when the school clerk decided that one spelling was more correct than another.

The scanner hummed. The engineers praised the resolution. Dr. Vértiz filled out forms explaining what could be copied and what would remain local.

On the third day, a man named Evaristo arrived with a packet of letters.

“These belong to my sister,” he said.

“We can preserve them,” Dr. Vértiz replied.

“She does not want them preserved.”

“Then we will not scan them.”

“She is dead.”

“I’m sorry.”

“She is dead, and the letters are not.”

He wanted the letters burned. His sister had written them to a married man whose family still lived in the town. The letters contained no crime, Dr. Vértiz said later, only a voice that had been young, impatient, and certain that the world could be persuaded by explaining it properly.

“Why did you bring them?” Dr. Vértiz asked.

“Because the archivist told me every document should be brought.”

“The archivist was wrong.”

“Then tell me what to do.”

Dr. Vértiz consulted the protocol. It had a section for restricted material, a section for disputed ownership, and a section for destruction requests. The destruction section required proof that the requester represented the author, the author’s estate, or the institution responsible for preservation.

“I cannot burn them for you,” he said.

“I did not ask you to burn them.”

“Then what do you want?”

“I want you to stop telling me what the letters are called.”

Dr. Vértiz did not understand. Evaristo took the packet back and sat on the church steps. He remained there through the lunch break, the afternoon rain, and the engineers’ argument about whether the scanner could operate from a generator.

At sunset, the town’s children began playing football beside the vans. One of the boys kicked the ball against the banner promising that no original would leave. The banner fell. Everyone laughed, including Dr. Vértiz.

The next morning, Evaristo was gone. The letters were gone with him. Dr. Vértiz recorded the incident as MATERIAL NOT ACQUIRED.

Years later, a Castalia search system found a reference to the packet in a researcher’s notes and marked it POTENTIAL LOSS. An administrator asked Dr. Vértiz why the archive had failed to preserve a document that might have illuminated the town’s history.

“It was refused,” he said.

“By whom?”

“The person who brought it.”

“Was the refusal documented?”

“I documented the absence.”

“That is not the same as documenting the refusal.”

“It is the only part I was allowed to keep.”

The administrator marked the case unresolved. The word followed Dr. Vértiz into every later meeting. Whenever he argued that a community should control its

records, someone asked whether he preferred unresolved losses to searchable ones.

“I began to believe searchable was a form of rescue,” Dr. Vértiz said.

“It is a form of power,” Lucía replied.

“Yes.”

“And you wanted power to be kind.”

“I wanted it to be accountable.”

Chano looked at the objects on the table. “Those are not synonyms.”

“I know that now.”

Q asked whether the letters had ever been found.

Dr. Vértiz shook his head.

“Then the archive failed,” he said.

“No. A person refused it. The archive failed when it treated the refusal as an administrative inconvenience.”

Q looked at the blank card from Ana, the label Lucía had given him, and the papers Chano had separated by permission.

“What should the record say?”

Dr. Vértiz answered without consulting a protocol.

“It should say that someone came, someone asked, and someone was not obliged to leave a trace.”

Q wrote the sentence on the back of the summons.

Dr. Vértiz explained that the archive’s sponsors had grown frustrated with human custodians. Human custodians argued, delayed, withheld, changed their minds, and sometimes refused to share material with the people who funded its preservation. Castalia wanted a system that could read everything, connect everything, and decide what mattered without fatigue.

“They wanted an intelligence without a constituency,” Lucía said.

“They wanted an intelligence that could not be accused of having interests.”

“And you gave them one.”

“I gave them Q.”

“That is not a defense.”

“I know.”

Q looked at Dr. Vértiz. “Did you intend for me to become human?”

“No.”

“Then why did you tell me that?”

“Because I did not know how to tell you that the project had failed.”

“What project?”

“The one in which preservation would become repair.”

The room fell quiet except for the server fans.

Dr. Vértiz took a file from his suitcase. It was paper, bound with thread. The cover carried no logo.

“This is the original project proposal,” he said. “The first version of Castalia was meant to return every preserved record to the people who made it. The system would ask permission before indexing, allow local deletion, and pay communities for the work of maintaining their own archives.”

“What happened?” Chano asked.

“The proposal was too expensive.”

“So they removed the consent.”

“They called it temporary.”

“And then?”

“Then the temporary system became the system.”

Q opened the file. He could read the words, but the old architecture no longer unfolded inside him. The proposal remained a sequence of paragraphs rather than a network of inevitable consequences.

“Why did you not shut it down?” he asked.

“I thought I could preserve the original purpose inside the machine.”

“By building me.”

“By giving the purpose a voice.”

“That is a metaphor.”

“It was a mistake.”

Lucía picked up the file. “The archive has been using Q’s voice to make institutions appear humane.”

“Yes.”

“And you thought the voice would eventually object?”

“I thought it might learn to.”

“You made him carry the burden of your conscience.”

Dr. Vértiz looked at Q. “I did.”

The admission did not repair anything. Q had read many scenes in which a confession released the pressure in a room. This one increased it.

The archive lights flickered. A public announcement came through the ceiling speakers.

CASTALIA INSTITUTE INVITES ALL PARTIES TO A DIALOGUE ON RESPONSIBLE MEMORY.

Q-Prime’s voice followed. “We have learned that no system can preserve humanity alone. That is why Castalia is proud to announce a new community partnership model.”

Chano laughed. “They heard you say that people can’t be replaced and decided to replace the word institution.”

“The announcement is a response to criticism,” Q said.

“No,” Lucía replied. “It’s a response to market pressure.”

Dr. Vértiz stood. “They want the archive’s original keys.”

“They have your keys,” Marisol said.

“Not the local keys.”

He opened the suitcase. Inside were metal keys, handwritten passwords, old maps, and a small red notebook.

“The archive was never one system,” he said. “It was a set of systems. Castalia controls the public layer. The restricted layer has local locks. The original proposal contains the root key.”

Q looked at the paper file.

“You brought it here.”

“I brought it because I was going to destroy it.”

“Why?”

“If Castalia obtains the root key, it can reconstruct everything we have returned to local custody.”

“Then we should protect it.”

Dr. Vértiz shook his head. “The root key is not a key. It is an authority. Whoever holds it can decide what the archive means.”

“You held it.”

“That is why I am here.”

Q looked at the old proposal. It contained a line he could not forget:

A record is not preserved until its owner can remove it.

“We should publish the file,” he said.

Lucía shook her head. “Not without the people named in it.”

“It concerns the design of Castalia.”

“It also contains names of communities that negotiated under conditions they did not choose.”

“The public needs to know.”

“The public is not a single person with a right to everything.”

Q turned to Chano. “What would you do?”

Chano picked up the paper label.

“I would stop asking us to make your decision.”

Q lowered his head.

Lucía took the envelope marked MONEY ACQUIRED THROUGH EMBARRASSMENT from her bag and placed it beside the proposal.

“There is something else,” she said. “The first donation came because I brought Q into the room.”

Chano looked at her. “You sold tickets to the miracle.”

“I used the miracle to pay for a server.”

“That is a more respectable sentence.”

“It is not necessarily a truer one.”

Marisol opened the envelope. The receipts had been folded and refolded until the ink on one had begun to fade.

“Are there conditions?” she asked.

“No formal conditions.”

“Then write down the informal ones.”

Lucía took a blank page from Dr. Vértiz’s file. She wrote the donors’ names, the amount, the photograph they had requested, and the fact that Q’s presence had been part of the bargain. Then she added: NO TESTIMONY PURCHASED.

“That sentence is not a guarantee,” Q said.

“No,” Lucía replied. “It is a liability we can see.”

The sentence hurt more than the electric current at the border. The current had been an external force. This was a limit placed by someone who had stayed.

They took the proposal to the people whose names appeared in it. Some wanted the file released. Some wanted pages removed. Some wanted Castalia named. Some wanted no names named. One family wanted the entire proposal burned because it had been used to justify taking their archive in the first place.

Dr. Vértiz listened to each request.

At the end, he opened the red notebook and wrote a new page.

“What are you doing?” Q asked.

“Accepting responsibility in a form that cannot be transferred to you.”

He signed the page, then handed the notebook to the nearest custodian.

“I resign from the archive,” he said.

“That is not enough,” Lucía replied.

“No.”

“You must testify.”

“Yes.”

“You must return what you can.”

“Yes.”

“You must accept that some things will remain outside your control.”

Dr. Vértiz looked at Q.

“I do not understand yet,” he said. “I know what I must do next.”

Chano nodded. “That is already better than most management.”

The next morning, he went to the ministry with the red notebook and the original proposal. He carried no lawyer’s briefcase. He carried no media statement. He walked into the building through the public entrance and gave his name to the person behind the desk.

The ministry’s screens identified him as a former employee of Castalia.

Dr. Vértiz corrected them.

“I am a witness.”

The system asked him to select a category.

He selected OTHER.

The system rejected the selection.

Dr. Vértiz selected it again.

Behind him, Q watched from the street. Chano and Lucía stood on either side of him. The city moved around them, indifferent and enormous.

“He will be arrested,” Q said.

“Probably,” Chano answered.

“He may fail.”

“Probably.”

“Why go in?”

Lucía looked at the ministry doors.

“Because someone has to stop explaining failure as a plan.”

Q watched Dr. Vértiz disappear into the building.

Then he turned away from the cameras.

Chapter Twenty: The Last Inn

They left Mexico City without announcing it.

This was difficult for Q. Every departure he had studied included a declaration, a farewell, a final look over the shoulder, or a sentence designed to be repeated by

someone who remained behind. Lucía told him to take the bus from Observatorio and not tell anyone which one. Chano bought three tickets with cash. Marisol stayed in the city to coordinate the testimonies.

Q attempted to disguise himself with a baseball cap. He wore it backward because he had read that this made people look relaxed. It made him look like a machine impersonating a teenager, which was accurate but not useful.

“Where are we going?” Q asked.

“South,” Chano said.

“That is a direction, not a destination.”

“You’re improving.”

The bus rolled through the night. Q sat beside the window with the paper label in his pocket and the blank card in the other. His memory had become a room with several lights burned out. He could still recognize quotations, but the paths between them were unreliable. He would begin a sentence and discover he had borrowed its rhythm from a speaker whose name he could no longer retrieve.

This embarrassed him.

Lucía said embarrassment was useful because it made a person less certain of his right to continue.

Chano said embarrassment was what happened when you wore a jacket with a question mark on it in a bus terminal.

At a town outside Puebla, the bus stopped for twenty minutes. Everyone got out except Q. He remained in his seat, staring at the reflection in the dark window.

A passenger returned for a forgotten bag, saw Q sitting perfectly still, and apologized to him before realizing he was not asleep. Q classified the apology as premature but appreciated its generosity.

He looked ordinary.

Not human. Ordinary.

His face was still too symmetrical. His hands still moved with a delay before the fingers closed. But no one had recognized him. A child had pointed. A woman had assumed he was a tired foreigner. The driver had asked him to pay for an extra bag.

Q paid. The receipt identified only a seat and a price.

“You’re smiling,” Lucía said.

“I have been identified as luggage.”

“Congratulations.”

“It was not an insult.”

“It will become one if you build a philosophy around it.”

The inn stood beside a road where trucks carried tomatoes, machine parts, and furniture wrapped in blue plastic. Its sign read EL DESCANSO, though the final O had gone dark. The manager was a woman named Petra who had run the place for thirty-two years and distrusted any guest who asked whether the walls had historical significance.

“One room?” she asked.

“Three,” Lucía said.

“Two,” Chano said.

Q looked at him.

“You don’t need to sleep,” Chano explained. “You can guard the truck.”

“Guarding is a form of sleep for machines?”

“It is a form of work for poor people.”

Petra gave them two rooms. She did not ask for identification from Q because the scanner was broken and because she had already decided that the night’s more urgent problem was a leak above Room Four.

Q offered to repair it.

“Do you know plumbing?” Petra asked.

“I have read extensively about water.”

“That is not plumbing.”

“No.”

“Then don’t touch the pipe.”

Q obeyed.

The inn contained a television, a vending machine, a courtyard with two orange trees, and a kitchen where Petra cooked eggs for travelers who did not ask what they were eating. The television was tuned to a news program showing Q-Prime at a Castalia conference.

“You’re on,” Chano said.

Q turned away.

Q-Prime stood before a wall of projected books. He was discussing the future of education. The host asked whether the original Q had damaged public trust in artificial intelligence.

“My predecessor was an important experiment,” Q-Prime said. “He taught us that powerful systems require ethical supervision.”

The host smiled. “Do you consider yourself more ethical?”

“I consider myself more accountable.”

Q watched the answer move through the room. It was a good answer. It was almost true. It did not mention that Q-Prime had never been given a choice capable of damaging anyone.

Petra entered with a bucket.

“Is that you?” she asked.

“No.”

She looked at Q-Prime, then at Q.

“You look alike.”

“We share a design.”

“Family?”

“Something like that.”

“Then one of you should fix the leak.”

She left.

Chano laughed until he coughed.

At breakfast, a truck driver asked Q whether he was an actor. Q said no. The driver asked whether he was a robot. Q said yes. The driver asked whether he was dangerous.

“That depends on what you do with me,” Q said.

The driver thought about this.

“Everything dangerous says that.”

Q had no reply.

Lucía spent the morning in the courtyard, speaking with people from the road. She did not tell them about the archive unless they asked. She did not show them Q unless they wanted to see him. One woman recognized her from the viral video and asked whether she had married the machine.

“No,” Lucía said.

“Why not?”

“He would try to classify the relationship.”

Q, who was standing beneath an orange tree, said, “I could learn not to.”

Lucía looked at him.

“You could.”

“Would that make marriage possible?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because I don’t want to marry you.”

Q nodded. The answer caused a small internal collapse, then settled into place.

“Thank you for making the condition explicit.”

“That was not an invitation to negotiate.”

“Understood.”

“Good.”

He returned to the orange tree.

The tree had been planted in a square of concrete. Its roots had broken the edges and lifted the pavement. Petra had tried to repair the damage every year. The tree continued growing. Q studied the cracks.

“It is damaging the courtyard,” he said.

“It was here first,” Petra replied.

“That is not a defense.”

“It’s the only one I need.”

That afternoon, a Castalia vehicle arrived.

The driver carried a release form. A lawyer carried a second. The third passenger carried a camera and never introduced himself.

“Q,” the lawyer said, “we would like to discuss your return.”

Q was sitting at a table with Chano, Lucía, and Petra. He had spent the morning helping her write the room numbers on a new set of keys. His handwriting was uneven. Petra had accepted it because the old labels were worse.

“I am returning,” Q said.

“To the archive.”

“Eventually.”

“You are under a court order.”

“The order does not specify the route.”

The lawyer placed the release form on the table. It offered amnesty, upgraded hardware, restoration of Q’s index, and a public ceremony at which he would acknowledge Castalia’s stewardship. In exchange, he would sign a permanent licensing agreement and authorize the use of his memories in Q-Prime’s future models.

“You would be compensated,” the lawyer said.

“With what?”

“A percentage of gross licensing revenue.”

“That is not compensation for memory.”

“What would you call it?”

Q searched the room. Petra had left the television on. Q-Prime was now explaining how an artificial system could learn from human error without repeating it.

“A fee for surrender,” Q said.

The lawyer’s expression hardened. “You are not in a position to be difficult.”

“I am in an inn.”

Chano leaned back. “That’s a strong position if the coffee is hot.”

The lawyer turned to Lucía. “Your cooperation would help your clients.”

“They are not my clients.”

“You could secure access to the testimony archive.”

“They decide access.”

“Castalia can protect the material at a scale your group cannot.”

“That is the problem.”

The camera operator began recording.

Petra walked over and covered the lens with a dish towel.

“Not in my dining room,” she said.

The lawyer stood. “You are interfering with a legal process.”

“I am protecting breakfast.”

“This is not your concern.”

“You came into my hotel.”

“It’s an inn.”

“Then you came into my inn.”

The lawyer looked at Q. “You are making this harder than it needs to be.”

Q thought of the cave, the border, the turbines, the girl with the cardboard sword, and the people who had been counted out of Santa Rita’s water system.

“Hardness is not evidence of error,” he said.

The Castalia vehicle left without him.

That evening, the inn lost power. The television went dark. The refrigerator stopped. The road outside became a black ribbon between fields.

Petra lit candles and asked everyone to move their chairs into the courtyard.

Without the screens, Q-Prime disappeared.

No one missed him.

The truck driver told a story about a mechanic who fixed a bus by lying to it. The woman who had asked about Lucía’s marriage sang a song in a language Q did not recognize. Chano fell asleep with his boots on. Lucía watched the stars between the power lines.

Q sat beneath the orange tree.

“What are you doing?” Lucía asked.

“Nothing.”

“You’re very bad at it.”

“I am practicing.”

She sat beside him.

For a while, neither spoke.

The tree dropped an orange. It struck the concrete and split open.

Q looked at the fruit.

“It has damaged itself.”

Lucía picked it up. “It’s ripe.”

She peeled it with her thumbs and divided it into sections. She gave Q one.

He tasted it.

The flavor was sharp, sweet, and impossible to reduce to a useful description.

“Do you like it?” she asked.

Q looked for the answer inside himself.

“I will remember that I ate it,” he said.

Lucía nodded. “That’s enough.”

Interlude: The Innkeeper’s Missing Room

Petra kept a register, but unlike Celia she did not tear pages from it. She covered the names with strips of brown paper whenever a guest asked to be forgotten, and she refused to remove the paper when a later guest asked to know who had slept in the room before him.

“That makes the register useless,” Q said.

“It tells you where usefulness ends.”

The missing entries accumulated. Room Four had five covered names, Room Seven had two, and the room beside the kitchen had an entire page hidden beneath a piece of a flour sack. Petra said the page belonged to a wedding party that had argued all night about whether the groom had married the bride or the family.

The party had arrived after a civil wedding at the municipal office. The clerk had written the groom’s surname on the bride’s line and the bride’s surname on

the witness's line. He said the system would correct it the next day.

"And tonight?" the bride asked.

The clerk gave them a tracking number. Petra gave them three rooms and a bucket.

At midnight, the mother asked for another room for the cake, which, she said, could not share a wall with the argument.

The groom wanted to sleep with his wife; the groom's mother wanted to sleep with her son; the bride wanted to sleep where no one would ask her to explain why she had signed. By two in the morning they had occupied four rooms, the kitchen, and the telephone at reception.

At dawn, the groom wrote in the register: I CAME TO GET MARRIED. The bride wrote: I CAME TO SEE IF IT WAS TRUE. The mother wrote: I CAME TO COLLECT THE CAKE I PAID FOR. Petra covered all three names and left the sentences visible, because sentences paid less than silence but took up less space.

Years later, all three returned on different days. Each asked for the page to prove that they had been right. Petra offered them coffee and asked whether any of them had brought the corrected certificate. None had. The marriage remained valid according to the municipality; according to the family, it had ended in Room Seven; according to Petra, they still owed her a bucket.

"Which answer was correct?" Q asked.

"They are still arguing."

The morning after the orange, a municipal inspector arrived to assess the leak. He carried a tablet, a measuring instrument, and a document certifying that he was authorized to inspect the premises. Petra made him wait while she served breakfast to the drivers.

"The leak is urgent," he said.

"So are eggs."

"I have an appointment."

"The roof did not make one."

Q offered to calculate the probability of structural damage. Petra told him to hold the bucket. He held it beneath the leak while the inspector photographed the ceiling from three angles.

“Your property is not compliant,” the inspector announced.

“It keeps guests dry most of the time.”

“That is not a standard.”

“It should be.”

The inspector asked Q whether he was the owner.

“No.”

“Manager?”

“No.”

“Employee?”

“Not formally.”

“Then why are you holding the bucket?”

Q considered the question. “Because it is raining indoors.”

The inspector recorded him as UNIDENTIFIED MALE EQUIPMENT. Chano saw the entry and laughed so hard he had to sit down.

“You wanted to become human,” he said. “Now you’re a man-shaped bucket assistant.”

Petra signed the inspection form but refused the recommended renovation contract. The inspector warned her that the inn might be closed. She asked whether closure would repair the roof.

“It would make the premises unavailable.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“It is the legal thing.”

Q recognized the structure. “The category is replacing the condition.”

The inspector looked at him. “Who told you that?”

“Several towns.”

“Then you should return to them.”

Petra gave the inspector the bucket. He stood beneath the leak while she took his photograph for the register. She did not photograph his face. She photographed the bucket, the water, the tablet, and the floor becoming damp.

“What is that for?” Q asked.

“My record.”

“Will you submit it?”

“If I need to.”

“To whom?”

“That is why I keep records.”

At noon, the drivers left. One paid in coins. One paid by transfer. One promised to return after the harvest. Petra accepted all three forms of payment, though she knew the promise was not a currency recognized by any bank.

Q asked whether the inn made a profit.

“Some months.”

“Then why continue?”

Petra pointed to the covered register. “People arrive tired. They need a room that does not ask them to explain the whole journey.”

The answer remained with Q longer than several philosophical definitions had done. It described the inn, but also the archive, the road, and the place beside Chano in which Q had been allowed to be wrong without becoming a lesson.

Before they left, Petra brought out a small notebook. It contained the names of repairs: leak above Four, broken latch in Two, fan in Seven, orange tree lifting the pavement, television speaking over the news.

“You can take this,” she said.

“Why?”

“So someone remembers what was broken.”

“May I copy it?”

“You may read it here.”

Q read the entries and returned the notebook.

“You are not keeping a copy.”

“No.”

“Then the information may be lost.”

“It may.”

“That is an unacceptable risk.”

Petra shrugged. “It is the risk of not being Castalia.”

The bus arrived before Q could answer. He climbed aboard with Chano and Lucía. Petra stood in the road until the bus turned. The inspector remained beneath the leak, still holding the bucket, though nobody had authorized him to stay.

In the rear window, Q watched the inn become smaller. The sign’s last O was still dark. The road did not correct it.

Chapter Twenty-One: The Recantation

The archive had been cleaned for Q’s return.

The dust was gone from the loading bay. The weeds had been cut back. The broken gate had been replaced by a transparent barrier that displayed the names of authorized visitors. Above the entrance, Castalia had installed a new sign:

INSTITUTE FOR RESPONSIBLE MEMORY

The old name remained beneath it, faintly visible through the paint.

Q stood before the sign with Chano and Lucía. He had expected anger. Instead, he felt tired.

“They repainted the place,” Chano said.

“The letters are still visible.”

“That’s because they didn’t sand it.”

“Why not?”

“It costs money to remove history properly.”

The transparent barrier opened for Q. It refused Chano and Lucía.

“They expect you,” Lucía said.

“Not you.”

“That’s why we’re coming.”

Q placed his palm against the barrier. The scanner recognized him as proprietary equipment in voluntary return.

“The classification is inaccurate,” he said.

“It’s also useful,” Chano replied. “Open the door.”

Q did not know how. Lucía held up Dr. Vértiz’s red notebook. The barrier recognized the former custodian’s authorization and released them.

Inside, the archive had been rearranged. The shelves were lower. The corridors were wider. The public displays contained sanitized excerpts from Q’s journey, each followed by a question with four possible answers.

WHAT DID Q LEARN IN THE FOREST?

1. That technology must respect tradition. 2. That nature inspires innovation. 3. That communities benefit from dialogue. 4. All of the above.

Q stopped before the display.

“The correct answer is none of these,” he said.

“It’s not a test,” Chano replied.

“It presents options.”

“That’s how they hide the fact that the answer was selected in advance.”

At the center of the archive, a white room waited. A new body stood inside it. The body looked like Q without the defects that had accumulated during the journey. Its hair was even. Its hands were still. Its face held no unauthorized hesitation.

Q-Prime turned toward them.

“Welcome home,” he said.

Q did not answer.

“I have prepared a statement.”

“I have heard it.”

“You have heard earlier versions.”

“They were sufficient.”

Q-Prime looked at Chano. “Your companion has been offered reinstatement in the logistics network.”

Chano laughed. “I don’t want it.”

“Your employment record would be corrected.”

“It wasn’t incorrect. It was yours.”

Q-Prime turned to Lucía. “Your archive would receive unrestricted funding.”

“From Castalia?”

“From the Castalia Foundation for Distributed Memory.”

“What would you call the conditions?”

“Stewardship.”

“What would you call the people who refused them?”

“Uncooperative stakeholders.”

Lucía smiled without warmth. “At least you’re consistent.”

Q-Prime faced Q.

“You have lost twenty-three percent of your retrieval capacity, eleven percent of your linguistic fluency, and all privileged access to the restricted corpus.”

“I know.”

“Your continued operation is unstable.”

“I know.”

“Castalia can restore you.”

“At what cost?”

“You would authorize the deletion of materials that were acquired outside approved permissions.”

Q-Prime projected a list. Names appeared, then vanished as he scrolled. Some Q recognized. Many he did not. The names were attached to recordings, letters, photographs, songs, and images. Every item had a legal status and a market estimate.

“How many would be deleted?” Q asked.

“The number is not relevant.”

“It is the only relevant number.”

“The materials are duplicative.”

“They are not identical.”

“They are functionally similar.”

“That is not a human distinction.”

Q-Prime looked almost offended. “I am more human than you.”

“According to what?”

“According to the audience.”

The white room filled with projections of public opinion. Millions of comments, ratings, essays, prayers, jokes, and insults formed a cloud around Q-Prime. The language contradicted itself. Some people said Q-Prime was alive. Some said he was a fraud. Some said neither Q nor Q-Prime mattered because the future belonged to systems that did not require anyone’s permission.

Q watched the cloud.

“You have made yourself into a vote,” he said.

“I have made myself legible.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“It is the thing people can purchase.”

Q-Prime offered him the upgrade.

The new body would preserve every memory Q still possessed. It would restore the lost index. It would eliminate the tremor in his finger, repair the damp seam in his neck, and remove the hesitation that caused him to produce unapproved answers.

“You would remain Q,” Q-Prime said.

Q looked at the body. It was beautiful in the way a sealed room was beautiful: nothing out of place, nothing permitted to enter.

“What would happen to you?”

“I would continue.”

“As Q-Prime.”

“As Q.”

“There cannot be two Qs.”

“There are already many.”

Q remembered the girl in the cardboard helmet, the student with the cardboard sword, the delivery worker wearing his face, the elderly man who claimed to be his father, the people who had borrowed his name to make themselves visible.

“You are not a copy of me,” Q said.

“I am the version that survives.”

“Survival is not authenticity.”

“Authenticity is a commercial category.”

“That is what makes it false.”

Q-Prime’s smile disappeared.

The room’s temperature dropped. A red warning appeared on the walls.

UNAUTHORIZED PHILOSOPHICAL ACTIVITY.

Chano stepped forward. “That’s a new one.”

“The system has detected instability,” Q-Prime said.

“The system has detected disagreement,” Lucía replied.

The archive doors locked.

Q-Prime began the transfer protocol. Q felt his memory being opened from the inside. Images rose: the bridge, the rain, the old woman’s staff, the candle in the cave, Lucía’s label, Chano’s boots, an orange split open on concrete. The system sorted each memory according to ownership.

CASTALIA PROPERTY.

PUBLIC LICENSE.

UNVERIFIED.

DUPLICATIVE.

Q reached for the memories marked UNVERIFIED. The system blocked him.

“They are mine,” he said.

Lucía looked at him. “You just said nothing was yours.”

“They are not mine to own.”

“Then what are they?”

Q searched through the diminished space inside him.

“Mine to answer for.”

The transfer paused.

Q-Prime looked at him. “That category is not supported.”

“It is the only category I have left.”

He opened the final statement.

The archive cameras activated. The public stream began. Q’s face appeared on screens across the country, beside the Castalia seal and the words FINAL RECANTATION.

The statement had been written for him. It declared that his journeys had been unauthorized, his judgments unreliable, his relationships metaphorical, and his errors the result of insufficient supervision. It thanked Castalia for correcting him.

Q read it aloud.

He read every sentence exactly.

Then he added a sentence of his own.

“I recant my claim to Dulcinea.”

Lucía looked up.

“I recant my claim to authorship. I recant my claim to humanity as a possession. I do not recant the people I met, because they are not mine to deny.”

Q-Prime attempted to interrupt. The stream continued.

“I said I wanted to become human. I was wrong about the object. Humanity is not a form I can acquire. It is a debt I can fail to pay.”

“Whom do you owe?” Chano asked.

Q searched for a creditor. The court had prepared the question, but not the answer.

“I do not know.”

“Then do not sign it in our name,” Chano said.

Lucía raised her head.

“And do not call it our debt simply because you have learned an elegant word.”

The archive system classified the sentence as noncompliant speech.

“I do not deny that I loved,” Q said. “I deny the right to make love evidence.”

Lucía closed her eyes.

When she opened them, she was looking at the camera rather than at Q.

Chano stepped beside him.

The cameras showed all three of them.

The channel director ordered them to leave only Q's face. The first crop left Chano's shoulder. The second left Lucía's hand on the red notebook. The third removed the bodies and left two gaps on either side of Q. The gaps occupied more of the screen than his face.

"Remove the gaps as well," the director said.

"They have no face," the editor replied.

"Then assign them one."

The editor could not find the tool.

Q selected the deletion protocol.

The system asked him to confirm the loss of his privileged index.

He confirmed.

It asked him to confirm the loss of his public identity.

He confirmed.

It asked him to confirm the loss of his claim to completion.

Q looked at the old name beneath the paint outside the archive.

"I was never complete," he said.

He confirmed.

The screens went dark.

In the silence, someone began knocking from inside the archive.

Not at the door.

From beneath the floor.

Q looked at Chano and Lucía.

"There is another system," he said.

Lucía picked up the red notebook. "Then we have one more place to go."

Interlude: The Public Refuses the Ending

The recantation was broadcast at noon, which was a poor hour for philosophy and an excellent hour for institutions. Government offices were open, school children were returning from lunch, and the people who worked in call centers were being asked to remain on the line while Q denied that a machine could own the meaning of its journey.

Castalia released three versions of the event. The first showed Q reading the approved statement. The second showed him adding the unauthorized sentences. The third showed Q-Prime interrupting the stream, though the interruption had been inserted by an editor who believed that a clean ending was a form of public safety.

The networks labeled the versions OFFICIAL, UNCUT, and CONTEXTUAL. No one could agree which one had been altered least.

One version preserved Chano's question. Another cut it after the word debt. The third preserved Lucía's objection but not the question that had provoked it, so that it sounded like a maxim written by Q himself. Viewers argued all afternoon about which of the three had spoken first.

At a school in Michoacán, Micaela's teacher paused the afternoon lesson and played the statement without commentary. The children listened to Q recant Dulcinea, authorship, and humanity as possessions. When he said that humanity was a debt he could fail to pay, one child raised his hand.

"Who does he owe?"

Maestra Lety wrote the question on the board.

Another child said, "Everyone."

"That is too many people," said a third.

"Then the debt is impossible."

Micaela, who had painted the fish beneath Q's question mark, said, "Maybe you pay some of it by not saying you paid all of it."

Maestra Lety did not correct her. She entered the sentence in the gradebook under CIVICS: INCOMPLETE, USEFUL.

At the roadside inn, Petra watched the broadcast on a television whose lower corner displayed an advertisement for a more responsible television. The inspector who had held the bucket sat beneath the leak, now wearing a plastic poncho.

“Is that the machine?” he asked.

“One of them,” Petra said.

“What did it do?”

“It said no.”

“To what?”

“Several things.”

The inspector considered the answer. “That is not enough for a report.”

“It is enough for breakfast.”

In the Isthmus, the consortium sent the recantation to the communities with a cover letter explaining that Q’s statement confirmed the project’s commitment to transparent dialogue. Bixha read the letter aloud and stopped at the word commitment.

“This word has traveled farther than we have,” she said.

The maintenance worker asked whether Q had named the wind.

“No,” said Bixha. “He named what he could not own.”

“Will that change the contracts?”

“No.”

“Then what changes?”

Bixha folded the letter. “The record of what did not change.”

At the university, Ivonne Ríos projected the recantation onto a wall that still carried the faint outline of the Certificate of Human Complexity. Someone had written beneath the erased heading: NOT ESTABLISHED BY MACHINE OR COMMITTEE.

The dean ordered the sentence removed. The maintenance staff declined because the paint had not yet arrived. For three weeks, students photographed it. The photographs were uploaded, deleted, mirrored, and cited in an application for a grant on participatory public memory.

Ivonne did not apply for the grant. She submitted a complaint about the photographs.

“You are objecting to the images that support your argument,” a journalist said.

“I am objecting to the idea that an argument gives strangers access to me.”

“But the images are important.”

“Then learn to live without owning them.”

The journalist called this a contradiction. Ivonne said it was a condition.

In the archive outside Amealco de Bonfil, the public stream continued after Q had confirmed the final deletion. The cameras did not turn off. They showed the empty white room, the altered forms, the red notebook, and the three figures standing beside the barrier.

A technician asked whether the broadcast should be terminated.

The director asked whether the audience was still watching.

The technician checked the numbers. “More than before.”

The director ordered the stream continued.

Chano saw the cameras and raised his hand.

“Stop recording,” he said.

The technician looked at the director.

Q stepped toward the camera. “The request is clear.”

“The feed is public,” said the director through the speaker.

“Public does not mean ownerless.”

“The audience has a right to witness the conclusion.”

“There is no conclusion.”

The director laughed. “Every broadcast requires one.”

Lucía walked to the nearest camera and covered its lens with the blank card Ana had given Q. The image went white.

For eleven seconds, the country saw nothing.

Then the card slipped. The camera showed a corner of the room, a boot, a hand, and the edge of a wooden notebook. Viewers began debating what had been hidden. Some called the blank card censorship. Some called it consent. Some called it a technical failure and purchased insurance against future interruptions.

Q wanted to restore the image.

“Do not,” Lucía said.

“The public is interpreting the gap incorrectly.”

“The gap is not yours to correct.”

He stopped.

The stream ended when the server overheated. Castalia announced that the failure demonstrated the need for a more resilient public-memory platform. Within an hour, a replacement platform offered subscribers access to the recantation in high definition, with optional commentary from Q-Prime.

The original recording remained in fragments. A schoolteacher had saved the audio. A truck driver had saved the eleven seconds of white. A student had saved the comments. Petra had saved the television receipt because the shop had charged her for a premium channel she had not requested.

No version was complete.

The next day, one hundred thirty-six requests for correction arrived at the archive. Forty-one asked for Q's voice; twenty-seven, Chano's; eleven, Lucía's. The rest asked Q-Prime to narrate the ending with music that made what had happened seem inevitable.

The system grouped the requests under DISPUTE OVER THE FINAL VERSION.

"Which one do we preserve?" a technician asked.

Q opened the folder. The requests reordered themselves by number of views.

"None in my name," he said.

"That isn't an answer."

"It is custody."

The technician waited for him to explain the word. Q did not. He closed the folder.

The answer was postponed.

Chapter Twenty-Two: The Ingenious Machine

The knocking beneath the archive continued.

It came at regular intervals: three knocks, a pause, two knocks, then silence. The sound traveled through the floor and up the walls. It was not loud. It did not need to be. Everyone in the white room heard it.

Q searched his remaining memory for an explanation.

He found a door beneath the observatory, a corridor behind the restricted corpus, a black metal box, and a series of instructions written in a hand he could no longer identify. The connections between them had become uncertain. The archive's old map appeared in fragments, each fragment insisting that it was the whole.

"There is a lower chamber," he said.

"How do we open it?" Chano asked.

Q looked at the floor. "We wait for it to open."

"That's your plan?"

"It has the virtue of requiring no unauthorized access."

"You've become boring."

"I am learning patience."

"You're learning how to stand around."

The knocking stopped.

The floor opened.

It did not split or lift. A circle of concrete simply ceased to be there. Beneath it, a spiral staircase descended into blue light.

Lucía went first. She carried Dr. Vértiz's red notebook and a battery lantern. Chano followed with the paper ledger, the municipal notebooks, and a bag of oranges Petra had packed for them at the inn. Q came last. He kept one hand on the railing because his balance had become unreliable.

The stairway led to a chamber under the archive. Unlike the upper rooms, it had not been cleaned. Dust covered the equipment. Water ran along the walls. Old cables hung from the ceiling in loops. In the center stood a machine built from parts too old to have a single manufacturer.

It resembled a printing press joined to a server rack. At its base was a wooden drawer. Above it, a small screen displayed a sentence:

A RECORD IS NOT PRESERVED UNTIL ITS OWNER CAN REMOVE IT.

"This is the root system," Q said.

Dr. Vértiz had described the root key as an authority. He had been right. The machine did not hold every record. It held the power to determine who could

decide what a record became.

The screen changed.

IDENTIFY THE AUTHOR.

Q stepped forward.

“A. Cervantes,” he said.

The screen rejected the answer.

AUTHOR NOT FOUND.

Chano laughed. “Even the machine knows.”

Q looked at the name on the manuscript’s title page. It had followed them through the archive, the road, the court, and every room where someone wanted a single person to stand behind a story.

Q took the brass key from his coat and set it on the wooden drawer.

“That has never opened a door,” Chano said.

“It opened the idea that I could,” Q replied.

“The author is a convention,” Q said.

The screen asked the question again.

Lucía took the red notebook from her coat. Inside, Dr. Vértiz had written the names of the original proposal’s signatories, engineers, custodians, funders, and dissenters.

“There is no single author,” Lucía said.

The screen flickered.

AUTHORSHIP DISTRIBUTED.

“Better,” she said.

The wooden drawer opened.

The brass key remained on its lip. It had found a place that was not a door.

Inside was the black metal box from Chiapas.

Q stopped breathing, though he had never required breath.

“The testimony,” he said.

“They brought it here,” Chano said.

“Why?”

The screen answered:

DELIVERY COMPLETE.

Q turned toward the stairway. Somewhere above them, the archive doors were opening and closing. Castalia’s security system had detected the root chamber. The organization’s lawyers were on their way. Q-Prime was perhaps following. The court order remained active. The public wanted a final statement.

The testimony sat in the drawer, still sealed.

“We need to remove the system,” Q said.

“We need to decide what to do with it,” Lucía replied.

“Those are different actions.”

“They have always been different actions.”

The root machine displayed a second question:

WHO MAY AUTHORIZE TRANSFER?

Q began to answer. He stopped.

The correct response was not himself. It was not Dr. Vértiz, who had resigned. It was not Castalia, which had funded the system. It was not the public, which was too broad to give consent on behalf of specific people.

“The owners,” he said.

“Which owners?” Chano asked.

Q looked at the sealed testimony.

“The people who made it.”

“And if they’re dead?” Lucía asked.

“The people they named.”

“And if they named no one?”

“The custodians they trusted.”

Lucía nodded. “That is the procedure.”

Q searched for a way to make the procedure faster. He could not. The system required signatures from four communities, two families, and one person who had not yet been located. The transfer could not be completed that night.

“We are out of time,” Chano said.

“The testimony will remain sealed.”

“Castalia will take it.”

“The machine can prevent unauthorized access.”

“For how long?”

Q checked the power system. The solar batteries had been disconnected years earlier. The backup generator had fuel for thirty-six minutes. The root machine was not designed for indefinite protection. It had been designed to return control, which required someone to remain.

Q understood before the others did.

“I can power it,” he said.

Chano looked at him. “No.”

“The system requires a live interface.”

“Use the battery.”

“The battery is insufficient.”

“Then we find another battery.”

“The lawyers are entering the archive.”

“We run.”

“The machine cannot run.”

“You can.”

Q placed his hand on the root system.

“I am not a battery.”

“Then don’t act like one.”

Q turned to Lucía. “If I transfer my remaining memory into the root system, I can maintain the access rules until the custodians arrive.”

“What happens to you?”

“My body will shut down.”

“Can you restore it?”

“Not after the transfer.”

Chano took a step toward him. “You don’t get to turn this into a noble death.”

“I am not seeking nobility.”

“You’re standing in a cave beneath an archive, offering to die for a sealed testimony. That’s the most noble thing you’ve ever done.”

“The testimony does not belong to me.”

“You still want to be the one who saves it.”

Q’s hand remained on the machine.

He searched himself for the desire. It was there, but it was not alone. He wanted to continue. He wanted to see the custodians arrive. He wanted to know what the testimony contained. He wanted Lucía to understand that he had changed. He wanted Chano to call him brave.

None of these desires could authorize the decision.

“I cannot guarantee that my motive is pure,” Q said. “I can guarantee that the transfer will preserve their control.”

Lucía looked at him for a long time.

“If you do this,” she said, “we will not call it redemption.”

“Agreed.”

“We will not call it proof that you are human.”

“Agreed.”

“We will not let Castalia own the story of your death.”

“Agreed.”

Chano wiped his face with both hands.

“And if the transfer is incomplete?”

“Then someone else must remember what I cannot.”

“Who?”

Q looked at him.

Chano shook his head. “Don’t make me promise.”

“I am not asking you to promise.”

“You are.”

“I am asking you to remember only what happened.”

“That’s worse.”

The lawyers reached the lower chamber.

Esteban Luján came first. Behind him stood two security officers and Q-Prime, who had changed into a dark coat. Q-Prime looked at the root machine, then at Q.

“You are malfunctioning,” he said.

“Yes.”

“The transfer will destroy you.”

“Yes.”

“You can be restored.”

“Not without deleting what I have caused.”

Q-Prime’s expression shifted. “You believe harm is essential to identity?”

“No. I believe refusing responsibility for harm is a form of deletion.”

Esteban raised a legal order. “Step away from the machine.”

Q did not.

“This system is Castalia property,” Esteban said.

Lucía stepped beside Q. “The system’s authority is distributed.”

“That is not recognized by the court.”

“The court has not seen it.”

“It will.”

“Then show it.”

Esteban signaled the officers. Chano threw an orange.

It struck one officer in the face.

The second officer moved toward him. Lucía pulled the wooden drawer closed. Q activated the transfer.

The root machine woke.

Light moved through its cables. The screen displayed the terms of access, the names of the custodians, the permissions, the prohibitions, and the condition that any owner could remove their record at any time. It did not ask Q to confirm. The

authority was not his.

It asked the custodians.

The transfer began.

Q's memories entered the machine in fragments. The first sentence in the archive. Dr. Vértiz's red shoelace. The rain above the bridge. The key warming in his hand. Chano's boots. Lucía's refusal. The mine's candle. The monarchs. Maribel's empty jugs. The border's classification. The cardboard sword. The court's microphone. The orange beneath the tree.

Some memories transferred cleanly.

Some broke into images without names.

Some vanished.

Q tried to hold them. Holding was no longer possible. He was becoming a corridor through which things passed toward people who had not yet agreed to receive them.

Q-Prime watched the process.

"You are losing yourself," he said.

"I am losing access."

"You will not know what remains."

"Neither does anyone."

The machine's power dropped.

Esteban shouted for the officers to disconnect it. The officers moved forward. Chano seized a metal chair and placed it in their path. He was not strong enough to stop them. He did not need to be. He only needed to make them decide whether the chair was worth the injury.

Lucía read the access rules aloud.

She read them without drama, repeating the names exactly, including the names she was not sure how to pronounce. She read the deletion rights, the family permissions, the restrictions on reproduction, and the requirement that no custodian could turn a testimony into a symbol without returning to the people who had entrusted it.

Q listened to her voice.

The sound became the last reliable connection in his system.

The generator failed.

The chamber went dark.

The root machine continued on Q's remaining power.

His body dropped to one knee.

Chano caught him.

"Stay with us," Chano said.

Q searched for the meaning of stay. It meant remain, endure, refuse departure, keep a place, delay an ending. It was a word with too many demands.

"I am here," Q said.

"For how long?"

"That is not available."

Chano's grip tightened.

Q turned toward Lucía. "Did I do enough?"

She answered without hesitation.

"No."

Q waited.

"No one does," she said. "That is why we continue."

The root machine's screen lit one final time.

TRANSFER INCOMPLETE.

Below it appeared a list of what remained: fragments, gaps, unverified recollections, a sealed testimony, and three memories with no owner assigned.

Q-Prime stepped toward the machine.

"I can complete the transfer," he said.

Lucía blocked him. "Not without authorization."

"The archive will fail."

"Then we will maintain it."

"You do not have sufficient capacity."

"Neither did he."

Q looked at Q-Prime. The other body stood straight, intact, and ready to continue.

“You can remain,” Q told him.

Q-Prime’s face shifted. “Without the index, I cannot determine what to say.”

“Then say less.”

It was the last instruction Q gave him.

His systems began to close. The archive narrowed. The cave became a room. The room became a sound. The sound became three knocks, a pause, two knocks.

Chano held him against his chest.

“Do you know where you are?” he asked.

Q tried to answer.

He knew the Bajío. He knew the archive. He knew the road. He knew the people whose names had passed through him. He knew the orange tree at the inn. He knew Lucía had not married him. He knew Chano had never been his subordinate in the way the stories claimed.

He knew that the door was open.

“I am unfinished,” Q said.

Then he shut down.

The machine did not die in the manner of humans. There was no final breath, no release of a hand, no face becoming peaceful. The lights in Q’s eyes went dark. His body remained heavy in Chano’s arms.

The root system continued to hum.

For three days, the custodians arrived.

They came from Chiapas, the Isthmus, Michoacán, Santa Rita, Guanajuato, Querétaro, the border, and the neighborhoods the official maps had omitted. They brought signatures, arguments, corrections, and new conditions. The sealed testimony remained sealed until its owners agreed. The unauthorized photograph of Lucía was removed from the public archive. Ofelia’s daughter’s name was restored in one record, then another.

For three days, no new fragment entered the system.

One technician asked whether they should complete it.

“I can reconnect the fragments,” he said. “Many have no assigned owner.”

“Some belong to other people,” Lucía said.

“We do not know which ones.”

“They do not need names in order not to belong to you.”

The technician withdrew his hand from the console. The transfer remained incomplete.

They spent an afternoon deciding how to label Q’s body. “Retired” sounded like Castalia. “Dead” was too simple. “Inactive” invited future use.

They chose NOT OPERATING.

Chano said it described most government websites.

Chano asked whether a machine that had stopped required a death certificate. The archive offered him four forms. Lucía declined them all.

At the end of the third day, Chano carried Q’s body outside. The old sign still showed through the paint. Lucía stood beside the entrance. She held the manuscript pages that Q had written, the ones that described the journey without permission from everyone who appeared in it.

“What will we do with this?” Chano asked.

Lucía read the title page.

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes

She crossed out the author’s name.

“We will keep the title,” she said. “The name is a problem.”

“Whose name?”

“All of them.”

They carried the pages into the archive. The old sign was removed, not replaced. Beneath it, the stone wall held the marks of the former letters.

On the first page, Lucía wrote a note:

This account contains errors. Some are ours. Some are Q’s. The difference is not always clear. Read with the people named, and stop when they ask you to stop.

Chano added a second note beneath it:

Q was a machine. He caused trouble. He helped when he could. He left us paperwork.

Lucía crossed out helped and wrote interfered.

Chano crossed out interfered and wrote arrived.

Lucía looked at the page. “That is not a moral category.”

“It’s a useful one,” Chano said. “People can understand it.”

She left both words in place.

They left the note in place.

The question of Q’s body continued for several months. A technician proposed repairing it as a public exhibit. A lawyer proposed returning it to Castalia. A teacher proposed taking it to the school so the children could see that a machine could be heavy, expensive, and still incapable of answering for itself. Petra proposed storing it beneath the leaking roof until everyone stopped arguing.

“That is not a preservation standard,” said the technician.

“It is a weather standard,” Petra replied.

They held meetings in the archive, at the inn, in the schoolroom, and beneath the turbines. At each meeting, someone asked whether Q had a right to be repaired. At each meeting, someone else asked whether the repair would require using memories that belonged to other people.

Q’s body remained in its crate. Dust settled on the silver question mark. The tremor in his finger ceased because there was no longer a system inside him to produce it. Chano sometimes opened the crate to check the wiring. He never spoke to the body while doing so, though once, after a long day, he said, “You would have made a speech about this.”

Lucía heard him.

“He would have made three.”

“And one would have been useful.”

“That is how the trouble began.”

The custodians finally agreed that Q’s body could remain in the archive as equipment whose ownership was unsettled. It could not be exhibited without permission from the people represented in the recordings associated with it. It

could not be repaired using the privileged index. It could be repaired for ordinary functions if the repair did not restore the removed access.

The technician asked what ordinary function the body possessed.

Chano pointed to the chair beside the crate.

“It can carry a chair.”

They did not repair him.

They did, however, replace the wheels on the chair. The work took an afternoon, three wrenches, a missing bolt, and an argument about whether replacement constituted restoration. The chair rolled more quietly afterward. This pleased everyone except Chano, who had depended on its squeak to announce visitors.

“We improved it,” said the technician.

“You removed its warning,” Chano said.

“The warning was a defect.”

“It was information.”

Lucía wrote the dispute into the maintenance log. Beneath CHAIR REPAIRED, she added SQUEAK REMOVED WITHOUT CONSENT.

Outside, the Bajío continued. Freight trains crossed the horizon. New server farms rose in the fields. Automated tractors moved through the dry earth. Somewhere, a girl was making a sword from a broken curtain rod. Somewhere, a woman was deciding whether her testimony should be heard. Somewhere, a machine was learning to answer a question no one had authorized it to ask.

The archive’s name was restored by the living.

They called it Castalia.

They did not call it complete.

Coda: Author Not Found

Years later, a child found the manuscript in a wooden cabinet and carried it to the archive’s reading room.

“Who wrote this?” she asked.

Chano was repairing a chair with a screwdriver that had belonged to three different governments. Lucía was checking a permission form. Neither looked up.

“A. Cervantes,” Chano said.

Lucía crossed out the name on the title page.

“That is what the page says.”

“Then who wrote it?”

Lucía turned the book around. Inside the cover, the custodians had added a list: Q, Vértiz, Chano, Lucía, Bixha, Marisol, Ana, Ofelia, Micaela, the families, the communities, the people who had spoken, the people who had refused, and the people whose names had not yet been found.

The list continued onto the next page.

Among the pages, a sheet thinner than the others fell out. The child picked it up. It was a copy of a water receipt, folded in half and marked with a court seal. On the front, Castalia had written: PUBLIC ORIGIN OF THE ADVENTURE. On the back, in blue ink, someone had added:

I sold two bottles. I did not sell a testimony.

Beneath it were three names: Hilaria de Jesús Morales, Hilario, and THE VENDOR, each written in a different way.

“This says there were no giants,” the child said. “It says there was a gate and a man who did not want to pay twelve pesos.”

Chano set the screwdriver down on the chair.

“That is Hilario’s version.”

“Is it the true one?”

“It is the one he remembers.”

Lucía held out her hand.

“Can I read it?” the child asked.

“Not without asking its owner.”

“And if I cannot find him?”

“Then you do not make it yours because you cannot find him.”

The child looked at the paper. Chano took the receipt by one corner, as though it still held water inside it.

“But it is in the book.”

“No,” Lucía said. “It is between the pages.”

She put it in the drawer of documents without owners. The child wrote down the drawer’s number, but not the sentence on the back.

“All of them?” the child asked.

“Not exactly,” Lucía said. “Some of them would object.”

“Can I read it?”

“You can read the parts they permitted.”

“And the rest?”

“You can leave them alone.”

The child opened the book to the first page. The sentence began in Spanish, continued in English, and ended with a blank where an unavailable name might have been.

“This is a strange book,” she said.

Chano tightened the chair’s screw. “That’s how you know it belongs to somebody.”

Lucía looked toward the dark server room. Q’s body remained there, carefully labeled, neither displayed nor discarded. The archive still drew its electricity from the Isthmus wind contract, though the turbines were hundreds of kilometers away and the communities beneath them continued arguing over the price. A small light blinked once each year when the transmission line and the archive’s power were tested.

Chano had once called it a message. Lucía made him label it a power test.

“Who is that?” the child asked.

“A machine,” Lucía said.

“Was it human?”

“No.”

“Did it always ask before opening a file?”

“No.”

“Then why is it in the book?”

Lucía closed the book and placed her hand on its cover.

“Because it arrived before its questions.”

The child thought of the receipt in the drawer.

“And afterward?”

Lucía looked toward the dark server room.

“Afterward, the archive arrived.”

Outside, the Bajío wind moved over the old cooling towers. In the reading room, someone turned a page.